Technically, It's a Love Story

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/73974501.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail), Tribbie (Honkai: Star Rail), Trianne (Honkai: Star Rail), Trinnon (Honkai: Star Rail), Hysilens (Honkai: Star Rail), Hephaestion (Honkai: Star Rail), Perdikkas (Honkai: Star Rail), Leonnius (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Temporary Amnesia, Phainon is Down Bad (Honkai: Star Rail), Slow Burn, Enemies to Lovers, Kind Of, Gaslighting, Alternative Universe - Sci Fi, Possessive Behavior, Mydei is Bad at Feelings (Honkai: Star Rail), Memory Loss, Comedy, in some parts, Alien Biology, Implied/Referenced Character Death, not Mydei/Phainon though

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2025-11-10 Words: 55,891 Chapters: 1/1

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by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon accidentally falls for an amnesiac war criminal, half-kidnaps him, teaches him how to love, and somehow sets off a future galactic incident.

He just wanted to keep him alive, maybe teach him how to make toast, definitely not trigger an interplanetary crisis. Unfortunately, memory loss doesn’t last forever.

Notes

Hey guys, so 3.7 was… something. No comment on that but anyway, it took me forever to get around posting this even though I’ve had it done for a week or so by now

I admit this isn’t my best or even favorite works to read/write, so apologies in advance but I still hope you guys enjoy some of it <3

See the end of the work for more notes

They say the universe began with silence.

Even the Titans, for all their thunder, died quietly.

When Amphoreus broke, the sound took centuries to arrive—a tremor slow as grief, rippling through the marrow of creation. The great body cracked, bleeding light and memory into the void. From that wound spilled dust, heat, and the bones of gods.

The fragments drifted outward, cooling as they went. Continents formed in the hollows of ribs; oceans pooled in eye sockets. Gravity gathered the debris into orbits, and where Titan blood met vacuum, it hardened into light—rings circling what had once been one divine body.

That is how the new worlds were born: bright shards trailing the ruin of Amphoreus, each pulsing with a trace of its maker's marrow.

The Titans had no destiny—only appetite. They devoured until they collapsed beneath their own hunger. When the last of them consumed the wrong star, the universe cracked its knuckles and began again. From their remains, civilizations crawled forth: small, radiant things that built cities from cooled godflesh and called themselves heirs.

And perhaps they were.

Time passed, as it always does. The Titans became myth, their bones became trade goods, their festivals excuses for pageantry. Reverence turned to routine. The old questions—*what shaped us? what remains of them?*—faded beneath a newer one: *who owns what?*

And when a species learns to covet, empires are inevitable.

Two fragments shone brighter than the rest, circling the void where Amphoreus's heart once burned. One gold, one red.

They shared no language, no faith, not even air—only conviction that the other was wrong.

Naturally, they went to war.

They say Kephale, the Worldbearer, was the gentlest Titan, second to only Georios. When he fell, a single shard of his spine drifted into the broken system and became Okhema—the city that never touched ground.

Its continents hover among auroras that pulse like slow heartbeats, tethered by cords of aether spun from Kephale's lingering breath. The cords feed on resonance—on feeling. When the people laugh, the roots tighten. When they grieve, the cities sink. Storms of sorrow can drag whole skylines from the heavens. Weddings can send them soaring.

For Okhemians, emotion is physics.

Their cities grow like coral, humming faintly underfoot. Gold-veined bridges stretch between floating islands, carrying the echo of every heartbeat that helped shape them. The people glow from within—bioluminescent pigments blooming under their skin in shades of amber and azure. Amusement flickers blue across the throat; affection warms gold in the palms. Arguments are silent, fought in dimming light.

To outsiders, it all seems unbearably polite. But composure is survival. The cities themselves are alive, and one stray surge of emotion can ripple through the atmospheric lattice, undoing years of balance.

Seen from orbit, Okhema resembles a miniature sun—its light steady on calm days, flickering like a heartbeat when unrest brews below.

To be calm is to build. To feel too deeply is to destroy.

And so they live as Kephale did—shoulders steady beneath invisible weight, carrying their shining world through the sky.

If Okhema is the sun, Kremnos is its moon.

Quiet, enduring, unbothered by the need to shine.

They say it was carved from the body of Nikador, Titan of Strife—his bones hardened into crust, his blood into twin seas of gold and red. His final

breath became gravity itself, pressing down like an oath.

Here, nothing comes easily. The air is heavy, the storms unending, the ground veined with molten light. But struggle is sacred. The Kremnoans believe effort gives shape to existence. Their towers don't scrape heaven—they defy it.

They are built like their world: strong, deliberate, forged under pressure. Laughter shakes the walls. Love is loud and certain. Even their faith is made of muscle and endurance. Every scar is proof that they refused to yield.

Their creed is simple: Struggle is proof of life.

And so, where Okhema polishes emotion into harmony, Kremnos hammers it into meaning. One seeks balance, the other, worth. Yet both burn with the same ancestral heat, two children orbiting the corpse of a god.

Their lights still cross in the dark—gold meeting red, sun meeting storm.

And somewhere between them, light-years away, a man named Phainon was staring into his fourth empty cup of coffee, trying very hard to remember what the hell "sacred" was supposed to feel like.

The station breathed.

That was what Phainon always thought when he was on the night shift—though technically, there was no night here, nor did he take shifts, just the dimmed lights of Ecliptica-6 humming low to mimic one. The walls sighed with quiet energy, the pulse conduits beneath the floor thrummed in measured time, and somewhere in the deep machinery, the station exhaled recycled air that smelled faintly of citrus.

He'd been awake for… well, long enough that the coffee cup in his hand had gone from full, to empty, to possibly a biohazard. But it was peaceful work, at least—monitoring emotional harmonics while the ship floated steady above the Meridian Rift.

Outside the viewport, the Rift sprawled across the void like a scar of light—endless, pale, and whispering. It wasn’t quite a storm, not quite space. It was something that simply hummed faintly against the hull when the station drifted too near. Most people found it unnerving. Phainon thought it beautiful.

“Deck Twelve’s stabilizing again,” Castorice said from his left. She stood over a projection panel, neat as ever in her uniform, her lavender hair pulled into a knot that never seemed to move even in zero-grav. “Ninety-eight percent coherence. I’ll log it, but you might want to double-check the southern harmonic node. It’s fluctuating.”

Phainon glanced up from his console, watching the data scroll lazily past. “Only by two decimals,” he said. “Could just be interference from the Rift’s edge.”

Castorice tilted her head, one eyebrow faintly raised. “Could be,” she said in the tone of someone who didn’t believe him but was too polite to argue.

He smiled. “You ever think we’re too calm for this job?”

Her eyes flicked to him, then back to the console. “Someone has to be.”

That earned a chuckle. The last time emotional coherence had dropped below eighty, the entire aft deck had flickered in what Command diplomatically referred to as atmospheric sensory leakage. He still found glittering gold dust in his boots some days.

“Alright, alright,” he said, holding up one hand. “Point taken. I’ll monitor it manually.”

Castorice hummed in approval. “Add that to your report while you’re at it. They’ll ask.”

Phainon set his coffee down and picked up his datapad, brushing a thumb along the smooth edge to wake it. “They always ask,” he muttered, then leaned closer to the screen as it lit up with the Okhemian crest—gold, radiant, and annoyingly bright for the hour.

“Ecliptica-6 to Command,” came a filtered voice over the comms. “Requesting confirmation on emotional harmonic data for Cycle 117.”

Phainon tapped the console, toggling the transmission line open. “Command, this is the Envoy Phainon of Okhema, responding from Ecliptica-6. Transmission link clear. You’re getting our data stream?”

“Confirmed,” the voice replied. “State your operational status.”

“Stable orbit around Meridian Rift,” Phainon said, professional cadence slipping easily into place. “Position holding five klicks off the inner boundary, trajectory locked at two degrees lateral drift. Harmonics steady at ninety-eight coherence, no empathic surges reported. We’re ready for traversal tests when you are.”

Castorice, silent beside him, monitored the readouts with faint concentration.

“Understood,” Command said after a pause. “Prepare for synchronization sequence. Expect confirmation within the hour.”

Phainon inclined his head slightly, even though they couldn’t see him. “Copy that. Ecliptica-6 stands by.”

The transmission clicked off.

Phainon leaned back in his chair, exhaling through a smile.

“Well,” he said, glancing at her. “Looks like we’re officially doing our jobs today.”

Castorice looked up from her monitor, entertainment flickering briefly across her face. “We should celebrate, I can offer you half a ration bar.”

“Tempting,” he said. “But I was saving my appetite for recycled air and despair.”

She smiled—barely—but it reached her eyes.

The moment held, easy and companionable, before the station's ambient quiet was broken by a new sound: light footsteps and a voice that chimed like laughter through glass.

"Ooh! Snowy! Where are we going again?"

Both of them turned.

Standing in the doorway was Tribbie, one of the Tribios triplets—though Phainon still thought of her as the youngest, even if technically she was a third of a collective AI consciousness. Her frame flickered with faint golden light at the seams, and the air around her shimmered faintly as her projected scarf looped itself into a new pattern every few seconds.

"Tribbie," Phainon said, a grin already tugging at his mouth. "Didn't expect to see you up. Thought you and your sisters were still in rest mode."

"We were," Tribbie said cheerfully. "But we woke up! Trianne and Trinnon wanted to keep dreaming, though, so we came instead."

Phainon set down his tablet, stretching his arms. "We," he echoed. "Even when you're alone, huh?" He assumed it was a bug at first but seems not.

"Of course," she said, as if it were obvious. "We're always us."

Castorice turned, her tone softening. "It's good to see you, Tribbie. We were starting to miss your drawings."

Tribbie gasped, delighted. "You did? You noticed?"

"Hard not to," Phainon said, and crouched so he was at her level. "But since you're up…" He lowered his voice, eyes glinting. "Want to know where we're headed next?"

Tribbie leaned closer, practically buzzing. "We do!"

Phainon's smile changed into something conspiratorial. "We're going to the Meridian Rift."

Tribbie froze for half a second—then her eyes widened, twin pinpoints of starlight. “*The* Rift?”

“The one and only,” Phainon said, straightening again. “Don’t tell your sisters.”

Tribbie clasped her hands behind her back, expression all mock-seriousness. “We won’t. Probably.”

Castorice exhaled what might’ve been a laugh, and for a brief moment, everything seemed peaceful.

Then Tribbie blinked—once, twice—and the constellation of light around her shimmered strangely, fracturing into brief static before reforming. Her smile wavered.

“Snowy…” she said, voice thoughtful now, the faint reverb in her tone flattening as her processors shifted focus. “We might be detecting a signal.”

Phainon frowned, straightening slightly. “A signal?”

Castorice’s eyes lifted from her screen, one brow arched. “From the Rift?”

Tribbie tilted her head, as if listening to something distant. “Not sure. It’s… faint. And not supposed to be here.” Her voice dipped into a whisper of computation, digital notes rippling beneath her words. “It’s like static, but it’s singing back.”

Castorice’s fingers danced across her console, pulling up a schematic of their current coordinates. “No external comm signatures detected,” she said. “It’s likely interference from the harmonic edge. The Rift distorts just about everything that gets too close.”

Phainon hummed noncommittally, eyes still on his tablet. He wasn’t convinced, but he wasn’t particularly alarmed either. “Could be,” he said, returning to his work. “Or maybe it’s the Rift saying hello.”

Tribbie blinked, processing. “Rifts can’t say hello,” she said seriously, then paused. “Can they?”

“Depends how lonely they are,” Phainon murmured.

Tribbie frowned faintly. “Our database is… a little fuzzy right now. We know what the Meridian Rift is, but not much else.” She tapped her chest lightly, where her light-core pulsed. “Something about the data here causes interference in our archive memory. We tried syncing last cycle, but it keeps looping.”

Castorice glanced over, her expression softening. She reached out and patted Tribbie’s head with one gloved hand. “Don’t worry. I’ll run a full diagnostic once we finish the harmonic sweep.”

Tribbie’s eyes brightened instantly. “Thank you, Cas! We love it when you do a checkup.”

“Of course,” Castorice said.

Phainon, still half-focused on his screen, spoke without looking up. “Well, if it helps your data bank, the Rift isn’t really one thing—it’s more of a scar left behind when the Titans fell.”

Tribbie turned toward him, intrigued. “A scar?”

“Mhmm,” Phainon said, finally glancing up, his tone adopting the easy cadence he used when explaining things to the triplets. “When the Titans’ age ended, all that raw energy—what the old records call ‘residue’—didn’t just vanish. It condensed. Left fragments scattered across the void. The Rift happens to be one of the biggest deposits of that residue.”

He gestured toward the viewport, where the pale divide shimmered faintly in the darkness. “Titanal fragments are like… concentrated echoes of creation itself. They bend fields, distort signals, and—if you’re reckless enough—can power just about anything. Okhema’s Lattices run smoother with them. Kremnos uses them to strengthen their bioforges.”

Tribbie’s eyes widened. “Ohhh. So that’s why we’re here?”

“Partly,” Phainon said, flashing her a small smile. “Research. Observation. Making sure no one’s accidentally blowing up a chunk of reality.”

“And the other reason?” Tribbie asked, her digital gaze fixed on him.

Before Phainon could answer, Castorice spoke up. “There’s talk of collaboration,” she started. “Between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos. Something involving the Rift.”

Tribbie blinked, the light around her flickering as she processed this. “Collaboration?” she repeated slowly. “But… you hate each other.”

Castorice hesitated, while Phainon chuckled. “She’s not wrong,” he admitted. “But apparently it’s been decided we should play nice for once. No one tells the envoys *why*, of course—just that it’ll be historic, poetic, transformative…”

“Fifty years of cold conflict,” Castorice murmured, her gaze drifting to the Rift beyond the glass. “Over this same stretch of void.”

Phainon nodded. “Half a century of blockades, sabotage, posturing—because both sides wanted the same thing. Like I mentioned before… these fragments could power Okhema’s empathy lattices or strengthen Kremnos’s biostructures. You can imagine how that went.”

Tribbie tilted her head, her gaze wide. “Not well?”

“Not well,” Phainon agreed with a small, rueful smile. “But it’s poetic, isn’t it? Using the same thing that split us apart to bring us back together.”

Castorice’s sighed. “Assuming it does.”

Phainon’s smile dimmed slightly. “I suppose you’re right.”

Tribbie’s light flickered again, and she paused mid-motion, as though recalibrating. When her voice returned, it was bright, chirping with an upbeat tone that was as unmistakable as ever.

“Ooh! Aggie wants to talk to you guys!”

Phainon blinked, his brow furrowing slightly. “Aglaea?”

Tribbie nodded eagerly. “She said there’s a briefing soon. Something about a peace operation.”

Castorice straightened slightly, a hint of surprise crossing her face. “It seems we were right, then.”

Phainon’s eyes glinted. “Well, that’s… interesting.” He clapped his hands once, the sound sharp. “Alright then—let’s wrap this up fast. Castorice, check harmonic stability. Tribbie, you’re on assist.”

“Sure!” Tribbie said, her tone full of eagerness. “What do you need me to do, Snowy?”

Phainon paused for a moment, tapping his chin. “Start by syncing the pulse grid with the Rift’s outer frequency. Let’s see if we can get her singing back properly.”

Tribbie gave a tiny salute, her digital lights flickering in a mock-serious fashion. “On it!”

As Tribbie twirled toward the console, humming a melody that somehow synchronized with the station’s pulse, Castorice adjusted the alignment nodes in silence, focused as always. Phainon, meanwhile, turned back to the viewport, his gaze drawn to the Rift—a slow, deliberate pulse of light against the dark expanse of space.

For all its grandeur—the politics, the history, the ever-present tension—it still looked, to him, like a heartbeat suspended in time. And for a reason he couldn’t quite place, he couldn’t shake the feeling that it was listening.

The sound of Ecliptica-6 was steady enough to lull anyone else into forgetting they were orbiting a fault in reality. Phainon couldn’t.

He and Castorice moved through the hall in silence, boots whispering over metal. Her stride was short but brisk, calibrated; his matched it

automatically. Years of running dispatches together had synced their pace without effort. The only real sound came from the small, translucent tablet in his hand, its interface flickering in layered data bands: spectral harmonics, navigation maps, Rift field readings, and the quiet rhythm of an impossible pulse—red, steady, deliberate.

Castorice's wrist console answered it a moment later with a crisp electronic chirp. She glanced down, frowned, and said, "That nonexistent signal is now repeating in a coded pattern. Five-cycle intervals. Which means it's evolved."

Phainon's tone was mild. "So nonexistent it's registering across four frequencies. Ambitious for something that shouldn't exist."

"Ambitious," she repeated under her breath, tapping her console. "Or bored."

Behind them, Tribbie drifted with the easy, weightless poise of her projection—barely solid light, a shimmer of color cut through with data feed halos. "We traced the origin to approximately twelve degrees off the Rift's polar axis," she said, concerned. "Except there's nothing there. Nothing charted, nothing visible, nothing mapped in the last two centuries."

Phainon slowed, scanning the tablet. "Not nothing. Just something clever enough to look like it."

The feed shifted with a flick of his wrist, pixels shattering into static, static condensing into shapes. Tribbie caught the cue and extended the projection mid-corridor, the light blooming outward into a three-dimensional lattice of noise. The grain moved—slowly, irregularly—then folded into angular symmetry. Faint outlines formed, then vanished again.

Castorice's steps stopped first. "That looks like hull curvature." Her brow creased. "Military grade. Pattern's consistent."

Phainon studied the formation, head tilted. "Formation?"

She nodded once. “Triangular. Tapered drives, long spines—design profile matches Kremnoan fleet architecture. Except they shouldn’t be here.” She scrolled her readings, muttering. “The Rift’s harmonics would’ve shredded any unauthorized entry.”

“Unless,” Phainon said quietly, “they found a way to walk through shredded space.”

Tribbie’s voice faltered, projection dimming. “That’s… not in their capacity range. Their vessels can’t even sustain prolonged exposure to Titanal residue. They’d corrode from the inside out.”

“Unless,” he repeated, “they learned.”

Castorice’s console beeped again. “Empathic sensors are clean. That’s not possible. Even if they’ve cloaked their visuals, we’d still pick up emotional residue from the crews.” She hesitated, then added softer, “Unless someone found a way to mask that too.”

Phainon smiled faintly. “Hide emotion. There’s a thought.”

Her reply came quick, defensive. “It’s impossible.”

But she didn’t sound like she believed it.

Tribbie’s tone lost its bounce. “We’re reading twelve distinct signatures. Same drive pattern. Same energy bleed.” She paused. “Do we… ping Command?”

“Not yet,” Phainon murmured. He enlarged the scan. Those shapes moved in unison, cutting through Rift distortion like knife edges through fog. They weren’t wandering debris or misread ghosts. They had formation discipline. Purpose. A fleet’s patience.

Castorice stepped closer. “Trajectory?”

“Vector drift toward the Rift’s outer rim,” Tribbie said. “They’re hugging distortion—masking in the pulse troughs. No registry match. Definitely not ours.”

The red pulse on Phainon's screen matched their rhythm now, each beat like a quiet, slow warning. His reflection blinked inside the glass, and for the first time since the mission began, he felt the faintest tickle of unease at the back of his neck.

"New design?" Castorice asked, though she already knew the answer.

Phainon gave a soft exhale. "New. And very improved."

Their eyes met—briefly, but long enough to say *we know what that means* without needing to voice it.

Tribbie's voice came out small. "Aggie's pinged again. Twice." A flicker of static laced through her projection. "Should I tell her we're about to ruin her afternoon?"

"Let's keep her anticipation alive," Phainon said lightly, closing the tablet with a flick. "Come on. She'll want visual proof before she starts lecturing."

Castorice sighed, falling into stride beside him as they resumed down the corridor. "You do realize she's going to lecturing anyway."

"She'd lecture at the sunrise if it wasn't formatted properly."

Tribbie laughed softly, spinning once midair. "She *did* last week."

That drew the faintest giggle from Castorice, though her eyes stayed on the slit window.

The doors to the central deck parted with a low hiss.

Light unfurled ahead—the consoles lining the walls pulsing with soft data rhythms, and through the panoramic viewport, the stars shimmered like they were moving underwater.

Phainon stepped in first. The deck lights adjusted around him, soft gradients rolling outward under his boots. He braced one hand against the glass, watching faint ripples of reflected light travel up his sleeve. In the

viewport’s curved surface, three reflections overlapped—his, Castorice’s, and Tribbie’s—half-solid, half-light.

“Still never gets old,” he murmured.

“Neither does hearing you say that every time we come here,” Castorice said dryly, already bent over the nearest console. The air shimmered faintly around her hands as she brought up the harmonic lock, the nested circles aligning one by one in a soft pulse. “Running synchronization.”

Tribbie’s voice piped up behind them. “Bandwidth’s jittery again. The Rift’s throwing electricity from all directions.” She bounded toward another terminal, flickering briefly as her holographic form stabilized. “Stabilizing transmission bandwidth—don’t move anything important for, uh, five seconds. Maybe six.”

“That’s not confidence-inspiring,” Phainon muttered, eyes on his own tablet as lines of command script danced up the screen.

“My code prefers accuracy to confidence,” Tribbie chirped.

“Those aren’t mutually exclusive,” Castorice said, without looking up.

Tribbie blinked, mock offense flickering across her projection. “I’m *both*!”

Phainon let a quiet laugh slip as he keyed in the final command. “Good. Then you’ll love this part.”

The air shifted.

From the deck’s center, concentric rings of light spiraled outward, their glow moving in smooth, perfect timing with each pulse. They spun faster, converging into a single point before expanding in a burst of pale gold.

A figure began to form—fragmented at first, a shimmer of lines and geometry that slowly resolved into shape. When the lattice stabilized, a woman stood at the center, tall and composed, her white-and-golden attire catching the light. Around her drifted soft orbits of shape—geometric constructs turning slowly like miniature constellations.

Castorice’s posture straightened, a reflex born of habit. “Hello, Lady Aglaea.”

The hologram’s eyes shifted immediately toward her. “Castorice.” Her tone eased, a soft undercurrent of familiarity. Then her gaze flicked to the man by the viewport. “And Phainon. You’re looking far too radiant for this hour, Envoy.”

Phainon gave her a wry smile, lifting his cupless hand as if in toast. “That’s because I sleep less than you do, Architect.”

A faint gleam curved Aglaea’s mouth. “An impossible metric. I don’t believe anyone does.”

Tribbie waved energetically, her form flaring slightly. “Bandwidth stable! Transmission’s clean across the field.”

“Excellent work, Tribbie,” Aglaea said. “You always bring the system more enthusiasm than it deserves.”

“I’ve been told that before.” Tribbie said proudly.

Castorice glanced sidelong at Phainon. “Usually after she crashes it.”

“That was *one* time!” Tribbie protested.

Phainon coughed, covering a smile. “Three, actually.”

Aglaea’s laughter came quiet but genuine—a low, melodic sound that filled the space without needing volume. It faded as her tone eased back into command, smooth as gravity reclaiming its pull. “It’s good to see you all,” she said. “Though I take it you know this isn’t a social call.”

“Unfortunately,” Phainon replied, finally letting his hand fall from the viewport. The stars refracted faintly across his palm. “You’ll want to see this.”

The last of the deck’s lights steadied around them.

Phainon adjusted the holo-tablet between his hands, its pale light running thin across the metal curve of his gloves. “Alright. Picking up from the sweep.”

At his cue, Tribbie flicked her fingers, and a projection shimmered to life above the central dais—an elegant, pulsing web of coordinates suspended in air. The Meridian Rift sprawled wide and jagged across the display, veins of light tracing where the distortion folded in on itself.

“Origin’s here,” she said, gesturing toward the edge of the polar quadrant. Her hand fuzzed slightly as it passed through the light. “Twelve degrees off the Rift’s axis, same as before. And before anyone reminds me—yeah, there’s nothing there. Not according to any map we’ve got.”

Aglaea’s image tilted her head, curiosity showing. “And yet you found something.”

Tribbie zoomed in. The hologram refocused, the map collapsing inward until it dissolved.

“That loop again,” Castorice murmured, already syncing her wrist-console. “Repeats every five cycles, clean intervals. Random noise doesn’t do that.”

Phainon scrolled through his display, lines of coded light shifting across his lenses. “Signal’s registering across four harmonic bands. Which shouldn’t even be possible unless it’s been structured manually.”

Aglaea’s brows rose slightly. “Intentional?”

“Without question,” Castorice replied before Phainon could.

“Not from Okhema, not from anyone friendly,” Tribbie added. “I checked every registry twice.”

Phainon flicked his wrist, expanding the feed. “Then we’re down to one explanation.”

The hologram deepened, static unfurling into hazy geometry—faint, glimmering, half-caught in the Rift’s distortion. Then, piece by piece, the

shapes resolved into focus.

Angular hulls. Triangular silhouettes. Vessels slipping in and out of wavelength, as if surfacing and drowning in light all at once.

Castorice's expression tightened. "They're cloaked."

Phainon's tone stayed dry. "Fully functional stealth signatures. And get this—they're bypassing empathic detection entirely. We ran a triple harmonic sweep and picked up nothing. No emotional residue, no energy displacement. Nothing."

"That's what confuses me," Castorice said under her breath. "Empathic sensors are harmonically anchored. You can't hide what you *feel*. That's the entire point of them."

"Unless someone finally cracked the threshold." Phainon didn't look up. "And I'd bet half my rations who did."

Tribbie's glow dimmed, almost nervous. "Cloaking tech's banned, though. Has been since—"

"The Lycurgus Accord," Castorice supplied. "Everyone signed it. Even Kremnos."

"Yeah," Phainon said quietly. "And yet—"

He zoomed in once more, the ships' hulls catching faint light.

"Tell me that doesn't look familiar," he said.

No one answered.

Castorice finally exhaled. "Kremnoan construction. You can tell from the symmetry anchors on the fins."

"Thought so," Phainon murmured. "They've refined the design. Whatever they're doing, it's cleaner."

Aglaea’s hologram watched silently as the image rotated. “You’re certain these readings are accurate?”

Tribbie straightened defensively. “The bandwidth’s been fluctuating, but the pattern’s stable. If it were a false echo, it wouldn’t hold formation that cleanly.”

“Which means,” Castorice said, “they’re operating with intent. Close to the Rift. Running tests they don’t want us to see.”

“Or,” Phainon countered, “tests we were never supposed to notice but did anyway.”

Aglaea’s voice cut through before either could continue. “That’s enough.”

The projection dimmed, pausing mid-flicker. The room’s low hum softened, matching the steady cadence of her voice.

“You’re right,” she said. “They are Kremnoan. Prototype scouts equipped with adaptive stealth arrays. They weren’t attacking, only performing calibration runs along the Rift perimeter.”

Phainon frowned. “Calibration. That far out?”

“It was sanctioned.” Aglaea’s tone didn’t waver, but there was something behind it. “Under new protocol.”

Her gaze swept over them one by one before she continued. “The arrays they’re using were developed through Okhema’s authorization.”

Silence rippled through the observatory. The soft glow beneath their feet seemed louder than it should’ve been.

Phainon blinked slowly, trying to make sure he’d heard that right. “… Ours?”

Castorice’s eyes sharpened. “We approved it?”

Aglaea inclined her head. “The High Council voted this cycle. The initiative’s formal now—Okhema and Kremnos will cooperate for the Meridian Rift’s recovery effort. The operation’s official title is the Meridian Recovery Initiative.”

Tribbie’s voice came out small. “Cooperate as in… *us with them?* I thought that was a joke.”

“Exactly that,” Aglaea said. “They’ll lead fleet security. We handle harmonic containment and research. The partnership’s already in motion.”

Phainon leaned back slightly, exhaling through his teeth. “Didn’t think I’d live to see the day.” He had expected a collaboration of sorts but not—

Castorice’s tone was mild, but it finished his thoughts for him. “I didn’t think I’d see us *sponsoring* them.”

Aglaea’s expression softened faintly. “It’s not sponsorship if it’s necessity. The Rift’s destabilizing faster than projected—this is our best chance to contain it.”

“That’s one way to call it,” Phainon muttered.

Aglaea continued as if she hadn’t heard. “The Council has selected both of you as Okhema’s liaisons for the operation. You’ll oversee harmonic relay calibration, and maintain contact between field divisions.”

Castorice nodded once, calm and already moving into work mode. “Understood.”

Then, slower to react, she let out a breath. “…Please tell me it’s not the same commander again.”

For the first time, Aglaea’s poise wavered. She coughed—delicately—and glanced aside. “I’ll send you the file.”

The silence that followed said enough.

The display bloomed into being, light fracturing upward in a clean column before unfurling into a projection between them. The text assembled piece by piece—headers, insignias, stamps of interstellar authorization—all glowing in Okhema's pale azure code.

Phainon leaned forward a fraction, eyes catching the reflected data as the title resolved.

[MISSION FILE – JOINT RECOVERY OPERATION: MERIDIAN RIFT]
AUTHORIZED UNDER: THE INTERPOLAR HARMONIC ACCORDS, REV. 1124
COLLABORATIVE OVERSIGHT: OKHEMA | KREMNOS | CENTRAL UNION

Below the formalities, paragraphs of technical data scrolled—a cascade of harmonic flux readouts, containment parameters, diplomatic hierarchy lists. Castorice was already scanning the brief with focus, her fingers flicking through screens like a conductor keeping rhythm. Phainon, on the other hand, only skimmed, attention half-latched on the motion, until one section caught his eye.

A single line, pulsing faintly in the Okheman system's signature gold, almost like it *wanted* to be read.

[COMMANDER // MYDEIMOS]

He went very still for a moment. Then his lips curved—slowly, involuntarily.

"…It's the Commander," he murmured, and the words came out soft, dreamily almost, like he'd been waiting for the name to appear.

Castorice didn't look up. "Of course it is." Her voice was cool, like she's been waiting for this headache to happen the whole week.

Phainon's mouth quirked further. "What? You sound thrilled."

Aglaea’s form, still projected beside them, did not dignify that with acknowledgment. “Mydeimos is representing Kremnos’s interests. You’ll meet upon arrival.”

At that, the empathic panels along the chamber walls warmed in response to Phainon’s sudden emotional spike—barely a flicker, but enough for the ship to register it. Light flowed gently across the edges of the room, a synchronized pulse like a heartbeat trying to smooth over the disturbance.

Castorice glanced sidelong. “You’re setting the room off again.”

He adjusted his sleeve, tone perfectly even. “Just calibrating.”

Tribbie pouted from their console. “You ‘calibrate’ every time he’s mentioned.”

“Maybe he’s got that effect,” Phainon said idly, voice lighter now.

Aglaea’s projection flickered once as she continued, businesslike. “Coordinates are transmitting now. You’ll dock at Port Eltarion—one of the original Meridian fringe stations. Expect unstable gravimetric tides; the Rift’s harmonic field has been volatile since the Titanal aftershocks.”

“Translation,” Phainon said. “Bumpy ride.”

“You’ll manage,” Aglaea replied without missing a beat.

The navigation panels at the far end of the deck thrummed—a shift in tone as the ship began recalibrating its own course. A faint ripple of golden light swept the length of the room as the pilot core awakened.

Phainon’s gaze flicked toward the motion. “Trinnon’s awake,” he muttered, half to himself. “Right on time.”

Aglaea went on, eyes narrowing slightly as if she’d caught the undercurrent in his tone. “And yes—the signal was Kremnoan. But they’re not here for battle. I expect you all to be on your best behavior.”

Her gaze sharpened on him specifically.

Then, bemused: “Everyone.”

Phainon raised his hands in mock surrender. “See? I’m not even doing anything yet.”

“Not yet,” Castorice said under her breath.

Aglaea ignored them both, though the faintest ghost of amusement passed across her face. “HapLotes-405—how are the triplet sync protocols holding?”

Tribbie straightened. “Stable! Mostly. Trianne tried to overload the resonance loop again, but we convinced her that would’ve vaporized the kitchen, so—success!”

“Progress,” Aglaea said mildly. “Keep it that way.” Her tone softened. “Safe travels, all of you.”

Her hologram fractured, light cascading upward before fading into the ship’s dim, ambient glow.

Castorice exhaled and flicked through her screen one last time. “Trinnon, ETA?”

A new voice emerged through the comm system—gentle, even-toned, laced with synthesized warmth.

[“Estimated arrival: twenty-three minutes, forty-eight seconds.”]

“Perfect,” Phainon murmured, collapsing the holo-display into a smaller window.

The ship shuddered lightly as thrusters adjusted for descent, their trajectory turning toward their landing point. Outside, the view stretched endless—ribbons of blue and gold distortion curling like silk, the gravity waves bending light in impossible arcs.

Phainon lingered at the viewport, hand braced on the transparent panel.

Beneath his palm, the empathic panel glowed once, registering a heartbeat just a touch too fast before dimming again.

Castorice noticed. She said nothing.

Phainon didn’t look away.

To say the trip had been bumpy was an understatement.

The Ecliptica-6 wasn’t flying so much as violently *flinging itself* through the Rift like a half-possessed comet. If anyone had been watching from the outside—and honestly, no one sane would’ve been—they would’ve seen the small Okheman craft streaking across a churning void that looked more like molten glass than open space.

Inside, it was bedlam.

The walls pulsed in frantic shades of blue and green, trying (and failing spectacularly) to keep the interior mood field stable. The entire ship groaned like it was personally offended by their flight plan.

Tribbie, stationed at the primary console, yelped as her holographic hands danced over a dozen shifting panels. “Okay! That’s *another* magnetic tide! If we hit it dead-on, we *might* lose the aft stabilizers—no pressure!”

From the pilot’s nest came Trianne’s gleeful cackle. “It’s the only course that doesn’t peel us in half!”

Oh, right. Trianne was awake also. He should’ve mentioned that earlier.

The Ecliptica jerked hard to port, and suddenly everyone was airborne. The artificial gravity stuttered, vanished, and then slammed back at double intensity. Castorice made a sound halfway between a grunt and a prayer as her hair floated, halo-like, for half a second before snapping down again.

Phainon barely moved—just a single hand braced against the overhead beam, boots steady, eyes calm. He looked less panicked and more vaguely

entertained.

“Are we *sure* she was programmed for this kind of flight path?” he called, his voice carrying clear through the air as the ship’s resonance field compensated for the chaos.

“Define *sure*!” Trinnon shouted back, clinging to a safety rail and very much not helping. The smallest of the Tribios had plastered herself against Castorice’s sleeve like a terrified squirrel, her hologram flickering each time the ship jolted.

The lights strobed ultraviolet. The mood field reacted to collective panic by flickering into a migraine-inducing pulse. Somewhere in the background, something made a noise that sounded suspiciously like “*krrrk-bzz-no-structural-integrity,*” which was not reassuring.

“Hold—hold—HOLD!” Tribbie shrieked, half into static. “That was a gravitational shear! Trianne, what part of *‘subtle approach’* did you not understand!?”

“The part where you think subtlety keeps us alive!” Trianne hollered back.

The Ecliptica dipped nose-first into another pocket of turbulence so violently that even Phainon had to grab the nearest beam. His other arm shot out instinctively, catching Castorice before she could collide with the console.

“You alright?” he asked, leaning close to be heard over the rising vibration.

She’d gone pale, lips pressed tight. “Fine,” she managed, voice thin. “Just —space motion sickness.”

“Understandable,” he said lightly, shifting so her shoulder pressed against his chest for support. “Focus on my voice, not…whatever the hell this is.”

Trinnon, trying to be helpful, piped up, “Statistically, only a thirty-three percent mortality rate.”

“Not now, Trinnon!” Phainon snapped, eyes still on the viewport.

Outside, colors were twisting into glassy filaments. Through the shimmering haze, a faint metal silhouette appeared, distant but steady: a skeletal ring dotted with weak blue lights.

Port Eltarion.

He gritted his teeth, half for stability and half to keep from swearing. “I’ve got visual on the port! ETA?”

Trinnon squinted at flickering readings. “Uh—5 minutes if nothing else implodes!”

“Great,” Phainon muttered.

Panels screamed in six languages. The inertial dampeners pulsed erratically, their hum alternating between too loud and nonexistent. The empathic stabilizers tried to emit “soothing” frequencies that only made things worse —a high-pitched, cheery white noise paired with the faint, persistent scent of citrus.

“Is the ship *trying* to gaslight us into calmness?” Castorice muttered weakly.

“Yes,” Phainon said grimly. “And it’s failing.”

Then Trianne’s vioce. “On three, everyone!”

Tribbie froze mid-command. “Don’t you *dare*.”

“One!”

“Please no—”

“Two!”

“TRIANNE—”

“THREE!”

The Ecliptica dove.

Phainon’s instincts kicked in—he caught Castorice again, dragging her in against his chest and bracing his boots against the floor.

“Almost there!” He yelled out, laughing.

She looked green.

And then—suddenly, mercifully—the pressure eased.

The violent shuddering slowed. The lights dimmed. The only sound left was the low hum of the ship’s engines exhaling relief.

Silence.

Then, the faint hiss of the air filters kicking back in.

They’d landed.

…Or at least crashed softly enough to call it landing.

The artificial gravity stabilized a heartbeat too late, which meant everyone was flung down in a graceless heap. Castorice landed squarely on top of Phainon, who sighed and decided, for the sake of gallantry, to remain the human cushioning.

He blinked up at the flickering ceiling, waiting for the world to stop vibrating. “…Well,” he said finally, “that was a ride.”

Castorice groaned, face half-buried in his shoulder. “I’m starting to dislike space.”

“Good news,” he said, “space definitely hates us too.”

Trinnon dangled upside-down from a safety strap like a stunned bat. Trianne was still giggling somewhere up front. Tribbie, however, dusted herself off, straightened her holographic uniform, and, after a perfectly timed pause, cleared her throat.

“…Ahem. Welcome to Port Eltarion. We hope you enjoyed your flight.”

Silence.

Castorice exhaled one long, exhausted sigh.

“Never again,” she said flatly.

Phainon stayed on the floor a moment longer before his ribs pulsed with dull complaint. “Alright,” he groaned, “new rule—no Rift shortcuts. Ever again.”

Castorice made a sound halfway between agreement and nausea. She blinked down at him, realizing belatedly she was still sitting on his chest. “Oh. Right. Sorry.”

He waved her off with a grunt. “You’re fine. The floor’s worse off than me.”

She pulled him up. Phainon’s spine cracked audibly enough for Trianne to wince from across the deck. The ship’s viewplate still flickered slightly as he turned toward it—Port Eltarion came into view, floating along the edge like a shattered crown.

The ring was half-collapsed, three docking arms missing entirely, but light poured through the fractures in molten ribbons. Every few seconds, the glow shifted—orange to violet to pale gold—casting the broken metal in hues that almost looked intentional.

It wasn’t perfect. But in its own way, it was beautiful.

Behind them, Tribbie was muttering apologies to the ship’s systems. Trinnon hovered close to Castorice, holding out a slim water flask as if it might detonate.

“Hydration stabilizes biofeedback,” she said seriously. “And you should not stand. Standing is statistically correlated with—”

“—Vertigo,” Castorice finished weakly, taking the flask. “Got it.” She sank onto the lower deck steps, one hand pressed to her temple.

Phainon crouched beside her, resting an elbow on his knee. “Sorry for the trouble,” she apologized.

“Please,” he said, smiling faintly, “you handled that better than Trianne.”

“Hey!” came a distant squawk from the cockpit.

Phainon didn’t bother to look up. “You drove us *through* a dimensional pressure wave.”

“It was tactical improvisation!”

He arched a brow. “Sure. And my spinal alignment is a religious experience now.”

Castorice let out a laugh that cracked into a cough halfway through, but it was laughter all the same.

Trinnon, still hovering, pressed two small fingers against her wrist. “Let me tune the ambient field to your pattern,” she said, her tone almost gentle. The deck beneath them brightened from cold blue to warm amber. The hum softened, syncing with her pulse until her breathing eased.

She let out a slow breath. “That’s… better. Thank you.”

Phainon smiled at that and reached for the console nearby. Gold shimmered across his face as the holo-doc booted up, lines of encrypted script scrolling down. “Joint op files are still syncing,” he muttered. “Arrival window’s been moved forward. Again.”

She pinched the bridge of her nose. “Please excuse me, I feel like I’m going to throw up.”

“Then aim for Trianne.”

“Rude!”

Phainon stretched to his full height, groaning as something popped in his back again. He rubbed his side, grimacing lightly. “Alright. Let’s see what bureaucratic miracle wants us now.”

The words had barely left his mouth before Trinnon’s ears twitched. “Incoming transmission.”

Everyone froze.

The main comms array lit up, a slow bloom

spiraling from the floor to the ceiling. Then—suddenly—the pattern fractured, overwritten by a sharp red lattice. The Okheman circuitry flickered uncertainly as the Kremnoan neural-tech protocol forced its way through, refracting light across the panels like crystallized blood.

Castorice leaned forward, squinting. “They’re pinging an open line. Kremnoan command signature.”

As if the dramatic color scheme hadn’t given it away.

“How soon?” Phainon asked, already straightening.

Trinnon blinked at the display. “Transmission strength—ninety-eight percent. So… now.”

Phainon sighed through his teeth. “Of course it is.”

He stepped to the console, massaging his side absently as he keyed in the handshake sequence. The red light sharpened, focusing into the silhouette of a man.

The hologram resolved fully: tall, broad-shouldered, silver at the temples. The lines of his uniform were severe enough to look weaponized, and his eyes carried that unblinking steadiness that came only from decades of command.

Krateros.

Phainon’s posture straightened instinctively. “General.”

The older man inclined his head. “Envoys of Okhema. I trust your transit through herw was… survivable.”

Castorice smoothed a stray lock of hair behind her ear. “Barely.”

Krateros’ gaze flicked to the background—the flickering panels, the scorch marks along the hull visible through the viewport—and back again. “Rift traversal remains a high-risk maneuver for non-Kremnoan craft. Consider your arrival… fortunate.”

“That’s one word for it,” Phainon said lightly, arms folding.

“Your efficiency is noted. Our fleets are still en route from the inner corridor. You will hold orbit at Eltarion until the forward relays are operational. Once synchronization is complete, we’ll begin anchor alignment.”

Phainon nodded once. “Understood.”

“Expect the first relay drones within the hour. Your systems will need to adapt to Kremnoan harmonics.”

Castorice glanced at her console. “We can accommodate. HapLotes405 will manage calibration once the signal stabilizes.”

Krateros inclined his head. “Acceptable. The Commander will join the transmission upon arrival. He intends to debrief you personally.”

Phainon’s brow twitched, ever so slightly. “Of course he will.”

Krateros ignored him. “Until then, Envoy. Keep your systems steady.”

The projection fractured into shards of light and vanished, leaving the room bathed once more in warm Okheman gold.

For a long moment, no one spoke.

Then Tribbie sighed, brushing her hands down her holographic clothes. “Well. That was intense. Anyone else suddenly craving a systems diagnostic?”

Castorice groaned softly into her hand. “I’m craving gravity that doesn’t shift moods every five minutes.”

Phainon scrubbed a palm over his face. “If by ‘intense’ you mean ‘a bureaucratic migraine waiting to happen,’ then yes. Completely intense.”

She pushed herself up, more balanced now. “At least we made it,” she said, gazing out through the viewport at the fractured ring beyond.

Phainon followed her line of sight. “Yeah,” he said quietly. “One piece is better than none.”

For now, they’d left the aftermath to the Tribios to deal with.

Trinnon had insisted they could handle the inbound calibration work—“*a minor synchronization issue,*” he’d said, as if merging two civilization-grade comm arrays across two cultures with diametrically opposed physics models was as simple as adjusting a radio dial. Phainon hadn’t argued. The small ones were frighteningly competent when left to their own devices, and besides, it gave him an excuse to get Castorice off the ship.

“Maybe you’d like some fresh air?” he’d offered, leaning in the doorway.

She had looked up from her terminal, arching a brow. “Fresh air? On a derelict ring station?”

“You’ll like it,” he said. “Eltarion’s dome filtration system still runs on original Okheman design. O_2 purity’s better than what we get on the homefront.”

“Lead the way, Snowy.”

And that was how they’d ended up here, twenty minutes later—leaving the Tribios to the diagnostics, while the two of them stepped out into the fractured grandeur of Port Eltarion.

Now, the present hums around them.

The outer decks breathe with faint light—half-living conduits pulsing underfoot, their blue glow tracing veins through the corroded metal. The dome overhead, fractured but whole enough, filters light into trembling shades violet. Below, the silent skeleton of the place stretches into the curve of the horizon, every ruin suspended in gravity’s half-forgotten memory.

Castorice stands near the observation railing, steady now. “You were right,” she says. “The air’s… clean.”

“Told you.” Phainon rests his elbows against the railing, eyes tracing the shimmer of field generators below. “Okhema built things to last.”

“Built them so well they fell apart poetically,” she murmurs, and he glances sideways.

“Hard to believe this used to be one of the major trade rings,” Castorice says.

He hums. “Harder to believe it’s still standing.”

Then she stills, head tilted slightly toward the viewport.

“Phainon,” she murmurs.

He follows her gaze—and sees it too.

“Docking sensors are activating,” he says under his breath, watching the readouts bloom across his wristplate.

The air pressure shifts around them; the dormant sirens shudder awake, casting resonant pulses through the hull. And then, with a slow, seismic grandeur, the first shadow breaches the fog.

The Kremnoan fleet arrives like the surfacing of continents.

Ships, if one could still call them that, unfold from the distortion—vast, triangular hulls of obsidian and red, their edges etched in molten veins that pulse like magma.

Phainon feels it before he sees it—the low, chest-deep vibration as gravity fields shift to accommodate their mass.

Even from a safe distance, the air itself seems to bow beneath their presence. The red-gold illumination paints the walls and the two Okhemans in soft, bleeding color.

“Never seen anything like that up close,” Castorice breathes, awe threaded through her voice.

Phainon lets out a low whistle. “Most people haven’t.”

He flicks his wristplate, the projection blooming into a curved comm-interface. “Let’s make sure they know we’re not standing in the blast zone.”

“This is Phainon of Okhema,” he says. “Station Eltarion welcomes the incoming fleet. Your approach vector is clear and registered.”

For a few seconds, nothing. Then: a voice.

“Eltarion Command, this is the Kremnoan Vanguard Serev-Kai. Your coordinates are stable. Visual descent will commence shortly.”

The clarity of the tone almost startles him. He glances toward Castorice, who raises a brow but says nothing.

“Well,” he murmurs. “Either we’re very important or very doomed.”

A flicker ripples across the interface, coalescing into a faint holo—Krateros, once again, crystalline eyes glinting like volcanic glass.

“Okhemans,” he greets, curt. “Our thanks for securing the perimeter. Transmission received with minimal deviation.”

“Glad to hear it,” Phainon replies. “Your fleet made excellent time.”

Krateros inclines his head slightly. “Efficiency is a matter of habit. Our escort divisions will synchronize docking in thirty standard minutes. Containment barriers will stabilize soon after.”

“Perfect.” Phainon nods, then adds lightly, “Would you mind sending someone to meet us once you’ve landed? Your ships are larger than ours, and I’d hate to wander into the wrong airlock and dissolve.”

A faint, almost imperceptible pause from Krateros. “Understood. An escort will be dispatched upon touchdown.”

“Much appreciated,” Phainon says. “We’ll be standing by.”

The connection flickers out, leaving a trace of harmonics hanging in the air.

He exhales slowly, lowering his wrist. “Thirty minutes,” he mutters. “Their estimate was six hours.”

Castorice doesn’t answer immediately. She watches the massive silhouettes align for descent, thoughtful. “They like to make an entrance.”

“Or a statement.”

The first of the ships begins to lower.

There’s no sound at first—just light, rippling in liquid waves over their hulls as they pierce the atmosphere’s thin membrane. Then the resonance hits: a deep, rolling hum that vibrates through every bone in his body. For a moment, the entire station feels alive again.

Microfractures skitter across the plating beneath their boots—harmless, caught by the stabilizers—but still, Phainon can feel the strain, the scale. The ships settle into the ring’s outer bay with the predatory grace of something ancient returning home.

The comm-plate chimes again, voice automated but unmistakably Kremnoan:

“Escort en route. Please remain within the designated perimeter.”

He glances toward Castorice. “Guess that’s our cue.”

She tucks a stray strand of hair behind her ear. “Please try not to offend anyone before we even step aboard.”

“No promises.”

As expected, the inside looked even better than the out.

Eltarion’s outer hull hadn’t done justice to what lay beneath its molten skin. Inside, the flagship of Kremnos was less a vessel and more a cathedral grown from the planet’s marrow. The walls gleamed in deep red and black-gold gradients, crystalline veins branching like rivers of light beneath the surface. When the air shifted, the glow inside them shifted, too, humming like a heart caught between mechanical rhythm and biological beat.

The escort leading them said nothing. His armor—if that’s what it was—looked forged from the same substance as the ship itself, a volcanic alloy so dense that even the sound of his steps seemed swallowed by it. Phainon couldn’t decide if there was a man under it or just another of Kremnos’s living constructs, one of those half-breathing guardians molded from the planet’s own core.

Castorice walked beside him, hands loosely clasped behind her back. The pale light caught the lavender sheen of her hair and the faint opalescence of Okhema’s standard uniform—soft white fabric trimmed in gold, a color palette that made them both look like stray sunlight wandering through the underworld.

When they entered the diplomatic hall, even Phainon—professional, unflappable—found his breath catching for half a second.

It was immense. Columns of white crystal spiraled up into vaults of molten glass, their tips refracting light like slow lightning. The floor was cut obsidian (?), smooth enough to reflect their faces in the glow.

“They built this to impress,” Castorice murmured, gaze trailing up one of the glimmering arches.

Phainon smiled faintly. “Or to intimidate.”

She considered. “Same thing, really.”

Their escort finally stopped at the hall’s center and gestured forward. Around them, Kremnoan officers stood in quiet formation, their armor a spectrum of metallic colors, their crystalline eyes catching and scattering the ship’s internal glow. The tallest among them—a beautiful looking woman—stepped forward and bowed, an elegant arc of formality.

“Okhema’s envoys,” she said, voice rich. “You honor the Vanguard with your presence.”

Phainon inclined his head in return, every movement polished. “And Okhema appreciates the welcome. It seems we’re in excellent hands.”

“The best our fleet can offer,” she replied, tone smooth. “The Vanguard awaits your findings.”

Phainon smiled faintly.

“You’ve made remarkable time through the Rift,” Phainon said, eyes on one of the shifting patterns. “Our instruments logged turbulence along your vector—most fleets would’ve diverted.”

Rhyktas, a captain with garnet skin marbled by black mineral veins, offered a small, tight smile. “Kremnos adapts. Our traversal algorithms refine themselves through repetition. Efficiency is a virtue.”

“Efficiency,” Phainon echoed, tone mild. “And stealth.”

A pause.

“Stealth,” Rhyktas said at last, “is a side effect. Never an intent.”

“Intent,” Castorice said pleasantly, “tends to be a flexible thing.”

That earned the faintest twitch at the corner of his mouth before the conversation drifted elsewhere.

Another officer, this one with quartz-bright eyes, turned toward them. “We’ve heard your readings from the outer sectors show a rise in empathic frequencies. Beyond predictive range?”

Castorice’s voice was gentle but deliberate. “They’ve been… irregular, yes. Nothing outside operational limits. The Rift is volatile, it reacts to any conscious field nearby. You understand how it is.”

That, of course, was a diplomatic lie. And Phainon could feel the moment every Kremnoan in the room recognized it.

By the time they reached the inner chamber, both delegations had exchanged far more sentences than secrets. Still, they’d both gotten what they came for: Kremnos’s interest wasn’t academic. Mydeimos’s personal detachment—his elite specialists—was onboard.

Curious.

The next chamber opened with a sound like a forge exhaling. The doors parted, and the temperature shifted. It was warmer, heavier.

Waiting within stood Krateros, this time in human form. Beside him, Commander Vireth—the arm still bearing the fracture scar from a skirmish with the Luofu Phainon remembered far too vividly—and Hekron, quiet, luminous-eyed.

Phainon and Castorice exchanged a glance. So the council had sent more than diplomats.

“Envoy,” Krateros greeted. “Adjunct. An honor to finally meet in person.”

“Likewise,” Phainon returned smoothly. “Your ship is… breathtaking. I’d almost call it holy.”

“The Kremnoan design strives for function and reverence,” Krateros said. “I imagine Okhema does much the same.”

“Oh, we prefer subtlety,” Phainon said, smiling faintly. “But I’ll admit, you’ve outdone us.”

Castorice, ever composed, added, “And efficient, too.”

Krateros’s eyebrow rose slightly. “Efficiency,” he said, amused at hearing the word again. “A shared principle, then.”

Phainon would’ve continued talking, but he was waiting for the right moment.

And then it came.

The chamber’s glow dimmed, turning from gold to a deep ember. The frequency beneath their feet shifted tone, low and resonant.

Phainon’s hand tingled. The small harmonic focus crystal he’d kept tucked in his sleeve—an instrument designed to measure resonance—suddenly thrummed to life, vibrating so violently he nearly fumbled it. Its readings spiked off-scale before the device began to burn hot against his palm. He slid it into his coat pocket fast, pretending to adjust his sleeve.

The doors at the far end split apart.

Two figures stepped through the haze first—one unmistakable.

Hephaestion—Phainon knew him by posture alone—Mydei’s right hand.

And behind him came the one every vibration in the ship seemed to anticipate.

Mydeimos.

He hadn’t changed.

His uniform was stripped down to functionality—dark crimson lined with gold circuit-threading that pulsed faintly, almost breathing. His hair caught the chamber light like a blade: beige at the roots, bleeding to molten red.

His eyes—gilded, unreadable—moved across the room like scanners set to find weakness.

He didn’t speak. He didn’t need to. The silence was enough to command the space.

Every Kremnoan in the room shifted subtly, bodies straightening in quiet acknowledgment.

Phainon stopped. His control flickered—just long enough that the color of his eyes shifted, a sudden flicker of gold through the blue. Castorice noticed. Her hand brushed his sleeve, just once, the faintest reminder to breathe.

He forced the light down, pulse steady again.

And then Mydeimos’s gaze found him.

A silence stretched—long, electric, impossible to fill.

Phainon’s mouth curled, the hint of a smile forming.

The kind of smile that never meant peace.

Phainon bowed his head—not deeply.

“Commander,” he said smoothly, voice dipped in silk.

Across the wide glass chamber, Mydeimos regarded him with that cutting stillness of his—like the pause before a blade drops. “You still breathe, envoy,” he said at last. “A shame.”

A grin unfolded over Phainon’s face, bright and unapologetic. “You missed me, then.”

The silence that followed rippled through the Kremnoan officers like static through glass. Someone shifted. Someone else coughed. Mydeimos’s expression did not move, but his tone dropped an inch lower. “I don’t miss irritants,” he said. “I remove them.”

Phainon tilted his head. “Mm. You’d have to touch me for that.”

The sound Castorice made beside him might’ve been a sigh—or a prayer for patience.

Mydeimos’s jaw twitched almost imperceptibly. Then, measuredly, he turned his attention toward the holo-table instead. “Let’s not waste any more time.”

But Phainon, of course, did. “Time spent in your company could never be wasted.”

That earned him a very flat look from Hephaestion across the table.

Castorice, as usual, knew better than to stay too close to the explosion radius. She drifted toward Hephaestion, polite smile already in place. “Hephaestion, I assume?”

He inclined his head. “That depends who’s asking. Researcher Castorice, I presume?”

“That’s right.”

He smiled. “Your reports make for fine reading. Detailed, and slightly terrifying.”

She arched a brow. “That’s because I write them myself.”

Hephaestion laughed—genuine—and Mydeimos’s eyes slid toward him with a look that said *please don’t encourage them.* He responded with a small shrug that said too late.

Meanwhile, Phainon had settled halfway on the edge of the conference table, idly toying with the corner of his glove.

“So this is where the great Commander of Kremnos holds court,” Phainon drawled, gesturing lazily to the vaulted metal and crystalline glow. “Glass, gold, and the faint smell of superiority.”

Mydeimos’s gaze snapped to him. “I hold court nowhere.”

“Oh?” Phainon hummed in mock thought. “Then I must be terribly lucky. Not many get to stand this close to you without vaporizing.”

Something in Mydeimos’s face shifted—a crack, barely visible, but there.

“Enough,” he said finally, voice sharpening in annoyance. “I’ve had it with your theatrics. Let’s begin.”

A flick of his wrist, and the room adjusted—lights dimmed, projection expanding until the entire space glowed with swirling star maps. The Rift loomed in scale before them: vast, jagged, unstable.

Mydeimos’s tone, when he spoke again, was changed. “The Titanal fragments within the Rift have begun destabilizing harmonic currents along our shared corridors. The imbalance is accelerating. If it continues unchecked, we lose our primary trade vectors by the next quarter-cycle.”

Castorice frowned. “We’ve observed similar readings—harmonic spikes, frequency splintering across the lateral bands.”

Phainon nodded, folding his arms, his earlier smirk fading just enough to show he was listening. “And if the field ruptures completely, containment becomes impossible. Half the interstellar routes collapse.”

“Both sides lose,” Mydeimos confirmed. “Our task is containment. Okhema’s fleet handles harmonic mapping and energy diagnostics. Kremnos provides tactical protection and navigational gridwork through the unstable zones.”

Hephaestion leaned forward, tapping a few panels. The hologram reoriented, showing their dual paths. “Two converging fleets,” he said. “Kremnos enters from the southern corridor, setting the anchor grid. Okhema traces the fissures from the northern vector. Data streams sync every six hours. Any deviation above point-six triggers an immediate recall.”

Phainon’s mouth twitched. “Simple. Almost charmingly predictable.”

Mydeimos’s eyes flicked toward him. “Predictability keeps people alive.”

“Mm. But unpredictability makes it interesting.”

The air tightened, charged. It might’ve stayed that way if Hephaestion hadn’t cut in—good-naturedly, but pointedly. “You two planning to compare philosophies or actually save the corridors?”

Mydeimos exhaled, clearing his throat. “As I was saying—”

Phainon, unrepentant, leaned closer. “You were saying *we’ll work together*. You should try to sound happier about it.”

“I’m elated,” Mydeimos deadpanned.

“Liar,” Phainon said lightly.

The commander’s mouth curved—barely, a ghost of something. “Careful, envoy. Some of us bite.”

Phainon’s grin brightened, teeth catching the white of the hologram’s light. “That’s the idea.”

Castorice, now deep in a hushed exchange with Hephaestion, pretended not to hear a word of it.

Other than that, the conversation was quite boring.

The deeper logistics were hashed out quickly—relay placement, data relays, interference fields, everything.

Soon after, when the projection dimmed and the final sequence stabilized, the air eased back into its natural rhythm. Mydeimos closed the holo with a gesture. “That concludes the joint coordination session. Data protocols are being transmitted to your flagship as we speak.”

Castorice inclined her head. “Acknowledged. I’ll ensure calibration syncs immediately upon return.”

“Good,” Mydeimos said.

Phainon hadn’t moved. His gaze was still fixed on the commander. “Always so composed,” he murmured, mostly to himself.

Mydeimos finally looked back. “Always so loud.”

Hephaestion smirked. “And yet, somehow, still invited.”

Phainon turned toward him, eyes glinting. “You’d miss me otherwise.”

“Unlikely,” Mydeimos muttered, already turning away.

When the meeting dispersed, the Kremnoan officers filed out with curt nods and metallic murmurs. Mydeimos and Hephaestion remained a moment longer, conferring in low voices by the projection dais.

Phainon lingered, just long enough to catch the sharp line of Mydeimos’s profile against the fading red light.

He didn’t look back.

Phainon smiled to himself. “Do you think monsters know when they’re beautiful?” he asked absently.

Castorice, already walking toward the exit, didn’t even turn. “Let’s get back to our ship, please.”

He followed, boots echoing softly through the crystalline corridor as the Kremnoan light dimmed behind them—red fading into the white of Okhema’s.

Phainon yawned—the kind that came from thirty-six hours of recycled air and soft alarm chimes, deep enough to echo faintly against the metal bulkhead.

Outside the viewport, the Okheman cruiser glided through a corridor of fractured starlight.

The panels beneath their hands pulsed slightly. Harmonic fields thrummed faintly through the deck—the heartbeat of a vessel holding itself together.

Phainon leaned forward on the console, chin propped against his hand. “You know,” he said around another stifled yawn, “for a sector named after a fault, it really likes to prove the point.”

Castorice’s focus never broke, not even when the deck swayed faintly beneath them. “Meaning?”

“Meaning it’s living up to the name. Fractured. Irritating. Unforgiving.” He squinted at a soft pulse of violet flaring across his display, then added more quietly, “And a little too beautiful for comfort.”

From above, a voice chimed in.

“Flux stable… quantum bandwidth holding at eighty-nine percent… we like this percentage!”

Phainon half turned. “You always say that, Tribbie.”

“We always mean it.” she replied, hovering just overhead.

“That’s reassuring,” Castorice murmured.

“Great work as always, Tribbie,” Phainon said, reaching up out of habit to ruffle her hair.

Trinnon and Trianne had gone quiet the day before, shutting down to conserve processing power while Okhema held position in the Rift’s heavier zones. The absence of their chatter left the bridge quieter than anyone liked. Every now and then, Phainon would glance at the empty ports where their signals used to hover, as if expecting them to flicker back.

Castorice had called the silence “unsettling.”

Phainon had said “sad.”

Tribbie had called it both before promising to “hold steady for all three of us.”

Phainon smiled faintly at the memory. “How’s our corridor holding?”

“Stable enough,” Castorice answered, adjusting a few dials. “The southern harmonic line’s syncing cleanly with Kremnos’s outer grids. Their fleet’s maintaining orbit along the second fracture cluster.”

“So,” Phainon murmured, “the plan’s actually working.”

“For now,” she said.

He huffed a quiet laugh. “You’ll make an optimist proud.”

“Don’t count on it.”

“I got another report earlier,” Castorice continued, scanning the readings. “The fragments are beginning to structure themselves—crystalline chains forming along the magnetic fractures. They’re… humming, in a sense. Frequencies we can barely translate.”

Phainon tapped through the analysis logs. “Any chance it’s not just random noise?”

“Doubtful. It’s decaying resonance—echoes of what the Rift used to be before it collapsed in on itself. Harmonic decay, residual motion, memory imprints. Nothing alive, but not nothing.”

He looked at the scrolling waveforms, colors bending softly against the screen. “The sound of dying stars humming their last song,” he said.

“Poetic nonsense detected,” Tribbie announced in mock seriousness. “Logging for future teasing.”

Phainon blinked, then laughed. “That’s mutiny, Tribbie. Mark that too.”

“Logged with affection.”

The bridge lights flickered—the quiet shift of the containment adjusting again.

The hum of etheric flow filled the pause that followed.

Phainon broke it. “You know, our last call with Mydei was short. Almost like he couldn’t wait to leave.”

“Still thinking about your favorite Kremnoan?” Castorice asked.

“Thinking about my least favorite man in the universe,” he said immediately.

Tribbie tilted her head. “That sounds suspiciously like favorite behavior.”

“Traitor.”

“Affectionate observation,” she countered.

Castorice folded her arms. “You’ll have a chance to glare at him again soon. Sync call’s coming up—two minutes.”

Phainon blinked. “Already? That was fast.”

“That’s what happens when you lose track of time.”

“I don’t lose track of time.” He stretched, vertebrae cracking audibly. “Time just refuses to behave around me.”

“That’s definitely how that works,” she murmured.

He picked up a sleek, iridescent device from the console—its surface alive with dim, rippling light—and thumbed through the new readings. “Outer corridor’s holding. Slight flux in the magnetic fold, nothing dangerous. Looks like Kremnos’s side is taking the heavier resonance strain.”

“They built for brute endurance,” Castorice said. “We built for balance.”

He hummed. “And here we are—proof that compromise can be inconveniently effective.”

“Or that necessity makes for strange partners.”

“Poetic,” he teased.

She shook her head, smiling faintly. “I’m learning from you.”

Before he could answer, the holo-channel shimmered to life—light unfurling in geometric strands, each one folding into the next until a translucent sphere hovered between them.

Tribbie’s form brightened as she adjusted signal flow. “Channel steady. Routing uplink now. Please try to sound professional.”

Phainon looked amused. “You’re the one who said we.”

“We includes you,” she said primly.

He grinned. “Alright, let’s start.”

The light stabilized, and then the signal cleared.

Hephaestion came into focus first and beside him, Leonnius lounged against a console, one arm slung casually over a holobar.

“Okhema uplink secure,” Castorice reported.

Hephaestion nodded. “Good to see your end still intact, Researcher.”

A voice came from off-frame. “You sound surprised, Hephaestion.”

Phainon stepped into the holographic wash, crossing the projection radius. His tone carried a lightness—the sort that made people uncertain whether he was being polite or mocking.

“I’m always pleasantly surprised when you’re not the source of interference.”

“Ah,” Phainon said mildly. “And here I was hoping for flattery.”

Leonnius gave a laugh. “Oh, there it is—the envoy himself. I was beginning to think you’ve died.”

Phainon didn’t answer right away. He just looked at Leonnius, the silence stretching long enough that even Tribbie, flickering faintly behind him, hesitated like she was waiting for a cue to giggle.

“Leonnius,” Phainon said finally. “You still talk as though your commander’s listening in. It’s endearing.”

Leonnius’s grin sharpened, all teeth. “Old habits. Especially when the commander’s busy making sure the rest of us don’t die.”

A flicker—brief, barely perceptible—crossed Phainon’s face, a tightening near his eyes that disappeared behind a smirk.

Hephaestion, amused, interjected. “You’re talkative today.”

“Blame the vacuum,” Leonnius replied, leaning back and tapping his console. “Anyway—grid anchors deployed and stable. Magnetic flux readings are steady. We’ve mapped seven of the southern fractures. Pretty ones, too. Shame they’re lethal.”

Hephaestion gave a low hum, eyes flicking toward the readings projected behind them.

Castorice adjusted her own console. “We’re seeing harmonic feedback from those same fractures. The pattern’s faintly rhythmic—pulsing in sequence.”

“Patterned?” Hephaestion’s brow rose. “That’s new. Flux is stable on our side, but temperamental. The commander’s leading the third sweep himself.”

Mydei.

Leonnius’s smirk faded into something almost fond, an ease that came naturally only when the subject was someone they trust. “He’s enjoying

himself," he said idly. "Haven't seen him go all out in ages."

That earned a sharper look from Phainon—subtle, but clear. "How lucky for you."

Leonnius caught it instantly, that edge of careful disinterest. "You'd say that differently if you'd ever seen him pilot up close."

Phainon's smile was smooth. "Oh, I've seen him. That's the problem."

Hephaestion made a sound suspiciously like a stifled laugh. "Easy, both of you. We're on the same side—for now."

Castorice cut through the tension. "Okhema's readings confirm the harmonic split's widening but not exponentially. The Rift's fragments are developing crystallized exo-shells. Their resonance is increasing—too deliberate to be random collapse."

Leonnius looked mildly impressed. "Deliberate?"

She nodded, scrolling through waveforms. "They respond to movement. Each time one of our ships passes, the crystalline matrix adjusts its resonance. Adaptive feedback. It's… almost aware."

Phainon brought up a holo beside her, magnifying a shimmering cluster. Tiny filaments twisted through the image like glass nerves. "We broadcasted steady harmonic tones," he said. "The formation reoriented toward us. Not hostile—more like… recognition."

Hephaestion frowned slightly. "That's unnerving."

"Beautiful," Phainon corrected under his breath.

Leonnius gave a quiet whistle. "And that's why we prefer armor over poetry."

Phainon's mouth curved. "And yet the poets are still here."

"Miracles happen."

Before anyone could respond, Tribbie exclaimed, “Miracle acknowledged. Logging optimism for morale reports!”

That earned a genuine laugh from Hephaestion. “I like your assistant, Envoy.”

“She’s the pragmatic one,” Phainon said. “Keeps the rest of us from drifting into existential despair.”

Castorice sighed. “Someone has to.”

Then the comm line pinged, a sharp chime slicing through the quiet.

Hephaestion checked his console. “Priority link. The commander.”

Leonnius straightened immediately, expression shifting from relaxed to focused in an instant. “We’ll take it.”

Hephaestion nodded once toward the Okhema side. “Appreciate the sync, Envoy. Researcher. Keep that harmonic data flowing—the Council will want comparative readings before the next cycle.”

“Understood,” Castorice replied.

Phainon added lightly, “Try not to get swallowed whole while we’re gone.”

Leonnius smirked, stepping back into the fading hologram. “We’d hate to miss seeing you jealous again.”

Phainon’s answering smile was too perfect to be sincere. “Take care down there.”

The image fractured—light dissolving into particles—and then they were gone.

Tribbie dimmed her light. “Transmission closed.”

Phainon stayed quiet for a moment, staring at the empty air where the projection had been. His jaw flexed once. He bit his inner cheek—a tiny,

human thing—before speaking, voice low. “Why doesn’t he ever call us directly?”

Castorice didn’t look up. “Because they’re running the front line. It isn’t his place to—”

“I know,” Phainon interrupted, too quickly. Then softer, almost embarrassed, “I know. Just joking.”

But the joke didn’t land.

Castorice turned her head just slightly, studying him. Whatever she might’ve said stayed unsaid.

Tribbie floated closer, voice barely above a whisper. “Another call soon.”

Phainon smiled faintly, without humor. “Yeah,” he murmured. “Soon.”

Unfortunately, the calls had became more frequent after that.

By the sixth day, the Okhema’s bridge had stopped bothering to dim the panels during rest hours. The Rift’s glow bled through the viewport in unpredictable flashes anyway—sometimes dim, sometimes bright, always too deliberate to be random.

They’d switched to staggered shifts by then. Castorice took the early hours, calibrating data streams and cross-analyzing the harmonics while Phainon slept in the observation cabin just off the main deck. When he woke, she was usually gone—her console cleared, her mug left half full, the faint steam always just cooled. A quiet signature that the day had already started without him.

When their hours did overlap, it was brief—a passing nod, a tired “morning,” sometimes a note left on the holo-feed that read more like a sigh than a sentence. Their conversations had grown shorter as well.

Even Tribbie filled the silence differently these days.

She’d started humming when idle. It wasn’t in her programming, not exactly, but neither of them ever told her to stop.

It would’ve been peaceful, if it didn’t sometimes sound like someone else was with them.

“Resonance stable,” Tribbie announced one morning, bright and chipper as ever.

Then, after a pause—same tone, same rhythm—

“Resonance stable.”

Castorice paused mid-sip. “Tribbie?”

“Yes?”

“You just repeated yourself.”

“No, we didn’t.”

The pause after was uncanny. More than it should’ve been.

“…Did we?”

Castorice exhaled slowly. “You did.”

“Oh.” Her voice dropped a register, embarrassed. “I don’t remember.”

“Check your logs.”

“I did.”

“And?”

“They’re fine.”

The lights flickered once—just once—and outside, the Rift pulsed in perfect sync, like it had been waiting for its cue.

The environmental drift started that same day.

Condensation appeared along the starboard panels—fine moisture on surfaces that shouldn't have been capable of forming it. The lights dimmed in strange intervals, sometimes following the hum.

When Castorice ran diagnostics, everything came up clear. Except—

a small, persistent deviation: 0.04 degrees off magnetic alignment, identical across every instrument. Too exact to be coincidence. Too minor to justify panic.

Phainon had leaned over her shoulder, squinting at the readout. "It's probably the Rift flirting again."

"You joke too easily."

"That's my only marketable skill."

But even he didn't laugh after saying it. His humor had thinned out lately—still there, but stretched and a little brittle.

They adjusted. That was what Okheman did best.

By the eighth cycle, the fatigue had settled in for good. Their bodies resisted it, but the exhaustion clung like static—persistent, never quite leaving. Okheman physiology wasn't meant for this kind of isolation; their species thrived on shared resonance, on proximity, on emotional exchange. Yet somehow, Phainon and Castorice held steady—stronger than most, or maybe just too stubborn to admit weakness.

Still, strength had limits.

Castorice started dreaming again—strange, vivid things. Voices like Tribbie's, slowed down and layered, like hearing an echo underwater. Once, she woke up to find her console already on, data logs open to harmonic readings she didn't remember pulling.

She didn't tell Phainon until days later. She knew he'd only make light of it to comfort her, and she didn't want to hear him sound worried.

His shift came.

Phainon sat alone on the dim bridge, the ship's systems whispering around him, every pulse half a beat behind itself. He'd gotten used to the rhythm—the mechanical heartbeat of the ship syncing with the slow shimmers.

He caught himself humming again, absently. The tune slipped into that same uneven pattern Tribbie had been using for days.

He rubbed his eyes. "I'm losing it."

"You're not," Tribbie said brightly.

He looked up. "Did I say that out loud?"

"Of course." Then, a beat later—same tone, same voice—

"Of course."

He stared. "…You're doing it again."

"Doing what?"

"The repeat."

Tribbie tilted her head. "I'm not."

He sighed. "Right."

The data feed rolled endlessly across his console—energy spectrums, resonance graphs, harmonic fluctuations. All noise, until it wasn’t.

Near the bottom of the latest sequence, something subtle emerged: a low-frequency pulse buried beneath main signature.

Too deliberate to be natural. The intervals followed half-beat rhythms—almost syllabic, almost speech.

He watched the waveform repeat. Then shift. Then pause, like it was waiting for him to notice.

Phainon leaned forward, isolating the frequency through three filters. The pattern persisted in each one—then, faintly, it echoed itself.

Not an error. A response.

“Castorice,” he murmured, opening the comm.

Static met him first—a slow hiss, like breath. Then her voice, hazy with exhaustion. “You’re up early.”

“It’s late. Or… was.” He pinched his eyes shut.

“What’s wrong?”

“I think it’s talking.”

A pause. “Don’t start.”

“I’m serious. Look at the last packet.”

“I’m looking.” Her voice hardened. “It’s feedback. Harmonic interference.”

“Then why does it pause when I stop looking at it?”

“That’s not possible.”

He smiled faintly. “Neither’s condensation on heat panels, but here we are.”

His head throbbed—sharp, rhythmic. He pressed a hand to his temple, eyes watering a little from the pressure. “Six-hour mark just passed. I’ll initiate the next call once the feed stabilizes.”

“Phainon—”

“Relax. I’m fine.”

He wasn’t, but it was easier to lie when she couldn’t see him.

He reached across the console, eyes half closed, and for a brief moment, the outside pulsed in sync with his headache—slow, insistent. The reflection in the viewport shifted a second behind him.

He didn’t notice.

The console’s light bloomed across the room.

“Establishing link,” Tribbie said.

Then again, perfectly mirrored—

“Establishing link.”

He ignored it.

Phainon stared at her display, exhaling through his teeth. “Right. Let’s keep it to one version of you tonight, yeah?”

He tapped the comm node, adjusting the frequency. “Channel four-three, Hephaestion relay. Let’s make sure you haven’t drifted into another dead zone again, old man.”

Tribbie’s face screen lit in bright sequence. “Transmission verified! Stabilizing, stabilizing—”

“Variance at one-point-two percent,” Phainon finished, leaning back in his chair. “You’re starting to sound like me.”

He checked the time—six hours late. The ache behind his temple had turned dull and constant. He rubbed at it absently, eyes flicking up to the viewport again.

The transmission wave rippled outward from the console, spreading rings of light across the deck floor.

Phainon frowned, head tilting. “That’s new. Usually, they at least start with a ‘copy received.’”

“Transmission stable,” Tribbie announced brightly. Then, a half-second later: “Transmission stable.”

The delay was wrong enough to make Phainon glance at her. Her display had flickered—not an error exactly, but as if her code was trying to decide what part of her should be speaking.

“Tribbie, are you—”

“Perfectly operational!” she replied, then blinked, softer. “Perfectly… operational.”

Phainon blinked, concerned.

Footsteps padded behind him—Castorice, hair slightly mussed from her shift rest, datapad tucked under one arm. “Still no response?”

He gave a one-shouldered shrug. “Either the Detachment’s ignoring me again or the environment decided to start screening my calls.”

She leaned against the console. “Bandwidth interference?”

“Already compensated.” He ran another diagnostic just to humor her. The feedback graph jumped, stuttered, and flattened back into a line that didn’t make sense. “Feels like something’s talking back,” he said finally. “Just… not in the right order.”

Before Castorice could answer, the sound shifted. The static hollowed out, the hum of the ship going eerily still for a half-second before a voice broke through—bent, wet, and too close to the ear.

[“…out of…here… alert…”]

Phainon blinked. “Hephaestion?”

The voice warped again, syllables stretching, overlapping.

[“…out—of—here—alert—”]

Castorice straightened, her tone edged with alert focus now. “Playback.”

Tribbie’s display dimmed to gray, then brightened again—confused. “Playback. Playback.” Pause. “No data found.”

Phainon huffed, the sound more nervous than amused. “Selective memory. Great. I’m sure that’s fine.”

Then, abruptly, the feed stabilized.

Light bloomed from the projection core—sharp, too bright. The figures finally resolved: Hephaestion, uniformed, expression taut with urgency, and Perdikkas just behind him, hands moving across unseen controls.

Phainon sighed in reflexive relief. “Finally. Signal confirmed. Is something—”

“Envoy, listen to me.” Hephaestion’s tone hit hard, stripped of its usual easy calm. “You need to turn back. Now. That’s an order.”

“An order?” Phainon raised an eyebrow. “You’re not my superior, Hephaestion.”

“*Phainon*.” The way Hephaeston said his name wasn’t friendly—it was strained, breath catching on distortion. “You don’t understand. It’s *in there with you*. Turn the ship—now.”

Castorice stepped closer, frown deepening. “The field hasn’t destabilized. We’re still within safe thresholds. What’s going on?”

Hephaestion’s background flickered—once, twice—like something massive was moving just beyond his feed’s range. “You don’t have time for me to explain.”

The air on the bridge thickened. Phainon’s skin prickled. The hologram shimmered again—its surface distorting inwards, then out, like a breath being taken.

Phainon opened his mouth to ask another question, but the words didn’t make it out. The deck light bent. Everything bent.

He froze mid-motion.

Castorice stiffened beside him, her hand still hovering above the console. Her pupils dilated to near black.

Every empathic panel on the ship ignited—white-red-white—screaming in silent resonance.

Phainon’s body jolted. The air turned solid in his lungs, his neural threads snapping bright behind his eyes. *It hurt.*

The kind of pain that wasn’t pain at all, but something deeper—like every emotion in his system was suddenly on the wrong frequency.

His vision split.

It hurt.

It hurt.

It hurt.

Something was *inside his head*, whispering through the wiring of his mind like it had found a door and didn’t plan on leaving. His throat clenched around a sound that wasn’t human.

Castorice gasped beside him—her body arched, fingers clawing into the console until the metal creaked.

Tribbie's voice fractured into a dozen versions of herself, each speaking over the other—code screaming, mechanical prayers and error strings blurring together.

Hephaestion's voice broke through the static: "Envoy! Status, respond!"

Perdikkas appeared behind him, shouting something indistinct, then sharper: "Neurological feedback loop! But there isn't any aetheroots—get them out of resonance—"

Phainon's knees hit the floor. He didn't remember falling. Every nerve felt inverted, his heartbeat *too loud*, his body trying to tune itself inside out.

Then—everything stopped.

Sound dropped out.

Color followed.

The panels dimmed, the hum flattened, and both Okhemans' biosigns fell to baseline as if nothing had happened at all.

For a few seconds, no one breathed.

Castorice was the first to move, her hands trembling as she lowered them from her temples. "What in the—" Her voice cracked. "What was that?"

Phainon wiped blood from his mouth with the back of his hand, eyes glassy. "That wasn't Okhema's aetheroots."

She blinked at him, still struggling to find words.

The hologram flickered one last time. Perdikkas' voice bled through, fragmented and urgent:

“Resonant trauma leaves traces. If it happens again—don’t suppress it. Find the sou—“

The feed cut.

…

Phainon took a slow breath, exhaled shakily, then looked at Tribbie.

“Tribbie,” he said, “get us out of here. As fast as you can.”

Tribbie’s eyes dimmed to cold blue.

“Understood,” she said quietly.

The ship began to turn.

Outside, the stars shifted—just slightly—like something enormous was watching them leave.

And for the first time since the mission began, Phainon didn’t feel like they were alone.

The hum of the Okhema’s engines had changed again.

“Harmonics are drifting again,” Castorice muttered. She adjusted the sliders one-handed, eyes flicking between two conflicting graphs. “By three hertz this time.”

Phainon looked up from his own screen, chewing on his stylus like the situation was only mildly inconvenient. “Could be atmospheric interference.”

“We’re in a vacuum.”

“Then it’s emotional interference,” he said, deadpan. “The Rift’s feeling temperamental today.”

Castorice shot him a glare over her shoulder. “You joke when things catch fire too.”

“Only after I put them out.”

The banter bought them about six seconds of normalcy before Tribbie’s voice cut in.

“No significant hardware failure detected. However…”

She trailed off, something hitching in the audio feed.

“However?” Phainon prompted, already typing a command string.

“There’s a harmonic echo,” Tribbie said slowly. “A residual waveform inside my auditory sensors. It’s… not registered as mechanical.”

Castorice’s eyes narrowed. “Meaning?”

Tribbie hesitated, and that alone set both Okhemans on edge. “Meaning I heard someone speaking.”

The bridge went very still.

Phainon raised an eyebrow. “Any chance you’re developing taste?”

“I do not *hallucinate*, Captain.”

“Didn’t say you did,” he said easily, but his tone sharpened beneath the drawl. “Run a sweep for ghost frequencies. If something’s piggybacking through the comm band, I want to know where it’s coming from.”

Castorice, meanwhile, was pulling up telemetry data. “Thermal readings are off, too. Condensation on the lower panels again—there shouldn’t *be* water this deep in vacuum.”

He swiveled his chair toward her. “So, we’ve got a haunted humidity problem. Again.”

“Don’t tempt it.”

Before he could reply, the comm line pinged.

“Signal from Kremnos fleet,” Tribbie said. “Origin tag: Leonnius.”

“Patch him through.”

Static hissed. Then a voice filtered in.

[—testing—line—Kremnos main channel four, confirm receipt—]

It looped once. Then again. Each repetition gained a slight distortion, until it sounded like Leonnius was arguing with a slower version of himself.

Castorice’s jaw flexed. “That’s a temporal desync.”

Phainon glanced at her with faint amusement. “And you were worried about humidity.”

The signal fractured, then snapped.

“Tribbie,” Phainon said quietly, “what’s our distance from Kremnos’s forward detachment?”

“Three point seven clicks,” she replied.

He hummed. “Close enough to hear them die if something goes wrong.”

Castorice shot him a look. “You always know what to say.”

“I’m a conversationalist.”

[…gravitational fluctuation detected—Hephaestion—confirm—Mydeimos’s fleet adjusting trajectory—]

Phainon paused. Every muscle stilled at once, like someone had flipped a switch.

Castorice’s gaze darted up. “That was—”

“Mydei,” he said softly, before the channel detonated into white noise.

The ship screamed.

The floor buckled as if something massive had struck it from below. Consoles burst into cascades of red light. Phainon’s hand shot out to stabilize himself against the main control bar while Castorice slammed emergency locks into place.

“Containment fields destabilizing!” she barked. “Tribbie, reroute auxiliary power to the secondaries!”

“I’m—trying—” Tribbie’s voice stuttered, glitched, split into two tones. “Primary systems—cannot—contain—”

“Tribbie!” Phainon snapped.

For a half-second, everything answered at once: alarms, klaxons, metal groaning, and Tribbie’s fragmented voice looping *we are not alone we are not alone* before cutting entirely.

Then the bridge lights dimmed to a sickly amber.

Castorice swallowed hard. “Tell me that wasn’t—”

“A spatial implosion,” Phainon said flatly. “South corridor. Kremnos fleet’s position.”

Tribbie’s voice flickered faintly back online, glitching like a dying echo: “—fleet—signal—lost—”

Phainon slammed a fist on the console. “Open channels!”

Static.

Then, briefly, the ship ID flickered to life.

HEPHAESTION PRIORITY RED

“—protect—command—”

Cut.

Silence hit so hard the air felt wrong.

Castorice grabbed his wrist, steady but urgent. “We can’t reach them, Phainon. They know what they’re doing.”

He looked at her, eyes catching the emergency light like glass.

“Tribbie,” he said quietly. “Can you detect any signal from Kremnos’s main fleet?”

A few seconds passed before her avatar reappeared—corrupted, halo flickering, voice thin as paper. “Residual drive signature detected. Near. Within seven minutes at current speed.”

Castorice hesitated, breath shallow. She didn’t need to ask what he was thinking.

Phainon stood. He typed the override manually—each code string sinking into the board with the finality of a sealed fate.

“Phainon,” she said softly.

He smiled without humor. “Relax. I’m not doing anything heroic.”

“Since when have you ever—”

“Exactly.”

He hit *execute*.

The Okhema’s engines roared, shuddered, then stabilized under his control. The atmosphere caught the hull like a living thing—curling around it, humming in time with the ship’s pulse.

“Well,” Phainon said, leaning back as the stars warped around them. “Looks like we’ve got a princess to save.”

Castorice exhaled a laugh—short, disbelieving, but it steadied her. “You’re unbelievable.”

“Please,” he said, grin lazy even as the alarms continued to blink around them. “I’m efficient.”

The Okhema plunged forward, engines singing, the Rift swallowing their trail whole.

This time the ride wasn’t nearly as bumpy.

And it was twice as easy, if the awaiting pod was to go by.

Castorice flicked a few switches, and the bay lights adjusted to a cool blue. “Trajectory’s calculated. You’ll slingshot past the debris and hit the signal’s gravity pocket dead-center. The pod’s shields will hold, but you’ll feel it.”

“Appreciate the warning.”

She looked up at him. “Your comms will break up the moment you breach the interference zone. You’ll have one sync window, maybe two if you’re lucky. Make it count.”

Phainon gave a crooked smile. “You sound like you’re sending me to confession.”

“Not unless you’ve got something to confess,” she said, reaching for the external clamps. “Pod’s primed.”

He hesitated at the hatch. “Cas.”

She raised a brow.

“If something happens—”

“Then I’ll yell at you when you get back.”

He smiled. “Fair enough.”

She looked at where he was once, before stepping back. “Five minutes, Phainon.”

Castorice’s voice came over comms, slightly distorted already. “See you soon, partner.”

“Yeah,” he said quietly. “See you soon.”

The hatch sealed with a hiss, and the pod launched—violently.

Gravitational surges clawed at the hull, dragging the pod sideways. The metal howled. Warnings flashed across his visor in angry red.

“C’mon,” he muttered through clenched teeth, adjusting the thrusters manually. “Stay with me.”

A wave of debris spun past—shattered hull fragments, wiring, shards of armor plating. For a second, he thought he saw something moving among them, a flicker of rocks shaped like a hand. Then it was gone.

The beacon pulsed again. Closer now.

Then impact.

The pod slammed into solid mass with enough force to knock the breath out of him. The harness caught, the shock absorbers screamed. Systems flickered, then steadied.

Silence.

For a long moment, the only sound was his breathing.

Then, one by one, the pod’s internal lights flickered back on. The hatch hissed open, releasing a curl of vapor into the dim, fractured glow beyond.

Phainon unlatched himself, stood, and stepped out into the wreck.

Cold air. Silence.

And then he started walking.

Or at least, something close enough to walking. The deck no longer deserved the title—half-bent plating, half-liquefied conduits, all of it groaning in slow, metallic protest. The gravity field flickered every few seconds, switching between syrup-thick and moonlight-thin, tugging at him like an invisible hand unsure whether to pull or let go. Every other step sent him floating half a meter off the ground before slamming him back down hard enough to rattle his teeth.

The wreck was silent in that way that screamed.

His breath fogged faintly in his visor. The air was thin but technically breathable, or at least survivable if you were built like an Okheman. He could feel it scraping at his throat, sharp and electric, the oxygen thinned out to the point it tasted metallic. His lungs burned, but his body compensated on instinct.

Okheman biology had been built—literally—for places like this. Their blood carried a network of adaptive myceles: living micro-filaments that could snatch stray oxygen ions out of air so thin it might as well not be there. The process wasn't pleasant; it left a faint chemical sting behind the eyes, a ghost taste of rust and copper. Still, it was better than suffocating.

The suit's biosensors pulsed faintly along his forearms, syncing with his bloodstream's rhythm. He could almost feel the myceles working—cool, relentless. Okhema had evolved for emotionsand endurance, for surviving the voids between systems where no one else would bother going.

"Yeah," he muttered under his breath, "real evolutionary masterpiece. Shame it doesn't help with claustrophobia."

He checked his wrist display—a soft glow, fractured by dust. The beacon's pulse trembled across it, weak but rhythmic. Okhema's tracking tech

worked off resonance mapping: not location, but *impression*. Each Okheman carried a trace field around them, a sort of quantum echo in their biofrequency. The system could read that—translate it, even amplify it—but Mydei wasn't Okheman.

The only reason Phainon could feel him at all was the link-band Mydei had worn, an Okheman-made device meant to sync heartbeat data across distances. Mydei had kept it on, half because he had to, half because Phainon had forced him to.

It was that band—the most ridiculous kind of sentimental tech—that was now saving Mydei's life.

Phainon slowed to a stop, closed his eyes, and let the link hum against his ribs. The resonance was faint but familiar, warm, flickering like candlelight in water.

"Got you," he said softly.

He started to move again, faster now, navigating through the ribs of the wreck. The deeper he went, the redder everything became—the emergency lights pulsing in slow, uneven rhythm, echoing the ship's death throes.

A warped bulkhead loomed ahead, torn open like the ribs of a carcass. He squeezed through, wincing as the edges scraped against him. Inside, the corridor narrowed. Every sound was too close. The air carried a faint crackle of electricity.

Something moved at the edge of his vision. A shape. A trick. Or maybe not.

He froze. Listened. Nothing.

"Yeah, no, definitely not haunted," he muttered, voice dry. "Just cursed. Totally different classification."

He ducked beneath a collapsed beam, boot catching briefly on something slick. A pool of hydraulic fluid glimmered beneath his step, violet and shimmering under the emergency red.

The marks along the walls had also changed the further in he went. No longer burn damage or pressure tears—these were grown. Thin, crystalline etchings cut through the hull, spreading in fractal patterns, glimmering faintly with internal light. They crawled upward like veins.

He touched one experimentally, and his glove sensors pinged low-level energy—unstable but active.

“Castorice would’ve told me not to touch that,” he muttered. Then, quieter, “She’s probably right.”

The beacon’s signal grew stronger, pulsing faster now, in time with his own heart. Mydei was close—he could feel it in the resonance building beneath his skin. The Okheman trait kicked in, that biological matrix that allowed their nervous systems to attune to another’s frequency. It guided him through the wreck like a compass made of intuition.

He broke into a sprint. Carefully, at first—measured steps, pushing off walls where gravity faltered, sliding across uneven plating when it returned. Then faster.

The corridor widened suddenly into a half-collapsed hangar bay. Red dust floated through the air in sheets, catching the faint glow of sparking conduits. The beacon’s pulse was deafening in his ears now, a steady rhythm that wrapped around his heartbeat like a double helix.

“Mydei,” he breathed. “I’ve got you.”

He vaulted a fallen girder, hit the ground hard, and kept going. The hum beneath his skin rose higher, until it wasn’t just sound anymore—it was presence, warmth, the distinct shape of someone alive and scared and *waiting*.

And then it happened.

The wall to his right didn’t just give way—it *burst*.

A sound like shattering glass mixed with thunder tore through the hangar. A plume of red crystals exploded outward, jagged and violent, slicing through the air in a fan of light. One shard missed his head by less than an inch, embedding itself in the console behind him with a sound like frozen lightning.

The blast hit him a second later. He was thrown backward, rolling across the deck until his shoulder slammed against a pipe. His visor flickered and the world was a mess of crimson and drifting debris.

The crystals pulsed faintly, their veins glowing brighter with each beat, like they were breathing.

Phainon staggered upright, blinking hard. The beacon on his wrist was gone —no, not gone, but consumed, its signal pouring out from the heart of the crystalline bloom.

He stared, realization sinking in slow and cold.

"…Shit."

The beacon's frequency wasn't just close to the crystals—it was *inside* them. The same pulse. The same rhythm.

The signal he'd been following—the heartbeat he'd been chasing—was coming directly from the core of the growth.

From *inside* the red.

He stood frozen, chest heaving, the red washing over him. Somewhere deep within the crystal mass, there was a heartbeat. Faint but undeniable.

Phainon had the distinct, stomach-turning sense that the wreck wasn't dead at all—

—it was *living*.

Phainon bit down hard, the copper sting of blood spreading across his tongue. He ignored the pain and kept moving. The once-metal walls had

been swallowed whole by red crystal growths that pulsed like veins under a thin layer of flesh.

The glow painted everything in slow, viscous color, each reflection a distorted image of himself walking deeper.

He turned a corner and stopped.

The crystals had devoured the room's structure completely, sprouting upward in jagged pillars and sweeping arcs, refracting the dim emergency lights into red storms across the walls.

And right at the center, at the eye of the storm, was the source.

Phainon's breath caught. For one impossible second, he thought the beacon had cracked open and become light itself—but then his eyes adjusted, and he saw him.

Mydei.

Or what was left of him.

He was encased within the crystal bloom—his entire body caught mid-motion, one hand half-raised, face turned slightly toward the floor, as if reaching for something. The red crystal had formed around him, not as imprisonment, but as… protection. Each shard curved along the lines of his body like frozen flame.

Phainon's jaw slackened. He took one shaky step forward, then another.

Was the crystal keeping him alive? Or feeding on him?

He reached out, gloved fingers brushing the crystal surface. It was warmer than it should've been—almost soft under the armor. A faint hum vibrated through his bones, harmonizing with his own heartbeat in a way that was *wrongly familiar.*

"Mydei…" His voice cracked, barely a whisper. "Hey, it's me. You can stop hiding now."

The crystal didn’t move.

He swallowed, flicked his wrist, and the plasma cutter flared to life. The blue flame reflected off the red crystal, tinting everything a molten purple. He aimed it carefully, exhaled, and cut.

The scream that followed wasn’t normal. It sounded almost alive—like the crystal itself crying out in protest.

Phainon winced, teeth grit as the vibrations rattled through his skull. Shards flew like molten snow, burning through the air. The heat pressed against him from all sides, and the oxygen readout on his display began to dip faster than he liked.

“Come on, come on—”

Another cut. The crystal resisted every strike, mending itself in slow waves.

“Fine,” he muttered, kicking free a length of cable from the wall. He twisted it between his hands, rigging it with the flick of his wrist, sparks snapping in the air. The arc torch hissed to life, white and angry, and this time when he struck the crystal, it bled. Cracks spidered outward, glowing bright enough to burn through his visor filters.

The crystal’s hum changed pitch—from low to something jagged, desperate. A piece fractured and fell, revealing the curve of Mydei’s face beneath.

He was beautiful.

Too beautiful for this place.

And that, somehow, startled Phainon more than anything else.

He kept going, ignoring the sudden sting along his arm where a flying shard had sliced through the plating. It buried itself. His blood—golden and iridescent—seeped into the inside of the suit, tracing a slow line toward his wrist. He bit back a hiss, forced himself to keep working.

He didn’t care.

He couldn’t.

Not when he was so close.

The final crack split the air with a sound like thunder underwater. The light within the crystal shuddered, then collapsed inward, releasing a burst of red vapor and sound. Mydei fell forward into his arms.

Phainon staggered back, the weight nearly knocking him over.

The crystals dimmed, their glow flickering like dying embers.

Mydei was cold—too cold—and still covered in a fine dusting of red crystal dust that shimmered faintly along his skin. His pulse, when Phainon pressed two trembling fingers to his neck, was there. Faint. Steady.

Alive.

He laughed, a short, breathless sound that bordered on delirium. “You damn bastard. You just had to make me work for it.”

He shifted Mydei’s weight, ignoring the protest of his injured shoulder. He slung Mydei’s arm around his neck, half-carrying, half-dragging him toward the nearest stable corridor.

“Castorice,” he rasped into the comm, using up his only call, voice breaking slightly, “I’m finished. Pick me up at—hangar deck, lower quadrant, now.”

The signal flickered in and out, fragments of her voice stuttering through: “—Phainon—do you—copy—what’s your—status—”

“Just get me out,” he said sharply, still moving.

And then—Mydei shifted.

Phainon stopped mid-step, eyes snapping down. Mydei’s fingers twitched, brushing faintly against his suit. He blinked once, slow, lashes catching

what little light was left. Phainon nearly dropped him.

“Mydei?” The name came out strangled, half a plea. He lowered them both to the ground, sliding to his knees. “Hey, look at me. You’re okay. You’re—Gods, you’re okay, I got you. Just stay still, alright? We’re getting out of here, I promise.”

He brushed a thumb across Mydei’s cheek without thinking, tracing the faint shimmer of dust that still clung to his skin.

For a moment, Mydei looked at him. Really looked—eyes weakly opened, golden, almost too bright. Something moved behind them, a flicker of confusion or memory or nothing at all.

And then he spoke.

“…Who,” he murmured, voice hollow and distant, “are you?”

Everything stopped.

…

What?

Phainon’s mind emptied all at once—the background hum of the ship, the smell of metal and ozone, the pulsing red glow—they all receded into nothing. He was aware of his heartbeat only distantly, a dull, slow echo behind glass. His thoughts didn’t move. They didn’t even exist.

He stared at Mydei’s face—the same face he’d memorized, dreamed about, killed for—and saw no recognition. No warmth. Not even faint curiosity. Just that hollow confusion, sharp enough to cut him open.

The sound in his ears went dull, replaced by a faint high-pitched ring. He was distantly aware of his breathing—too shallow, too fast—and of Castorice’s voice breaking through the comm, words warped by glitching:

“Phainon—status—if you can hear me, proceed to extraction—don’t linger—repeat, do not linger—”

He didn’t move. His fingers twitched once against Mydei’s sleeve, then stilled.

When he finally spoke, it was automatic. His lips moved before his mind caught up.

“…You defected with me from Castrum Kremnos,” he said softly, almost dazed. “You said you wanted peace.”

The words didn’t sound like him. They sounded rehearsed.

The crystals along the walls flickered faintly, pulsing once in response. As if listening.

Phainon didn’t notice. He just kept looking at Mydei, at those gold eyes that looked back through him like he was no one at all.

And for the first time, he wasn’t sure if he was.

The skies of Elyon-7 were always gold.

The soft, syrupy kind specifically—the kind that made everything below shimmer as though dipped in honey. Two suns hung lazily overhead, taking turns warming the horizon in a choreography so smooth it was rehearsed. The winds here didn’t howl or race; they strolled. Even time seemed to move slower, basking in its own reflection.

Welcome to Elyon-7, the crown jewel of the Okhema colonies—where stress is a myth and taxes are somebody else’s problem!

Come bask in our eternal daylight, sip gravity-light cocktails on our sky-terraces, and let our patented *WeatherMod™ system* guarantee you’ll never, ever experience an inconvenient breeze again. Relax in our famed *weightless lagoons*—now with ninety-nine percent fewer jellyfish—and enjoy our all-inclusive, interstellar-award-winning hospitality!

Looking for romance? We have it.

Looking for enlightenment? Simulated.

Looking for an affordable stay? …We have romance and enlightenment.

Here on Elyon-7, the suns never set, the drinks never end, and the only thing deeper than the cloud seas… is your credit debt.

Elyon-7: *Where the universe takes a breath—and your wallet takes a vacation!*

There was a brief pause in the ad's music—an almost reverent moment to let the promise of perfection sink in—

—followed immediately by a loud, distinctly real groan.

A head hit a table with a soft *thunk*.

"Shut *up*," Phainon muttered into the surface, muffled, his voice breaking the serene background track.

The holo-display sputtered mid-sentence, as if startled, before cutting out altogether.

The camera—or perhaps just fate—panned out from the glossy brochure fantasy to something smaller, and infinitely less marketed: a sun-bleached café perched on a floating dock, its metal rails warm from the afternoon light. Below, an ocean of clouds stretched forever, slow currents rolling in golden waves. Cruises drifted lazily in the distance, birds flying about.

The air smelled faintly of salt as a parasol fluttered overhead. Somewhere, a drone waiter whirred softly by, chirping an automated "*Enjoy your day under the twin suns!*" before continuing its route.

Across the table, Castorice sipped from her glass, watching the horizon without much interest. The condensation slipped lazily down her drink, catching the light in miniature rainbows.

"Lovely day," she said mildly.

Phainon didn’t move, cheek still pressed to the table. “Mm-hmm. Lovely.”

A long breeze drifted by, warm and patient, carrying with it the faint echo of the ad’s last jingle:

Elyon-7… Elyon-7… Elyon-7…

Somewhere out there, the perfect world kept spinning.

Here, two people were just trying to forget why they’d landed on it.

The ship had been grounded for “post-mission maintenance,” as Castorice so politely phrased it. In reality, it was more like being benched. The vessel hung suspended over Elyon-7’s stratosphere docks 2 hours from here, surrounded by a halo of repair drones and diagnostic lights flickering like lazy fireflies. Its engines had purred at idle—recovering, recalibrating, and, according to Castorice, “learning to breathe again.”

“Breathe,” she’d said.

Which, somehow, had turned into *“sit in public and pretend everything’s perfectly fine.”*

So now Phainon sat across from her at a café suspended on a glass terrace above the clouds. The deck was built around a sprawling synth-tree, its silver leaves rustling in the filtered wind that carried a faint trace of burnt sugar from somewhere around.

Phainon pretended to study the view, then pretended harder not to. His eyes eventually landed on Castorice’s drink—some fancy mineral brew, crystalline blue and faintly shimmering. It sat untouched, perfect, and cold.

He coughed once. Adjusted his sleeve. Coughed again.

“Well,” he said finally, voice a little too casual to be accidental. “What good weather we’re having today, huh?”

Castorice’s gaze lifted from her cup with the slow precision of a targeting system.

“Are we going to address the elephant in the room?”

Phainon looked around, scanning the surrounding tables. A family of tourists, two dockhands, a server drone. No pachyderms.

“I don’t see any elephants,” he said.

Castorice exhaled, set her glass down, and leaned forward, sunlight glinting off the insignia on her uniform. “You know what I mean, Phainon.”

He pursed his lips, tilting his head like a confused puppy. “Elaborate, please.”

Something twitched in her eye. Subtle, restrained, but deadly—a small rebellion in the face of her usual composure. Sweet, measured, endlessly patient Castorice looked seconds away from discovering a new form of homicide.

Phainon, entirely unaware—or pretending spectacularly well—leaned back, his chair creaking under the lazy stretch.

If patience was a virtue, then Castorice was rapidly ascending toward sainthood.

“You know how a *Kremnoan Commander*—a *Commander*, Phainon—is currently resting back on our ship, dead asleep, and from what you’ve told me, has forgotten all his memories?”

Phainon’s smile faltered like a ship losing power. “…Vaguely.”

Her lashes lowered, the slow blink of a woman choosing diplomacy over strangulation. “And you lied to him. You told him he defected with you. From Kremnos. When you’re not even *Kremnoan*.”

He rubbed the back of his neck, a sheepish wince tugging at his mouth. “Technically, you’re making it sound worse than it is.”

“Phainon,” she said flatly, “that’s literally treason on three different levels of jurisdiction.”

He paused, opened his mouth, and then shut it again. For a man usually armed with a quip at all times, the silence was almost impressive.

It wasn’t the first time Castorice had been left to sweep up the cosmic debris of one of his “spontaneous judgment calls.” Still, this one set a new record.

Her mind flickered back, unbidden. The wreckage had still been burning when she arrived—red dust in the air, metal warped into grotesque shapes. The silence had that eerie, hollow kind that only came after chaos, when even sound was too stunned to return. And then, through the haze—him.

Phainon.

Dragging himself through the debris, shirt torn, one arm hanging uselessly at his side, and in the other—someone.

A man. Insignia glinting faintly beneath the grime.

A Kremnoan Commander.

She’d frozen, long enough to think her sensors were malfunctioning. Then he stumbled closer, soot-streaked and grimy, cradling the Commander like a man carrying something breakable.

“Imagine my surprise,” she murmured now, mostly to herself.

He’d barely made it to the extraction point before collapsing to one knee. His hand had been shaking when he finally looked at her and said, hoarse and bewildered, “*He doesn’t remember anything*.” Then he’d placed the man down with such care it almost looked reverent.

That had been two weeks ago. Two very long, very strange weeks.

Now, Castorice tilted her glass and watched the brew catch the sunlight. “I ran half a dozen scans,” she said finally. “No neural trauma, no decay, no cybernetic corrosion. His memory chain isn’t damaged—it’s *gone*. Erased clean. And your response to that was to tell him he defected with you.”

Phainon hunched slightly, shoulders drawing in like maybe that would make him smaller. “You say it like I had time to draft a report. You saw his face—he didn’t even know his own name. What was I supposed to do? Tell him, ‘Hi, I’m the idiot who found you encased in glowing red crystal—also, your empire might be planning your memorial service as we speak?’”

Castorice’s brow creased. “You could’ve said literally *anything* else.”

He raised a hand. “Could’ve. Didn’t.”

She inhaled through her nose. The faintest twitch crossed her jaw before she muttered, “You’re unbelievable.”

There was no heat behind it. Just that weary, patient tone of someone too tired to even scold anymore.

Phainon exhaled, slouching back into his chair, his expression somewhere between guilt and stubborn pride.

“Yeah,” he murmured, almost ruefully. “So I’ve been told.”

Castorice’s tone shifted, the edge of humor bleeding out.

“Jokes aside,” she said quietly. “The situation’s worse than we thought.”

Phainon looked up, the change in her voice enough to pull him upright.

She turned her glass in her hand as she spoke. “Setting aside that disaster for now… we’ve lost all contact with the other original ships. Every single one. The entire Kremnoan detachment’s gone dark.”

Phainon blinked. “All of them?”

“All of them,” she confirmed, still not meeting his eyes. “We’ve run full-range pings for three cycles—nothing. No beacons, no relay noise, not even residual jump static.” Her expression tightened. “It’s like they were erased mid-transit.”

He stared at her, trying to piece it together. “That’s—” He stopped. “That’s impossible.”

She finally looked up. “Which means we have to assume that—”

“No.” His response was sharp enough to cut the air between them. His shoulders squared, jaw set. “That’s not possible.”

“Phainon—”

“They’re not dead,” he snapped before she could finish. “They wouldn’t go out like that.” His hand curled against the table, knuckles white. “I didn’t know them—not personally—but I *know* they wouldn’t—”

“Phainon.”

The word landed softly, but it stopped him anyway.

He didn’t meet her eyes. His gaze had gone somewhere far away—past the table, past the glass, into the cold dark part of space.

Castorice watched him a long moment, then sighed. “I don’t want to believe it either. But the data’s clean. The blackout’s absolute—no trace, no interference, nothing. The entire fleet just vanished off the grid.” She leaned back. “Whatever happened out there, it wasn’t a skirmish.”

Phainon’s jaw worked. “Then we find out what it is.”

“That’s assuming we have the clearance to even *look*,” she said.

He turned to her fully now. “Since when has that stopped us?”

A faint, humorless smile tugged at her lips. “Touché.”

Phainon said, quieter this time, “They’re not gone.”

Castorice didn’t argue. She just looked at him once, long enough for him to notice the faint tremor of something behind her calm.

She didn’t agree—but she didn’t deny him that hope, either.

Her silence was mercy.

“Never mind,” she murmured, half to herself. “I’ll contact Aglaea about this. She’s probably worried sick by now. We were sent on a high-risk mission, and with Kremnos gone dark, there’s no telling what kind of reports are circulating. She’s either tearing through the galaxy looking for us or already convinced we didn’t make it back.”

The thought of Aglaea pacing somewhere on Okhema’s central deck, waiting for a transmission that might never come, seemed to weigh on her.

Castorice rubbed a hand across her face, fatigue showing in the slight tremor of her fingers. “Once the refit’s done, we’ll head out again,” she said finally. “Assuming the Council doesn’t ground us for questioning first.”

Phainon hesitated. “About that…”

Her brows lifted slightly, a warning and an invitation all in one. He didn’t immediately answer.

Because before he could, that image came back—the look on Mydei’s face, the hollow confusion when he said it: *Who are you?*

The words echoed in his head.

He swallowed and forced his voice steady. “Just… give me a few weeks.”

Castorice’s tone cooled a notch. “A few weeks for what?”

“Before we file the report. Before Aglaea hears anything. Let me handle this, Castorice.”

She blinked at him. “Handle *what*, exactly?”

“Everything,” he said. “The fallout, the Council, Okhema’s oversight committee—whatever comes from this. Just give me the time to figure it out.”

“Phainon—”

“If there’s fallout,” he pressed, “I’ll take it. All of it. You can say I went off-record, that you didn’t know. Aglaea can strip me of rank, toss me out an airlock for all I care—but just… give me the time. Please.”

Castorice’s eyes narrowed, but there was something almost wounded in her expression too. “Do you realize what you’re asking?” she said softly. “We were nearly killed out there, Phainon. Do you really think I can sit on my hands while everyone assumes we’re dead?”

“Not assume,” he said quietly. “Hope.”

The word caught her off guard.

The ad drone beeped faintly in the background, the low drone of refit systems washing over them. Finally, Castorice let out a tired breath, closing her eyes.

“You’ve got one month,” she said. “After that, I’m reporting everything. Don’t make me regret it.”

Phainon felt the air loosen around him for the first time in hours. “Thank you, Cas—”

A sharp chime split through the air, interrupting him.

Both turned toward the sound. The comm interface blinked amber on Castorice’s wrist display, pulsing with an incoming call.

She frowned and checked the ID. “It’s Trinnon.”

Phainon slumped back into his seat, a laugh breaking loose. “Oh, thank the stars. For a second I thought it was Aglaea.” He reached for his drink again, grinning. “Go ahead, patch her through.”

Castorice accepted the call, the display flickering to life and stabilizing into Trinnon’s small, nervous avatar.

“Trinnon!” Phainon leaned forward, his grin widening. “You’re back online! That’s a relief. How are systems looking? Looks like the engineers actually earned their pay for once.”

The avatar flickered once. “We—uh—we are… stable,” Trinnon said, voice stuttering the way it always did when she was nervous. “Reboot sequence is seventy-eight percent complete. Tribbie and Trianne are… um… coming online shortly.”

“Good, good,” Phainon said, leaning back, clearly pleased. “Tell them I’ll run a calibration check myself once—”

Trinnon’s voice glitched, a flicker slicing through her words. “Captain—there’s—uh—we—uh—”

He frowned, setting his glass down. “Trinnon, slow down. What’s wrong?”

The hologram jittered once, the signal stabilizing just long enough for her voice to come through clear—louder, higher than he’d ever heard it.

“It’s that man!” she blurted. “He’s awake!”

For a heartbeat, the words didn’t register.

Then, simultaneously, both Phainon and Castorice froze.

His drink hung halfway to his mouth. Her hand hovered midair over the call.

And then—perfectly synchronized—they both choked.

“Shit.”

Well, after traumatizing a poor skycrawler pilot into driving three-quarters of the way there—and then running the last quarter on foot because somehow, *somehow*, the damn thing decided to sputter, spin, and die mid-flight—they made it back to the ship in record timing.

It wasn’t a graceful return. Castorice looked like she’d been personally hunted by a windstorm, one boot scuffed, the other half undone. Phainon’s coat had caught on something during the sprint, one sleeve torn clean off and dangling from his wrist by a few loose threads. He didn’t even bother trying to fix it.

They stood there for a moment, panting, staring up at the gleaming hull—their ship, their beautiful, broken, half-disassembled ship—as if sheer willpower could make the hangar doors open.

The universe, unfortunately, remained unimpressed.

The docking platform was a disaster zone of repair drones, stray welding sparks, and people shouting orders over the clamor of machinery. The hull plating was half-peeled open for diagnostics, the engine core sat exposed like a beating heart mid-surgery, and the ship’s comm line repeated its cheerful automated message on loop:

“Maintenance in progress. Access restricted. Please contact your assigned dock officer—”

Castorice pinched the bridge of her nose, muttered something unprintable, then snapped, “Just open the damn hangar.”

There was a stunned pause. Then, against all odds, the system chirped an affirmative tone. The massive doors rumbled open.

Phainon blinked. “You know, one of these days, you’re going to yell at the wrong AI and it’s going to actually *explode*.”

She didn’t even dignify that with a response.

A barely restrained argument followed—with two engineers, a flustered dock manager, and one very nervous safety officer—before they were finally granted entry. By the time the airlock hissed open, both of them were out of breath again, leaning forward, hands braced on their knees.

“Next time,” Phainon said between breaths, “we’re requisitioning a proper transport. Preferably one that doesn’t fall apart when it sees a storm cloud.”

Castorice let out a sharp exhale that was halfway between a laugh and a groan. “Next time, you’re *flying*.”

“That’s the plan,” he muttered, straightening.

Her eyes swept the dim corridor ahead—wires hanging from the ceiling, the hum of auxiliary systems running low. She adjusted her gloves, already shifting back into that crisp tone of hers. “We’ll cover more ground if we split. You take the lower decks; I’ll sweep the maintenance wing.”

“Fine,” Phainon said, already moving before she’d finished. He didn’t even wait for the airlock to finish decompressing before slipping through, the metallic hiss fading behind him as he disappeared into the corridor’s low light.

Castorice watched him go, one brow twitching.

“Kephale help me,” she muttered, before setting off in the opposite direction.

What a great day it was shaping up to be.

Phainon took the lower decks, his boots echoing against the grating with a rhythm too steady to match his thoughts. The air down here was cooler. It should’ve been grounding. It wasn’t.

He tried not to think about why Trinnon had said. Tried not to replay that trembling cry over and over in his head: *He’s awake.*

The words wouldn’t leave him.

He should’ve felt relief. That’s what any sane person would feel—someone survived, someone woke up, end of story. But instead, there was this awful tangle sitting under his ribs.

Because if he was being honest to himself, Mydeimos had never liked him much. Barely tolerated him on the best of days. And still, Phainon had followed him—too closely, too often. He told himself it was because Mydei was brilliant, indispensable, someone the others relied on. But that wasn't the whole story, was it?

His flashlight flicked across the corridor walls, light catching on wires and dust motes.

What the hell was he supposed to say to him now? "Sorry about that, Mydei, I panicked"? As if Mydeimos wouldn't immediately see through it. He could already picture it: that silent, assessing look, the faint twitch of disdain at the corner of his mouth before he turned away again.

And yet, the idea of facing that expression again made Phainon's chest feel tight.

He stopped at a sealed door, the handle cold beneath his glove. Nothing but noise from the internal machines.

He sighed and moved on.

"Nothing… empty… empty…"

Every door he passed hissed open at his approach, and every time it revealed the same thing. Untouched consoles. Half-sealed storage crates. Air so still it might've been frozen.

He frowned.

His footsteps thudded evenly against the deck plating, the rhythm steady enough to keep him anchored.

He's awake.

He pressed the heel of his hand to his brow. *Not thinking about it.*

Noise flared softly in his ear. Castorice's voice followed, clear and clipped. "No signs of forced entry here either. Are you sure Trinnon's readings are

accurate?”

“Trinnon doesn’t panic for no reason,” Phainon said. He crouched to check a maintenance panel. “If she said something’s here, something’s here.”

“Could be a feedback loop. The sensors have been touchy since the refit—”

“Castorice.” His tone flattened. “You heard her voice.”

A pause. Then, softer, “…Yeah. I did.”

He stood, scanning the ceiling ducts, the ventilation grid. “Just stay alert. If she’s right, maybe he’d already left—”

A sound sliced through the comm.

High-pitched. Distant. The kind of sound that didn’t belong anywhere near a ship.

Castorice’s voice vanished. All that remained was that noise—half mechanical, half human. Then it came again, higher, clearer this time.

A scream.

Trinnon’s.

Phainon froze. The beam of his light jerked upward, as if he could pinpoint it through sheer will alone. The sound had come from above—Castorice’s level.

“Castorice?” he barked, already turning toward the nearest liftwell. “Trinnon?”

The comm spat. Then a voice—small, broken, barely coherent.

“W-we—we didn’t mean to—he just—!”

The line cut.

Silence.

Phainon’s pulse dropped into his stomach, cold and heavy. Then came the heat—the rush that overtook everything else.

“Fuck.”

He broke into a run.

The corridor became a blur of flickering amber lights and the pounding in his chest. He nearly slipped on the grated floor as he rounded the first corner, one hand catching the wall for balance, the other fumbling for his comm controls—dead, nothing but whir noise.

He kept running.

“Trinnon! Castorice!” His voice bounced uselessly off the metal bulkheads. No answer.

He took the ladder two rungs at a time, his hands burning against the cold bars.

“Come on, come on…”

The ship groaned around him as he reached the next deck, the lights stuttering overhead. Somewhere ahead, a muffled thud. Then another. Fabric tearing. The scrape of boots against the floor.

He broke into a sprint again, lungs burning. Each step echoed louder until the hallway funneled into a narrower passage choked with fallen debris. He shoved it aside, heartbeat rising to match the rhythmic clang, clang, clang ahead of him.

“Castorice!” he shouted, rounding the final bend.

And then something *slammed* into him.

The impact hit hard enough to knock the air from his lungs. The world snapped sideways. They hit the grating floor with a crash that sent pain

spiraling through his ribs. His flashlight spun away, clattering across the metal.

Instinct took over. He twisted, grabbing at his attacker’s arm, his other hand snapping up to brace against their shoulder. They were strong—shockingly strong. His grip slipped as a forearm pressed down on his chest, pinning him.

“Get—off—” He braced his knee, ready to throw his weight—

Then he saw them.

Eyes.

Brilliant, burning gold that caught the flickering light and turned it molten.

Everything froze. The noise, the pain, the air in his lungs—gone, replaced by that single, impossible detail.

Those eyes.

He knew them.

He’d memorized them once, traced their light like something sacred.

The figure above him hovered in the half-light, breath ragged, expression unreadable—but those eyes blazed through everything else. Familiar. Furious. Alive.

“My—” The name stuck in his throat, barely forming.

The person’s grip faltered for half a second—enough time for the recognition to cut both ways.

Mydeimos.

The word slammed through Phainon’s mind with all the weight of the world.

And the look Mydei gave him said everything before either of them could speak.

For a moment, everything hung still.

Then, from above him, a voice—rough, scraped raw.

“Where am I.”

The sound didn’t even seem human at first. It was low, uneven, guttural, like he was teaching his lungs to work again. The words dragged as though they didn’t fit right in his mouth.

Phainon’s pulse tripped. He didn’t answer. Couldn’t.

Mydei’s chest rose and fell in shallow bursts, muscles tight, every inch of him strung like a live wire. His hair was damp, plastered unevenly against his forehead; his medbay clothes hung half-open, a patchwork of torn seams and clinging fabric. Bare feet against the grating, half-wrapped wrists. He looked more animal than man—sharp, cornered, dangerous.

And yet, somehow, painfully familiar.

“Mydei…” Phainon’s voice barely came out.

The reaction was immediate. Mydei’s head snapped toward him, teeth still bared, gold eyes flashing under the cold lights. For a heartbeat, Phainon swore Mydei was gonna kill him.

Footsteps echoed in the distance—quick, urgent—but Mydei didn’t turn. He didn’t even glance that way. His entire focus stayed pinned on Phainon, like nothing else existed outside the space between them.

Something flickered in his expression—too quick to place. Not recognition exactly, but something that almost resembled it. His snarl faltered, confusion creeping in where fury had been.

“It’s… you.”

The words weren’t a question.

Phainon’s throat tightened. He stared up at him, caught somewhere between shock and blankly staring.

Mydei blinked slowly, as though trying to match memory to face. His voice came softer now, uncertain.

“I remember your face.”

That single line hit harder than any strike could’ve. It cracked through the tension.

And then—

“Phainon!”

The spell shattered.

Castorice rounded the corner with Trinnon clinging behind her, both looking like they’d sprinted the whole way. Her scythe was already drawn, energy flaring down the curved blade. One glance at the scene was enough to have her aiming squarely.

“Step back—he’s unstable—”

Trinnon peeked from behind her shoulder, holo flickering faintly. “L-leave Snowy alone!”

Mydei didn’t even look at them. His attention barely wavered from Phainon, though the growl in his throat rumbled again—warning.

Phainon swallowed, forcing his voice out. “He’s not going to hurt me.”

“Phainon.” Castorice’s tone sharpened. “Look at him. He nearly broke my __”

“He’s not going to hurt me,” he said again. Quieter. But firmer.

Something in his tone made Castorice pause mid-breath. Even Trinnon went silent, her projection dimming slightly.

Mydei's breathing slowed. His hand—still gripping Phainon's wrist—loosened just enough to not bruise. The readiness didn't leave his body, but the hostility did.

"…You helped me escape those crystals," Mydei murmured after a beat.

Phainon's breath caught. "You… remember that?"

(What he didn't say was—is that all?)

Mydei didn't answer.

Castorice finally exhaled, lowering the weapon a fraction. "Phainon. Either get him to medbay or get out of his reach, I'm not asking twice."

Trinnon, flickering nervously beside her, whispered, "We said he needed more time before waking, his vitals weren't even—um—stable—"

Phainon rose slowly, careful not to spook the man in front of him. Mydei's grip adjusted instinctively, fingers catching his wrist to steady him.

The touch made something electric crawl under Phainon's skin. Too much. Too easy to want.

"Come on," he said quietly, his tone gentler than he meant. "We're not doing this here."

Mydei hesitated, but he didn't resist. He followed when Phainon tugged, the faintest pull enough to guide him forward.

Their steps fell into sync without meaning to. Mydei's eyes stayed fixed on him, studying, remembering—or trying to.

It was the first time Phainon had seen Mydei look at him without hatred. Without the familiar, cold disgust.

Something inside him twisted. Maybe guilt. Maybe something worse. His fingers tightened slightly around Mydei's wrist before he realized it, before he could stop himself. He didn't let go.

Neither did Mydei.

They passed under the low hum of the lights and out of sight, their voices fading into the soft rumble of the ship.

Castorice stood there long after they disappeared, scythe still in hand, expression torn

Beside her, Trinnon's projection flickered again.

Castorice finally sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose.

"…We're going to need more containment fields."

Trinnon blinked. "Uh… more than one?"

"Way more than one," Castorice muttered, watching the corridor's empty stretch where they'd gone. "And maybe a leash while we're at it."

Phainon had all but dragged Mydei with him.

The medbay's light had been too harsh so he'd overridden the controls and dimmed it until the glow softened to something bearable. It wasn't cozy, but it was private.

Mydei sat on the edge of the narrow bench, posture coiled. Even cleaned up he carried the look of someone halfway between a briefing and a battlefield. His shoulders stayed squared, his legs planted, as if ready to spring for the nearest exit.

Phainon leaned against the opposite counter, pretending to look casual. He wasn't.

He’d told himself he’d brought Mydei here to keep him calm. Truth was, he didn’t want anyone else near him.

For a while, neither spoke. The silence stretched taut.

Then, Mydei broke it.

“How long was I out?”

Phainon looked up from the console. “2 weeks.”

That earned a flicker of surprise. “That long?”

“Your body took time to stabilize,” Phainon said. “Those crystal fields—you weren’t exactly meant to breathe them.”

“You make it sound like I was a lab rat.”

Phainon almost smiled. “You were closer to a cardiac event, actually. For me.”

That got him a faint eye-roll—progress, technically.

Mydei’s gaze drifted to the stars outside, reflecting faintly in the dark glass. Then, quieter:

“Where is this place?”

Phainon didn’t miss the suspicion in his voice. “Still in neutral orbit,” he said quickly.

That made Mydei’s head turn. His eyes narrowed. “Neutral orbit,” he repeated, like he was testing the phrase for lies. “You expect me to believe that?”

“It’s safer this way,” Phainon said.

“For who?”

Phainon kept his face still. “For both of us.”

A pause. Mydei studied him for a long moment, unreadable. Then his voice dropped, softer, but edged. “Who else made it out?”

Phainon felt the faintest spike in his pulse. He should’ve seen that coming.

He shifted his weight, leaning back on the counter, fingers tapping against metal to stall. “A few,” he said. “The ones stationed along the western ridge when it happened. Command didn’t hold.”

Mydei’s jaw flexed. “Names.”

He hesitated. “You should rest before—”

“*Names*,” Mydei repeated.

Phainon didn’t flinch. “…Ptolemy. Peucesta.”

It came out too fast.

He prayed Mydei wouldn’t notice.

He had no idea if either of them had survived—he was gambling, constructing a lie from memory fragments and educated guesses.

“That’s it?”

Phainon forced his tone into something neutral. “The others didn’t make it.”

Mydei’s expression didn’t change, but something in his posture did—a small tightening at the shoulders. “You’re saying *I* was the lucky one.”

“You are,” Phainon said.

“I don’t feel lucky.”

He wanted to say, *you should,* but that wasn’t the kind of thing that helped. He wanted to tell him how close it had been, how he’d nearly stopped died,

how Phainon had carried him out of the collapse with hands shaking so badly the suit telemetry thought he was injured. But none of that would make sense to Mydei now—not when he still thought they'd defected *together*.

So instead, he said, "You're alive. That's what matters."

Mydei shot him a look, unimpressed. "You talk like a medic."

"I've had practice."

"Right."

The air eased slightly, if only by a fraction. Mydei's shoulders lowered a little, some of the tension bleeding out, though his eyes never stopped moving. He was cataloguing exits again. Counting. Always counting.

"You don't have to stay on guard," Phainon said quietly.

"I don't trust empty rooms."

Phainon smiled faintly. "Didn't think you trusted me either."

Mydei's eyes flicked toward him. "Should I?"

Phainon's throat tightened.

"You trusted me enough to follow me out," Phainon said instead, carefully wording his speech.

"That's not the same thing."

"No," Phainon murmured, almost to himself. "It's not."

Mydei looked away, muttering something he probably didn't intend to be heard.

Phainon caught himself smiling again, helplessly. He didn't even know why. Maybe it was the absurdity of it—the fact that he was sitting here,

spinning stories to the one person least likely to believe them. Maybe it was the way Mydei's presence still pulled at him, magnetic, even through layers of suspicion.

He was the one with the upper hand, yet Mydei still made him feel like the one being interrogated.

He tried to keep calm.

And when Mydei turned slightly, profile caught in the half-light of the lab, eyes glinting like the edges of a blade, Phainon could only think one thing:

He was in so much trouble.

When Mydei stood, it should've been a simple motion—just standing. But Phainon's attention caught on it anyway.

Something about it was wrong. The shift of weight, the subtle overcorrection when Mydei straightened, the way his stride carried a weightlessness that didn't belong to his frame. His balance looked practiced, not natural, like someone walking across unstable ground and pretending not to notice.

Phainon watched him cross the small space, that lightness in his steps setting off an itch at the base of his thoughts until realization slotted neatly into place.

The gravity.

It was too low.

He'd left it calibrated to Okheman standards—comfortable for him, a little over one standard gravity, easy on the joints. But Kremnoans were different creatures entirely. They grew under pressure, shaped by denser air and heavier atmospheres, by planets that pulled harder. The weight of their world lingered in their bones.

And here Mydei was, moving as though the air had thinned to glass.

Phainon’s fingers twitched toward the console. The correction was small, just a few adjustments keyed in manually, but the room responded instantly—metal groaning faintly as the artificial field deepened. The hum of the air changed pitch; the floor seemed to reach up, claiming them both.

1.8g.

He didn’t say anything. He just watched.

Mydei steadied. It happened so naturally that Phainon almost missed it—the small shift in stance, the way his shoulders evened, the fine tension bleeding out of his neck. Even his breathing changed: slower, heavier, grounded again.

And Phainon, damn him, felt a small tug of satisfaction. The sight of Mydei at ease—just a fraction, but enough—felt undeservedly like a victory.

Then Mydei’s gaze cut toward him.

“You changed it.”

Phainon didn’t look up from the console, voice perfectly mild. “You were moving lighter than usual.”

Mydei studied him, one brow raised. “You pay attention.”

Phainon’s mouth curved, more reflex than smile. “Bad habit.”

That earned him a look—part scrutiny, part thought. Mydei turned back to the viewport and sat again, the faint creak of the bench filling the space where a thank-you might have gone.

Phainon shifted his thoughts.

That subtle lightness from before—the way Mydei had been disoriented, his questions clipped and suspicious—it wasn’t just exhaustion, most likely. The crystalline exposure, the neural interference, the fact that he still didn’t remember half of what had happened—Phainon couldn’t just leave it at that.

And then it hit him.

Hyacine.

He could take Mydei to her. She'd know what to do, how to run diagnostics properly, maybe even patch the fragments left behind in his memory. If anyone could help, it was her.

The thought crystallized so abruptly that he froze mid-motion, staring past the viewport like he was watching something only he could see.

Of course. The Grove of Epiphany. He'd have to cross through it to reach Hyacine's outpost. Not ideal—but better than waiting here and doing nothing.

He must have gone quiet too long, because Mydei turned, eyes narrowing faintly.

"What?"

Phainon blinked, realizing how still he'd gone, the edges of his expression probably betraying more than he meant. He coughed, adjusting his collar as if that could cover it. "Nothing. Just—remembered something important." His tone softened into that easy drawl again, practiced and harmless. "I need to make a call. I'll be right back."

Mydei leaned back, still watching him, one hand resting loosely on his knee. "Then why are you still here?"

Phainon snorted quietly, a huff of breath that almost became a laugh. "Fair question."

He pushed off the wall, steps steady now under the heavier pull of gravity, and started toward the door. The faint smile ghosted back for a second as he keyed it open.

He didn't look back, but he could feel Mydei's gaze following him—measuring, and full of questions that hadn't yet found words.

And that was fine.

He had enough of his own.

Now he just needed to convince Castorice that dragging a half-amnesiac Kremnoan through the Grove wasn't completely insane.

God help him.

He scrubbed a hand through his hair, sighed, then keyed in the frequency he wasn't supposed to use outside emergency channels.

The interface flickered to life, stabilizing into the familiar pale light of Castorice's projection. She was still somewhere on the upper decks, uniform jacket half unzipped, the glow of her displays painting faint blue rings under her eyes. Calm, professional, maddeningly composed—her gaze always made him feel like a particularly unwashed stray someone had decided to let in out of pity.

He grinned anyway, leaning a shoulder against the wall. "Heyyyyy, Castorice. Fancy seeing you here. Lovely signal weather we're having, yeah?"

Her gaze didn't even twitch. "You're planning to move him, aren't you?"

The grin froze halfway. "…You're supposed to be running diagnostics."

"I did," she said simply, not breaking eye contact. "And while you were playing babysitter, I prepped two ships."

He blinked. "Two?"

"We're splitting."

Phainon hesitated, caught between surprise and suspicion. "…Well. That was easier than expected."

"Don't get comfortable," she said, glancing toward a side console. "The Council deployed a new trace pulse an hour ago. They're sweeping for

surviving Okhemans."

"Of course they are," he muttered. "Wouldn't want to let a few unsupervised disasters slip through."

Castorice ignored that. "I don't mind being found," she continued quietly. "You, however, should go."

He frowned, folding his arms. "You're volunteering me? Why not send—"

"Because if they find me," she interrupted, "they'll take me back for review and reclassification, and I'll be fine. If they find you, same thing. But if they find *him*…" She paused, her voice softening without losing clarity. "You know what they'll do, Phainon. They'll dissect what he knows. Maybe even for no reason."

Phainon looked away, jaw flexing. "You're assuming a lot."

"I'm assuming the obvious," she said pointedly, her hands moving off-screen as if finalizing the transfer before he could argue. "If we move together, we'll amplify the trace signature. Split, we're noise. Two smaller blips are harder to lock than one larger one."

"Smart," he said after a beat. "Paranoid, but smart."

"Both keep you alive," she replied, faint amusement ghosting in her tone.

He leaned back, watching her. "You're sure this pulse isn't a decoy?"

"No." She hesitated briefly before adding, "But you're taking him to Hyacine, aren't you?"

"…You shouldn't assume."

"I don't have to." Her tone gentled. "It's the logical next step. Hyacine's work with crystalline recovery makes her the only one who might help him. You wouldn't sit still knowing that."

Phainon exhaled, a sound somewhere between a sigh and a laugh. “You make it sound like a bad weakness.”

“It is,” she said, smiling faintly now. “But it’s the right one this time.”

He looked down at the deck, then back up at her. “You’re letting me go.”

“I’m not *letting* you. I’m clearing the way before you do something reckless without backup.” She reached for another control panel. “Take the secondary vessel. It’s fueled and warp-stable for short runs. Just—don’t get caught again.”

He tilted his head, lips twitching. “You say that like it’s something I plan for.”

“Phainon,” she said softly, cutting through his grin. “Be careful. Please.”

He smiled again, smaller this time. “Always am.”

The line flickered and went dark.

It wasn’t so bad.

Phainon stood there for a long minute, fingers still resting against the comm panel, replaying the look on her face.

Separate ships. Separate logs. Separate records.

No supervision.

No witnesses if Mydei got his memories back and decided to strangle him.

And still, he couldn’t not go.

Damn it.

With a slow breath, he pushed off the wall and headed back toward the medbay.

The door hissed open to reveal Mydei exactly where he'd left him—sitting with that practiced stillness that wasn't quite rest, gaze fixed on the window's edge. The faint starlight framed his profile in silver and shadow. When Phainon stepped in, those sharp eyes shifted toward him instantly.

Phainon gave a faint, lopsided smile. "Well," he said lightly, "how do you feel about a space trip?"

Mydei's brow rose. "That depends. You planning to tell me where we're going this time?"

He considered, then flashed a toothy smile. "Would you believe me if I said it's somewhere quiet?"

"No."

Phainon chuckled under his breath. "Didn't think so."

He moved to the viewport beside him, the hum of the engines resonating beneath his boots. Out there, the stars stretched endless and patient, like they knew just how small this was in comparison—and still, how much it mattered.

They were really doing this.

And for better or worse, there was no one left to stop him.

That was it.

Today, he was going to talk to Mydei.

Properly, this time. Not the awkward little check-ins, not the occasional muttered “morning,” not the static-filled silence between open comms pretending to be coincidence. Actual words. A conversation. Maybe even something resembling connection.

True to her word, Castorice had prepped their departure fast—two ships ready before dawn, stealth-mode locked, all traces scrubbed clean. They’d barely made orbit before she was found, but by then, they were already too far to recall. Phainon remembered reading the report, smiling faintly to himself. Trust her to survive chaos like it was a hobby.

He’d gone right back to watching the feed after that.

It was supposed to be a precaution—monitoring vitals, keeping tabs, being responsible. That was all. Except, somewhere around the fourth night, it wasn’t about data anymore. He kept the feed open longer than he should’ve, checking if Mydei was still awake, if he’d started pacing again, if his breathing changed when the ship shifted into sublight drift. The rhythm of it had become… familiar. Steadying, almost.

Mydei, for his part, had been restless from the start. He’d spent days circling his cabin like a storm caught in a jar. Sometimes he’d pause right in front of the active feed, eyes unreadable, the faint hum of his breath carrying across the open comm. Phainon never mentioned it. Neither did he.

By now, three days into the flight toward the Grove, the silence had started to ache.

So Phainon decided to break it—forcefully, if necessary.

Which was why he stood now in Mydei’s doorway, smile just shy of manic, holding a tray of what could only be described as edible despair.

“Dinner’s served~” he declared, sing-song, stepping in before Mydei could object.

The other man barely glanced up from the viewport. His eyes flicked to the tray, then to Phainon, then back again, unimpressed. “That’s not dinner.”

“Technically,” Phainon said cheerfully, setting it down, “it qualifies. Nutritional. Caloric. Gray.”

He leaned in slightly, lowering his voice like he was sharing a secret. “Do you always scowl when food’s good, or am I just that talented?”

Mydei—as expected—scowled. Too predictable, really. “You talk too much.”

“Flattery will get you everywhere,” Phainon sighed, dragging a chair over and plopping down beside him.

Mydei poked the gel with the spoon like he was checking if it might bite. When it didn’t, he gave a reluctant hum and took a small bite, wincing at the taste. Phainon watched with all the intensity of someone observing art in motion.

“You know,” he began conversationally, “I would cook if I could, but Cyrene says—oh, that’s my sister, by the way—says no one wants to eat salads every day. Which is ridiculous, because salads are an art form. Crisp greens, balance, color—”

“Cyrene,” Mydei interrupted, tone flat.

Phainon blinked. “Yeah! Cyrene. My sister. How’d I never mention her?”

He leaned back, gesturing vaguely with his hands as if the story needed space. “She’s a menace, really. Smart as hell, mouthy as hell, thinks she’s the second coming of every engineer who’s ever existed. I once asked her to recalibrate the drone rotors, and she reprogrammed them to whistle songs instead. Whole hangar sounded like a haunted festival for a week.”

The faintest, quietest snort left Mydei.

Phainon noticed and smiled, bright and unguarded. “Exactly. You get it.”

He kept going without realizing he’d slipped into a softer cadence. “She’s working under Cipher now. Poor woman probably regrets ever agreeing to it. But Cyrene’s got this thing about her—she just… makes messes sound manageable. Like, even when she’s clearly about to burn down the lab, she’ll smile and say, ‘Don’t worry, I’ve got it.’ And somehow, you believe her.”

He paused, realizing how easily he’d gone off track. “Sorry. I tend to ramble when I start talking about her.”

Mydei tilted his head slightly, going silent. “Continue.”

Phainon froze for a heartbeat, unsure if he’d heard that right. “What, really?”

A faint nod.

He blinked, caught off guard by the sudden curiosity. The air between them felt suddenly closer, sharper somehow. He cleared his throat, trying to sound nonchalant. “Right, uh—well. She’s the only one who can get me to shut up, for starters. Sends me updates every week, mostly stupid jokes or photos of her projects. Or her cats. She keeps rescuing the ones that sneak into the labs, and I keep telling her she’s gonna get kicked out for it.”

A small laugh slipped out—real this time, soft around the edges. “She doesn’t listen, of course. Never has.”

He shifted, rubbing the back of his neck, then suddenly brightened. “Wait—hold on. I’ve got a picture of her somewhere.”

Without thinking, he scooted closer, their shoulders brushing as he scrolled through his teleslate. The contact was brief, accidental—but he felt it anyway. His breath hitched slightly before he found the photo.

“There.” He angled the slate toward Mydei, smiling. “That’s her. Look at her—tell me she’s not gorgeous.”

It was Cyrene, mid-laugh, pink hair catching the glow of the lab lights. A smear of green on her cheek, a half-tamed grin that looked like trouble and kindness at once.

Mydei leaned in slightly, his gaze flicking to the image. For a moment, neither spoke.

“She’s got that kind of look,” Phainon said quietly, a note of fondness threading through his voice. “Sharp but kind.”

He didn’t notice how close he’d gotten, or how his voice had dropped lower without meaning to. He didn’t notice, either, that Mydei’s eyes had shifted —away from the slate, to him.

Phainon only looked up when he heard a faint exhale beside him. Mydei’s expression was unreadable, but his reply came softer than before.

“…Yeah.”

Phainon beamed at that, easy and bright again, missing entirely the way Mydei’s gaze lingered a moment longer than it should’ve. “Knew it. She’d be thrilled you said so.”

And just like that, the tension broke—light, seamless, almost comfortable. Phainon leaned back, scrolling idly as he kept talking, warmth still coloring his tone.

He tapped a finger against the tray, the last hint of a smile lingering on his lips. He should’ve let the quiet stay—let the ease between them breathe—but silence, when it came to him, was a luxury he rarely allowed himself.

He turned, humming under his breath. “Say, Mydei,” he began, tone light but deliberate, “we’ve got a room that passes for a training deck onboard. Have you ever been there?”

Mydei looked up. “No.”

Phainon’s excitement spiked up suddenly, a duel with Mydei? Who wouldn’t be happy. “Then I’ll have to give you the tour sometime. Show

you how Okheman tech actually behaves when you're not threatening to dismantle it." He leaned an elbow on the table, voice dipping to something closer. "I could even… reacquaint you with it. Properly, this time."

Mydei blinked, faintly skeptical. "Properly?"

"Well, the first step is learning that our systems don't respond to logic alone," Phainon said, gesturing as though drawing circuitry in the air. "They read intent. They can tell when you're irritated, or impatient, or trying too hard to hide either." His smile turned slow. "You have to coax them a little. Like they're listening."

"That sounds inefficient," Mydei replied, dry as ever.

"Maybe," Phainon allowed. "But they're honest about it. Most things that react to emotion are."

A beat passed—soft, suspended—and Phainon found himself watching him too long. Mydei's attention had drifted to the viewport again, the reflected starlight tracing faint silver along the line of his jaw. Something in the sight of it, calm and unaware, made Phainon want to keep talking just to see if he could draw another flicker of expression from him.

He leaned forward slightly, resting his chin in his palm. "You know," he said, "you look better when you're not trying so hard to be mysterious."

That earned the smallest shift—the briefest flicker of eyes toward him, like surprise caught too late.

He almost smiled again, softer this time. "There it is. Don't worry," he added under his breath, "I promise I don't bite. Not unless you try to override my calibration settings."

Mydei exhaled a quiet, nearly imperceptible sound—half a scoff, half a laugh. It was fleeting, but real.

And then—

A vibration shuddered through the deck, faint but immediate. The air seemed to tighten.

Phainon straightened, every trace of teasing gone. “What was that?”

Before Mydei could answer, a low warning tone rippled overhead—subtle, but carrying the ship’s unmistakable hum of alert.

He was already on his feet. “Stay here,” he said, and this time there was nothing casual about his voice. The ship’s ambient lighting wavered with his pulse as he crossed to the control junction, teleslate already activating in his hand.

“C’mon…” He murmured to the ship, half command, half coaxing. Pain sensors whispered under his skin when he linked in—small stings that mirrored tension, grounding him in the Okheman vessel’s shared feedback loop.

The diagnostic data flowed fast, elegant, familiar. Everything seemed normal—except for one faint flicker at the edge of the schematic.

A trace of red. Subtle, too subtle, like infection woven into clean code. It pulsed once.

“What…” He zoomed in, eyes narrowing, fingers brushing across the interface. The anomaly didn’t react to direct input. He adjusted parameters, prodding gently at its edge—

And in the next instant, it vanished.

No alert, no trace, nothing. Just the ordinary grid of energy lines as if it had never been there.

The system chimed: **All clear.**

Phainon stayed there, hand hovering over the display, his reflection faint in the glass.

He didn’t know what that was.

He didn’t know why it had felt alive.

And he definitely didn’t see the faint, unsettled color that had touched Mydei’s face when he’d bolted from the room.

VESSEL STATUS: IN TRANSIT—Estimated Arrival at the Grove: 72 Hours
Crew Activity Log: Stable. No further anomalies detected.

At least, that’s what the ship kept saying.

Phainon had learned to stop trusting the ship’s tone after day one—it had the smugness of someone who *knew* it was smarter than him. But it wasn’t wrong. It had been three days since that flicker in the system, three days since the strange pulse that had crawled under his skin and refused to leave his mind.

And in that time, he’d accomplished something arguably more miraculous than stabilizing a ship’s code:

He’d gotten Mydei to talk to him.

It had started small. A quiet response here, a nod that lingered a moment too long, a question that wasn’t strictly necessary. Phainon would call that communication. Hell, he’d call it a breakthrough.

And now—well, now he had a plan. A bold, brilliant, slightly reckless plan.

Okheman tech training.

Educational, productive, and, best of all, conveniently hands-on.

Which was why he currently found himself dragging a very unwilling, very disheveled Mydei down one of the glowing corridors toward the ship’s training deck.

“Come on,” Phainon was saying as they walked, grin audible in his voice. “You’ll like this one, I promise. No chance of getting electrocuted unless

you *really* try.”

Mydei didn’t answer, though he didn’t pull away either. His hair was uncharacteristically messy, the soft edges of his composure frayed just enough to make Phainon’s brain short-circuit for entirely unrelated reasons.

He’d looked… docile, earlier. That was the word. Like a cat too tired to fight being carried, tail twitching but otherwise resigned.

Phainon *definitely* wasn’t going to admit how adorable that had been.

By the time they reached the deck, the air felt charged already. The space was broad, clean-lined, and dimly lit by the pulsing threads of Okheman circuitry tracing along the walls and floor—each pulse syncing faintly with the rhythm of whoever stood near.

Phainon stretched, cracking his neck with the easy confidence of someone who’d done this hundreds of times. Mydei stood beside the circular training interface, yawning, his eyes tracking the faint movement of light beneath the translucent floor.

“Alright,” Phainon began, rolling his shoulders. “We’ll start with resonance control. Nothing too intense. Just… feel for the hum in the current. Don’t overthink it—it’s like breathing. You let the tech match your rhythm, not the other way around.”

Mydei nodded once, wordless, and pressed his hand against the surface.

The lights flared obediently at first. Perfect symmetry. Perfect alignment. Then—

A sharp *crack*, followed by a burst of static light that made the air pulse.

Phainon didn’t even blink. A thin wisp of smoke curled upward from the interface.

“…”

He inhaled slowly, counted to three, and smiled. A perfectly composed, perfectly *I-totally-meant-for-that-to-happen* smile.

“Well,” he said brightly, clapping once. “Progress! You didn’t vaporize it this time.”

Mydei stepped back, his expression unreadable but the faintest trace of contrition flickering in his eyes.

Phainon tilted his head, amused. “Don’t tell me you actually feel bad for it. You’ll hurt the ship’s feelings.”

“I misjudged the output,” Mydei said quietly.

“You don’t say.”

There was the faintest twitch at the corner of Mydei’s mouth, there and gone in a heartbeat.

“Alright then,” he said, tone softening. “Let’s try again.”

They’d switched to resonance training after Mydei’s strength made short work of the more physical drills. In any other context, Phainon might’ve been… distracted by that. The way his hands fit against the equipment, the effortless tension in his arms—

He cleared his throat. Professionalism, yes. Focus.

Mydei’s gaze flicked toward him again, uncertain. Then, after a long beat, he nodded.

Huh. The bastard actually *did* feel bad.

How endearing.

Phainon motioned toward one of the auxiliary pedestals gleaming at the edge of the deck. “Alright, let’s try something a little different,” he said, tone pitched somewhere between challenge and charm. “Here—”

He picked up a sleek crystalline rod, translucent with veins of faint blue light pulsing just under the surface. “This,” he said, holding it up between them, “is a *vein conduit.* It regulates emotional output through resonance alignment.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow, arms crossed. “Emotional output,” he echoed.

“Yes,” Phainon replied, undeterred, holding it up like a holy relic. “Okheman tech reads feeling as data. If your focus slips, it mirrors that instability. Which is why I’m going to—” He made a vague gesture that could’ve meant anything. “Help you stabilize the flow.”

Mydei stared at him for a moment longer, as though weighing the risk of asking what that meant. Then, with the barest sigh, he extended his hand. “Fine.”

Phainon smiled—small, genuine, a little too pleased. “Atta boy.”

He stepped closer. Close enough for Mydei to feel the faint glitch that always seemed to follow him when he worked with tech—like the circuitry itself charged under his touch. “Here,” Phainon said, offering the conduit and guiding Mydei’s grip until both their hands overlapped along the smooth, humming surface.

Mydei’s fingers were steady but tense. “And now?”

“Now,” Phainon murmured, moving behind him, “we calibrate it.”

He positioned himself close—close enough that his chest nearly brushed Mydei’s back, his breath grazing the edge of his hair. There was no teasing in his tone when he spoke again, he was focused. “Don’t lock your wrist. Let it move. Feel for the pull in the current—”

The conduit flickered in response, the soft blue light trembling like a pulse.

“Better,” Phainon murmured. His voice dropped unconsciously. “You’re connecting. The conduit draws from both of us now—my signal balances yours. If either of us spike emotionally, it’ll throw the flow off.”

Mydei's jaw flexed, but his focus didn't waver. "Convenient," he said, voice mellow, though it came out quieter than before.

Phainon smiled faintly. "It's why I make such a good diplomat. Comes with built-in damage control."

He adjusted his stance, one hand lifting slightly to hover over Mydei's, fingertips brushing the back of his knuckles—not quite touch, but near enough that Mydei's breath hitched before he caught it. "Alright," Phainon said softly. "Steady. Let it resonate with you. Don't force control—just let it learn you."

For a few long moments, the hum of the conduit deepened, its glow spreading like veins of living light across its surface. Phainon could feel Mydei's concentration sharpen, all that composed stillness drawn into a singular point of focus. He could almost see it—the way Mydei's energy aligned.

Then, suddenly, the light brightened—no stutter, no flicker—just a clean, steady pulse that filled the space between them. The air hummed like a held breath.

Phainon blinked. "Well I'll be damned."

He eased back half a step, happy despite himself. "You actually did it."

Mydei exhaled, lowering the conduit. The look on his face wasn't defensive—it was earned. The faintest flush of pride crossed his features, gone almost as soon as it appeared.

Phainon laughed, delighted. "See? Natural talent. Should've known you'd show off once you got the hang of it."

A corner of Mydei's mouth curved into a small smile that caused Phainon's chest to do something strange and unhelpful.

"These weapons," Mydei said after a pause, tone thoughtful, "are difficult to hold."

Phainon tilted his head. “Yeah?”

“They feel…” Mydei hesitated, searching for words. “Foreign. Like something that doesn’t want to fit.”

The smile faltered, just slightly. “Huh.”

Phainon forced an easy chuckle. “You’re not wrong. They were designed by a bunch of eccentric engineers who think ergonomics is a myth. You’ll get used to it.”

But even as he said it, something about Mydei’s words lingered—an itch just out of reach. *Doesn’t want to fit.*

He smiled again, softer this time, but the look in his eyes gave away the flicker of unease beneath.

Phainon watched him for a moment longer. Mydei still held the conduit with that same carefulness, the glow dimming to a faint pulse in his palm. There was something almost reverent about the way he regarded it—entirely absorbed.

It struck Phainon, suddenly and without warning, how foreign that sight was.

Had they ever even fought together? Not as in training—but fought. Shoulder to shoulder. He couldn’t recall. He remembered the way Mydei moved through a room, yes, the authority that made people part before him, but not the way he fought. Not truly.

The only image that surfaced was fragmented—a flash of light, a shout, the edge of claws slicing through smoke. Mydei, incandescent and terrifying, cutting through the dark like he’d been *born* to it. Beautiful. Blazing. Untouchable.

And Phainon, idiot that he was, had been watching him even then.

The memory tugged at him like wired under his skin. *Huh*, he thought. *I wonder if—*

He stopped. Then his lips curved, the kind of slow, dangerous smile that never meant anything good.

“Well,” he said suddenly, stepping back into Mydei’s line of sight, “I have an idea.”

Mydei blinked, wary. “That usually means trouble.”

“You wound me,” Phainon said, already swiping a hand through the air to call up the holographic weapon matrix. The grid hummed to life, geometric light tracing itself into being until a greatsword solidified in his hand—sleek metal, black-veined with pale gold light.

He twirled it once, easy and fluid. “Meet *Dawnmaker*. My personal weapon.”

Before Mydei could respond, Phainon tossed it lightly toward him. The blade hummed midair, and Mydei caught it without looking, the weight settling into his palm like it belonged there.

“Wanna have a quick spar?” Phainon asked. “Don’t worry, I don’t bite.”

The look Mydei gave him was unamused, but Phainon caught the faintest smirk forming on his mouth. Even without his memories, of course he was bloodthirsty. “You bite,” Mydei said pointedly.

Phainon spread his hands. “Only when provoked.”

Mydei exhaled softly through his nose—half sigh, half reluctant amusement—and looked down at the sword. The weapon’s light reflected against his eyes, gold against blue, and for just a moment, he looked… conflicted.

Phainon tilted his head. The Kremnoans had a saying: *You don’t know someone until you’ve fought them*. For them, sparring wasn’t aggression—it was intimacy. A communion of will. The first time Phainon had learned that, he’d laughed. Now, watching Mydei trace the edge of Dawnmaker with gloved fingers, he wondered if there was something in him that *missed* it.

He grimaced inwardly. *Gods, Phainon, you're pathetic.*

Still, the thought wouldn't quite leave him. He doubted Mydei remembered a single Kremnoan custom after the amnesia—he doubted he remembered *Phainon,* for that matter—but still, the temptation to see what was left, what instincts lingered, burned bright.

Besides, what harm could it do? Mydei might have been a legend but that was before the memory loss. Phainon doubted the old edge still lingered.

Right?

He forced his focus back to the moment. "You use that," he said, nodding toward Dawnmaker. "I'll grab something less intimidating. Wouldn't want to bruise your ego and your ribs."

He turned and reached for one of the practice blades hanging nearby—lighter, shorter, with dull-edged lines glowing faintly down the fuller. He spun it once in his palm, the motion smooth, practiced.

When he turned back, Mydei was still studying him. Not the sword, surprisingly.

Phainon's theatrically sighed. "Oh come on," he said lightly, stepping onto the sparring deck as the floor flared alive with containment lines of pale blue. "It'll be good for you. Builds character."

There was a pause, long enough for Phainon to start wondering if he'd pushed too far—then, slowly, Mydei nodded once.

That single nod hit harder than any yes.

Phainon felt the shift immediately—the air thickening, the faint hum of the deck responding to their movement, calibrating for combat mode. He rolled his shoulders, raised his blade, and let the grin return.

"Alright," he said, eyes glinting. "Don't worry. I'll go easy on you."

A dry voice replied, "I'd rather you didn't."

Phainon blinked, startled—then laughed, delighted. “Oh, you’re serious. Even better.”

He took a step forward, blade angling up, a spark of anticipation running through him like lightning through wire.

“How hard can it be?”

Harder than he thought.

Phainon had gone in expecting something simple—light sparring, a touch of showmanship, maybe the kind of lazy back-and-forth where he could sneak in a few jokes and coax a reaction out of Mydei. Maybe even a smile. But the instant their blades crossed, all those expectations cracked clean through.

The first strike hit with surgical precision. Mydei met it like he’d been waiting for it—one smooth deflection, one seamless turn of the wrist, redirecting Dawnmaker’s weight as though it were nothing. The shock bit up through Phainon’s arm, nerve to shoulder, bright and sharp.

His eyes narrowed. “Oh,” he said lightly, shaking out his wrist. “So that’s how we’re playing this.”

No reply. Mydei simply reset his stance, his gaze gilled with intent. He moved with the kind of stillness that made Phainon’s instincts twitch—loose and unassuming, but ready to strike at any second.

Something in Phainon shifted. His casual swagger thinned into something sharper, his weight balancing just right on his heels. The lazy smile stayed, but now it was edged—an expression worn by someone who *finally* felt a challenge in his bones.

They circled, the sound of the training field pulsing faintly underfoot.

Phainon lunged first—testing, teasing, the kind of opening meant to draw out the other’s rhythm. Mydei met every swing cleanly, every parry precise.

Sparks of kinetic light spilled across the floor like molten stars.

“You sure you don’t remember any of this?” Phainon asked, laughing as their blades clashed again.

Mydei’s response came in that calm, even tone of his, not even a flicker of emotion. “My muscles do.”

That threw him off more than he wanted to admit. The rhythm of his strikes faltered for half a heartbeat before he laughed again—lower, breathier. “Unfair. I liked you better when you were bad at this.”

He barely caught the next blow. The pace had picked up without warning—each strike sharper, faster, heavier. Mydei didn’t waste a single motion. It wasn’t brute strength. Every movement said, *I’ve done this a thousand times before.*

Phainon couldn’t help it—his excitement increased. *Gods, he’s reading me.*

It wasn’t fear that shot through him—it was exhilaration. A rush he hadn’t felt in too long. He wasn’t used to being the one chased into focus, hell most the time he wasn’t even fighting. He was a diplomat for goodness sakes. Maybe it made him a freak, but that realization alone lit a fire in his chest.

So what if I’m a little freak? It’s not like anyone’s watching.

He feinted left, then snapped right. Mydei parried, slipped inside his guard, and—without warning—Phainon’s sword was gone, skittering across the polished floor.

“Oh, come on—”

Before he could blink, Mydei caught Dawnmaker mid-air, turned it effortlessly, and leveled it right at Phainon’s chest.

Phainon blinked once. Then he laughed. Full-bodied, delighted. “Oh, that’s beautiful.”

And then Mydei *smirked*. Small. Dangerous. The kind of expression that shouldn't have been half as attractive as it was.

Phainon felt his pulse spike so fast it was ridiculous. *Oh, I am so screwed.*

He lunged for a nearby rack, grabbed another blade, and came back swinging before Mydei could get a word out. Their swords clashed again—fast, hot, relentless. The simulation lights above them flickered, struggling to keep pace with the energy output.

The deck vibrated faintly beneath their feet. Heat rolled off the air in waves.

Phainon ducked under a swing, clicking his tongue. "We're breaking the training deck."

"You're the one heating it up," Mydei replied without missing a beat.

"Oh, *I'm* the problem?" Phainon twisted around him, catching his sword against the other's, forcing their faces close enough to share breath. "You're not supposed to try and *kill* me!"

"You told me not to hold back."

He exhaled through a laugh that came out closer to a groan. "Why am I into these types?" he muttered, almost to himself.

Mydei's eyes flicked up at that, expression incredulous.

A twist, a parry, a push. Mydei caught his wrist mid-swing; Phainon turned the grip over, reversed it, and shoved him back. The sound of their blades locking was almost like music.

Gods, Phainon thought, *no wonder the Kremnoans turned this into a courtship ritual.*

Mydei came in low, forcing Phainon to pivot—fast, defensive. When their blades met again, they didn't part. Shoulder to shoulder, each pushing for ground.

Phainon could feel the other’s breath brush his jaw, heat ghosting between them, both of them smiling like lunatics.

For a moment, the world narrowed to just that—breath, motion, heartbeat.

He looked up, and Mydei’s face was lit from below by the simulation field. Focused. Wild. Hair clinging to his forehead, eyes with the kind of focus that shouldn’t be possible mid-fight. Beautiful, in that dangerous, too-alive way.

Phainon almost forgot to move.

Their swords twisted together again, guards locking, and the momentum shoved them closer still—too close.

“…You’ve done this before,” Phainon murmured, voice rougher than he meant.

It wasn’t a question.

“…Maybe,” Mydei said.

He tensed, heartbeat catching—then smiled, that sharp, wicked kind of smile that promised trouble. “Then don’t hold back.”

The next strike came without hesitation.

Mydei didn’t.

Alas, Phainon would’ve loved to keep going. Gods knew he could have.

But the simulation’s temperature was peaking, the air sharp with electricity, and the glow from the floor panels flickered dangerously between them. So, they had to end it—preferably before the deck burned itself out.

One final exchange.

Phainon feinted left. Mydei mirrored perfectly, their swords flashing in mirrored arcs. Both twisted, stepped in, and stopped—an inch from each

other’s necks.

Silence.

The energy fields dissolved in a quiet ripple, their blades dimming to silver and steel.

Phainon stayed there a moment, breath heaving, shoulders rising and falling with the aftershock. Mydei wasn’t much better off—his stance solid, but the fine tremor in his wrist gave him away. Sweat ran down the curve of his throat, caught in the line of his collarbone.

For a second, neither moved.

Then Mydei lowered his blade first. His voice a second later, edged with something between disbelief and amusement. “You call that easy?”

Phainon barked out a breath of a laugh, rubbing at his shoulder. “Harder than I thought.”

Mydei tilted his head. “You underestimate poorly.”

“Maybe I just like surprises.”

The answer earned him a look—flat at first, then curious. Mydei studied him for a moment too long, as if trying to read something behind his face. His gaze lingered on the line of Phainon’s jaw, the faint cut at his lip, the easy rise and fall of his breathing.

He didn’t look away when Phainon caught him staring.

Instead, Mydei asked quietly, “Does everything amuse you?”

“Only the good things.” Phainon said in response, deciding to forgo the taunts. “You’re one of them.”

For all his composure, Mydei faltered for half a heartbeat—eyes narrowing as though unsure whether to take it as mockery or not. The silence stretched.

Finally, he huffed out something like a laugh, barely audible. “You talk too much.”

“And yet you’re still standing here.”

That earned him the faintest smirk. Mydei looked away, brushing damp hair out of his face with the back of his wrist. “You fight like you mean it.”

“Should I not?”

“No,” Mydei said, glancing at him again. “It’s… good.”

That shouldn’t have sounded as serious as it did, but it was. There was something almost fascinated in his tone—not admiration exactly, but something similar.

It should’ve been flattering.

Phainon didn’t know why it caused him to tense up suddenly.

“You’re not so bad yourself.” Phainon rolled his shoulder, winced, then said, “Next time, I’m setting ground rules.”

“Next time?”

“Oh, you think I’m letting you end it here?” Phainon scoffed. “You owe me a rematch.”

Mydei’s smiled again, slower this time, less restrained. “You’d lose.”

“Maybe,” Phainon said easily. “But I’d have fun doing it.”

The simulation lights flickered back to normal, the hum of the ship returning as if it had been holding its breath too. Finally, Mydei twirled his sword and threw it to Phainon to catch, voice threaded with something new—interest, maybe.

“You’re strange,” he said, almost to himself.

Phainon smiled, head tilting just slightly. “And yet you don’t seem to hate it.”

Mydei didn’t respond, but the silence was an admission without words. That was enough.

And when Mydei started toward the exit, Phainon let him—mostly because he couldn’t think of a good excuse to make him stay. Not yet, anyway.

[TIME UNTIL GROVE ARRIVAL: 10 HOURS]

The ship purred along the edge of an asteroid belt, coasting steady and slow. Outside the viewport, fragments of rock turned lazily in orbit, catching stray streaks of starlight as they passed. The glow reflected faintly against the hull, like ripples on water.

Phainon leaned over the console, humming to himself as he adjusted the gravitic stabilizers. The field sensors had been flickering on and off since they’d entered the belt—nothing serious, just annoying enough to keep him from getting bored. Every time a larger chunk of debris drifted too close, the radar chimed softly, and he nudged it away with a flick of his wrist.

“Not today,” he murmured, smirking faintly as another small boulder spun off into the void.

He’d woken up about an hour ago. Technically, Okheman didn’t *need* sleep (for long periods of time at least), but it was nice to pretend sometimes. There was something satisfying about waking up groggy, stretching, and realizing he didn’t have to be anywhere for a few hours.

Now, he sat cross-legged in the pilot’s chair, barefoot, wrapped in a too-big blanket he was pretty sure he’d “borrowed” from the medbay. His shirt was wrinkled, hair half-dried from a quick rinse, and he looked every bit like someone still mentally in bed.

The bridge lights were dimmed to a cool-rainy glow, soft enough that the stars outside looked brighter. The sound of the engine was low and

rhythmic—steady enough that, if he wasn’t paying attention, it almost sounded like a heartbeat.

Phainon reached for his mug, found it still warm, and smiled. “Good ship,” he said absently, as if it could hear him.

He flicked open a few displays, checking the asteroid density maps, then idly rerouted the ship’s external shields to redistribute impact load—completely unnecessary, but it gave his hands something to do. There was something calming about it, like knitting for people who grew up with star drives.

He glanced at the countdown clock. *Ten hours until Grove arrival.* Not bad. Enough time to breathe, to pretend the universe wasn’t constantly trying to kill him, and maybe even nap again if he felt like it.

“Could be worse,” he said, echoing his own thought aloud, voice warm and lazy in the still air.

He reached out and dimmed the remaining lights until the only illumination came from the starfield. The glass canopy reflected his outline. It wasn’t glamorous. But gods, it was comfortable.

Phainon tilted his chair back, drawing the blanket tighter, and watched the asteroids drift by. They spun slow and steady, glimmering with every rotation, and for once, he didn’t mind the quiet.

There was no one demanding a report, no crisis alarm, no eldritch alien being screaming through the comms. Just the sound of metal and stars and a single man keeping them alive.

“Alright,” he said to the empty bridge. “You win, universe. This’ll do.”

He tapped one last command into the console, setting the ship to autopilot, and settled in.

Phainon had sunk deep into the pilot’s cradle—more a half-cocoon than a chair at this point—and the blanket wound tighter around him until—

He exhaled a slow sigh, fingers flicking idle patterns across a console's edge.

"You could just tell me what the problem is, you know," he said at last.

Silence answered him. Then, the subtle change in the air—weight shifting against the bulkhead, the faint rustle of fabric. Someone pretending not to exist.

Phainon didn't turn around. "I don't like to think of myself as a rude host," he went on, conversational, "but I can't exactly fix what I don't know, Mydeimos."

For a while, there was nothing. Then, a shadow detached itself from the dim amber of the wall.

Mydei stepped forward, the soft light catching in his pale hair and the faint redness of his cheek (was he cold? He'll have to adjust the ship's temperature later.). His tone was quiet, almost neutral. "You're up early."

Phainon finally turned, unimpressed. "As are you. And, if I'm recalling correctly—this whole week?"

A pause. One of those short silences that say *you're right, but I'm not giving you the satisfaction.*

Instead of answering, Mydei drifted closer to the viewport. He looked out at the asteroid field, where distant rocks gleamed in slow, silvery arcs.

"What are you doing?" he asked idly.

"Adjusting our trajectory," Phainon said easily. "Field's dense, but manageable. We're riding the edge to stay off scans. Efficient and scenic—my favorite combination."

Mydei made a quiet sound in his throat. Not quite agreement, not quite disapproval.

Phainon chuckled faintly. "Something on your mind, captain?"

For a long moment, the other man didn’t answer. Just stood there, gaze fixed on the window, jaw set tight in a way that made Phainon want to kiss his worries away.

Then, quietly—too quietly:

“When we reach orbit, I’ll leave.”

Phainon stilled. His hand hovered over the console.

Ah.

So that’s what this was about.

He should’ve known. Mydei never lingered anywhere he couldn’t navigate himself. Never trusted what wasn’t his to command.

Still—it hit harder than he wanted to admit.

He leaned back a little further, letting the cradle shift with him, pretending nonchalance. “I see,” he murmured.

Mydei didn’t stop there. “You’ve done enough,” he said, still looking out at the stars. His reflection shimmered faintly on the glass. “You got me off Kremnos, kept me alive long enough to get this far. That’s… more than I can ask for. Once we reach the Grove, I’ll handle the rest.”

Phainon arched an eyebrow, tone casual. “Should I be flattered, or worried that you sound like you’re resigning from a job?”

Mydei’s scoffed. “Neither.”

He turned then, and looked directly at Phainon.

“You shouldn’t concern yourself with what happens next.”

Phainon tilted his head, smiling. “Things that aren’t my business, you mean?”

“That’s one way to put it.”

Mydei started walking again, slow, unhurried. It had that cinematic rhythm—like a dream half remembered, his voice calming even as he moved past.

“I meant what I said. You’ve done more than enough.” He didn’t look at him as he spoke. “You don’t owe me anything, Phainon.”

Phainon watched him go. Mydei’s hand brushed the back of the cradle in passing—close enough to feel the static hum between them, but not close enough to linger.

He could let him leave.

He could.

But where was the fun in that?

Phainon’s hand shot out, catching Mydei’s wrist before he could take another step.

Mydei froze, startled but not alarmed—his head turned just enough for Phainon to catch the faint raise of an eyebrow.

“Now, now,” Phainon said, “let’s get to know each other first, yeah? No need to rush off. We’ve still got ten hours to kill.”

Mydei’s eyes narrowed. “Deliverer,” he said lowly.

Ah. That again.

Phainon almost smiled. The title had started as a joke a few days ago—Mydei, in one of his rare dry moments, had called him Deliverer after catching him hauling a crate twice his size without breaking stride. The name had stuck, though Phainon was still undecided whether it was meant as mockery or reluctant endearment.

“Mm,” Phainon hummed, feigning thoughtfulness. “That’s the tone you use when you think you’re in charge of a conversation.”

Mydei’s brow ticked. “And that’s the tone you use when you think charm substitutes for sense.”

Phainon shrugged. “You’d be surprised how often it works.”

Mydei tugged his wrist, intent on pulling away—but Phainon’s grip held firm. A subtle twist of movement, deceptively relaxed, and the momentum tipped.

A startled breath—then gravity took over.

Phainon caught him easily, arm braced around his back, the other still wrapped around his wrist. Mydei’s knee landed against the edge of the cradle, body half-hovering over Phainon’s lap.

The proximity was instant and dizzying. Mydei’s hair brushed Phainon’s cheek; the fabric of his shirt bunched where Phainon’s fingers pressed.

For once, Mydei looked almost uncertain.

Phainon tutted softly, tilting his head, hand sliding up to nudge Mydei’s chin until their eyes met. “You never listen, do you?”

The blanket slipped halfway off Phainon’s shoulder, catching on Mydei’s sleeve. The console light painted them in soft gold and shadow.

Neither moved.

Mydei’s expression barely shifted, but the sound he made—a low, dismissive humph—gave him away. He turned his head aside, eyes flicking toward the viewport instead of Phainon.

“Well? I’m waiting.”

He almost let out a victorious whoop when Mydei finally gave in.

Albeit very reluctantly.

“…I have trouble sleeping here.”

Phainon tilted his head, curious. “Yeah?”

Mydei exhaled slowly. “It’s unfamiliar here. The air’s too thin. The lights dim, then flare again when the systems cycle. Every noise sounds closer than it is.” He paused, lips downturned. “It’s like the ship’s alive and it’s watching me breathe.”

He hesitated, fingertips brushing the edge of the pilot cradle. “It keeps me alert. On edge. Waiting for something to happens”

Phainon blinked once, then made a small, drawn-out sound of understanding. “Ohhh.” His mouth curved, tone playful. “Why didn’t you just say so?”

Before Mydei could ask what that was supposed to mean, Phainon’s hands settled lightly at his waist.

Mydei startled, jerking back instinctively. “What the—”

Phainon’s grip held firm—not harsh, but undeniably strong. His smile widened, bright in the dim light. “Relax.”

“Phainon.” The name came out as a warning.

Too late. With a deft pull, smooth and practiced, Phainon drew him closer. Mydei’s balance tipped forward, and the ship’s pilot cradle responded to the movement with a quiet mechanical hum—widening, reclining, reshaping itself to fit them both.

By the time Mydei caught his breath, he was fully seated on Phainon’s lap.

“What the hell are you—”

“Helping,” Phainon interrupted lightly, one arm braced behind Mydei to keep him from sliding off. “You’re wound up. I’m fixing it.”

“The chair is *fixing* it,” Mydei muttered, glaring down at him.

“The chair’s doing great,” Phainon said, amused. “You, not so much.”

The cradle shifted again—another gentle recline—and the blanket pooled around them like a second heartbeat. Mydei looked ready to snap a retort, but the absurdity of it all got the better of him. His glare dulled into disbelief.

“You have three seconds,” he said as warning, “to explain yourself before I __”

“—help you sleep.” Phainon’s voice was gentle, as he rubbed at one eye with mock drowsiness. “You said you’re tense. I can regulate emotional feedback—pulse rhythm, hormonal drift, all that fun bio nonsense. Most Okhemans can’t, but I can.”

Mydei gave him a flat, disbelieving stare. “You expect me to believe—”

“—that proximity makes it easier?” Phainon interrupted again, leaning his head back. “Obviously. Go on. Tell me you don’t feel better already.”

Mydei opened his mouth. Closed it again.

Silence lingered—then he frowned faintly, realizing the tightness in his chest had already eased. The constant alertness had ebbed into something quieter, softer.

“…I suppose it does,” he admitted at last, the words quiet and grudging.

Phainon’s teasing faded into something gentler. “Good to know,” he murmured, his tone shifting lower, sleepier. “I used to do this with Cyrene when she was little. She’d wake up whenever the gravity flux hit. Said the air felt ‘too much.’ I’d hold her until it smoothed out. Always worked.”

Mydei blinked, surprised by the warmth in his voice—that easy fondness threaded through memory.

After a while, Mydei’s posture softened, the rigid edge easing as he let his weight settle more naturally. His hands rested near Phainon’s shoulders, fingertips brushing the soft fabric of the blanket pooled beneath them.

Outside, the asteroid field drifted in slow motion, their faint light blinking in and out across the hull.

Phainon's breathing had slowed, eyelids fluttering as sleep tugged at the edges. "You can stay here tonight if you'd like," he murmured, voice dropping to something almost inaudible. "Or go. I won't stop you."

For a long time, Mydei didn't answer. Then, in a tone so soft it barely disturbed the air:

"…I'll stay."

Phainon smiled at that—a small, content curve that reached his eyes. "Good," he whispered, half-asleep.

The chair adjusted one last time, recognizing the shift in weight, and Mydei instinctively leaned closer—drawn toward the warmth, toward stillness. His head found its way against Phainon's shoulder, the steady pulse beneath calming, grounding.

Outside, the stars drifted. Inside, only quiet breathing.

By the time the control lights dimmed for the night cycle, Phainon had dozed off—and the quiet, steady warmth still pressed against his chest did not move away.

Usually, there would've been hours of prep work before setting foot on the Grove of Epiphany.

Ship clearance. Identity verification. Half a dozen bureaucratic headaches wrapped in polite language. The Scholars were notorious for it—every visitor expected to crawl through protocol before being allowed within a kilometer of the planet's surface.

But Phainon, of course, was an exception.

He always was.

Once a student of the Grove, now something between guest and anomaly, the gates opened for him without a fuss. The world below welcomed him back with a soft hum, the air alive with electric fragrance and chlorophyll haze.

And besides—he had other things on his mind.

The wind here carried warmth; sunlight dappled through silver-veined leaves that whispered with soundless energy. Mydei knelt amid it all, just off the walkway's edge, beside a patch of flora that glimmered faintly with bioluminescent veins. A translucent pot cradled the bloom he'd been tending since they left orbit—an Asterion filament, glowing brighter the longer his hands lingered near.

Phainon lingered at a distance, one hand in his pocket, the other shading his eyes as if the sight might blind him. Not the plant. Mydei. The rare quiet that came over him when he thought no one was watching.

"…You know," Phainon called, tone teasing, "if I didn't know better, I'd say you're trying to charm that thing more than you ever try with me."

Mydei didn't even glance up. "That's because the plant listens when spoken to."

"Ouch. Brutal."

He wandered closer, boots crunching softly over the crystalline gravel, hands clasped behind his back in mock authority. "Alright, Doctor Doom-and-Bloom, tell me—how long until you start lecturing it about proper soil pH?"

A quiet sigh left Mydei as he brushed a fingertip over one of the petals. "The plant doesn't need to be lectured."

"Sure, but I do?"

"You just volunteered yourself," Mydei murmured.

Phainon crouched down beside him. "Hey, I was being supportive."

“You were being distracting.”

“Same thing, really.”

Mydei sighed.

Phainon leaned in, pretending to study the flower with the gravity of a man solving cosmic mysteries. “So, what is this one, anyway? It looks like it’s trying to glow itself into another dimension.”

“An Asterion filament,” Mydei said, looks like someone’s been doing their research. “They react to kinetic energy. The more movement nearby, the brighter they get.”

Phainon blinked. “So it likes attention.”

“Unlike some.”

“That’s rude.”

He reached out before Mydei could stop him, brushing a knuckle against one of the petals—

A flare of gold light burst outward, bright enough to sting the air.

“Whoa—”

Mydei’s hand darted out, steadying the pot before it tipped. “You are going to make it combust at this rate.”

“Reflex test!” Phainon said quickly, raising his hands in mock surrender. “And you passed with flying colors.”

Mydei exhaled slowly, looking every inch the man debating whether the flower or his companion would be more deserving of being thrown into the compost. “You’re insufferable.”

“And you adore me.”

He ignored him.

Phainon tilted his head. The air shimmered faintly between them—hazy sunlight through glass. Something too gentle to name.

Then, as if on cue, Phainon broke it. “Anyway, back to the topic—we’re almost there.”

Mydei brushed his hands off, his composure sliding neatly back into place. “How far?”

Phainon sing-songed, “Very close~,” already taking a few steps ahead. Then, without warning, he reached back, caught Mydei’s hand, and tugged.

“Phainon.” Mydei said, carrying that mild warning that usually preceded an act of violence. “Where are we going?”

Phainon didn’t slow, glancing over his shoulder with that infuriating half-smile. “Looks like you’re getting your tour a bit early.”

“…Tour?”

“Of course. You said you wanted to see the Grove.”

“I thought we had to—”

“We do, but that’s boring, and this isn’t.” He patted his shoulder. “Trust me. I’ve got the perfect first stop.”

Mydei sighed quietly, but didn’t resist. He followed, still holding Phainon’s hand like it was an inconvenience he didn’t truly want to remove.

The path curved—and suddenly, the Grove opened before them.

It was like stepping into a waking dream.

The world here was color, alive and endless—buildings that shimmered with breathlike pulses, grown instead of built, veined with light from the petrified bones of Cerces herself. Great tendrils of vine and circuitry wove

together across the skyline, a marriage of nature and mind, of life that refused to die.

Phainon slowed, letting Mydei take it in. His expression softened, a rare thing—open awe, unguarded. The light caught in his eyes, refracting gold and green.

Phainon watched him quietly.

There was something satisfying in it. The sight of Mydei in color. In light. In *this* world.

And something else—something that tightened faintly in his chest as he thought, absurdly, *don't get used to it.*

But he smiled anyway. "And for what could it be," he began dramatically, sweeping an arm wide, "except the humble, world-renowned, ever-prestigious medical institution—the Twilight Courtyard!"

He stopped walking, beaming, gesturing grandly toward a towering structure of iridescent crystal whose surface rippled like water when the wind brushed against it.

"Tada!"

Mydei blinked at him, expression perfectly neutral. "That was unnecessarily dramatic."

Phainon coughed. "Nevermind."

He strode ahead, waving to a few passing Scholars who lit up at his presence, offering cheerful greetings that he half-returned. His steps quickened the closer they got, as though pulled by something familiar.

Finally, he stopped before a door at the far end of the courtyard. Its metal shimmered faintly with embedded sigils that pulsed softly when he approached. Phainon pressed his palm against it—the glyphs brightened, recognizing him, and the door slid open with a low sigh.

He turned and swept into a theatrical bow. “After you.”

Mydei regarded him a moment—then stepped forward without comment, brushing past him as he entered.

Phainon’s laughter followed quietly, soft as the door sealed behind them.

Mydei glanced around once they stepped inside, taking in the gleaming walls and the faint antiseptic tang in the air. “Now what?”

Before Phainon could answer—

“Phainon?”

He turned fast, instincts snapping taut before his brain caught up.

Then he blinked, tension uncoiling the second he recognized the voice.

“Hyacine!” He beamed instantly, disarming and bright. “Perfect timing, actually—long time no see! Here, I wanted to introduce you to—”

He didn’t get the chance.

“Not here,” she said, voice quick and light but carrying that unmistakable *don’t argue* undercurrent. Before he could even react, she seized his wrist, caught Mydei’s sleeve with her other hand, and hauled both of them down the corridor.

Phainon barely managed to keep his footing. Mydei, predictably, didn’t so much as trip.

They were swept through a pair of automatic doors that hissed open just long enough for Hyacine to shove them into a compact infirmary before slamming shut again with a decisive click.

The silence that followed was immediate and profound.

Phainon blinked, slightly winded, and looked from her to the sealed door. “…Alright. Definitely stronger than I remember.”

Hyacine straightened, smoothing her dress with both hands. “You make me sound fragile.”

“Not fragile,” he said. “Just deceptively sparkly.”

Her eyes narrowed—but the sigh of relief she had after gave her away. “You haven’t changed.”

“And you have?” he shot back, light as ever.

That earned him a full smile this time—bright, genuine, and terribly at odds with the look that followed.

Then she fixed him with a stare sharp enough to cut through alloy. “You’ve already told me about your… *companion*.”

“Oh,” Phainon said.

There was a pause.

Then another, slightly more painful one.

Right. The transmission. The one where he may or may not have described Mydei as “some guy who he lied to not remembering he was a galactic commander.” Yeah. That.

And yelling Mydei’s name the second she appeared—possibly not the smoothest choice in retrospect.

He cleared his throat, trying for composure. “…Yes. That companion. Hyacine, this is Mydei.”

Hyacine’s expression shifted almost instantly; her tone gentled, bright again. “Ah—so you’re the one he’s been worried about.” She smiled, extending a hand that shimmered faintly with the light from her wrist device. “It’s a pleasure.”

Mydei inclined his head slightly, every movement respectful. “Likewise.”

There was a brief, quiet moment of mutual study—Hyacine's open, assessing gaze against Mydei's subtle one.

Phainon could practically *feel* the polite silence expanding between them.

He sighed under his breath. "Fantastic. Two statues. My favorite social dynamic."

That earned him twin looks—one unimpressed, one mildly disbelieving.

"So!" he said, clapping his hands once, too brightly. "Should we get started before I'm executed for breathing too loudly?"

Hyacine's cracked; she huffed a small laugh, shaking her head. "Right, yes—let's. Before you break something."

She brushed a strand of pink-blue hair behind her ear, stepped closer to the medbay cot, and gestured for Mydei to sit. "Here, please. It'll be easier to get a full read from the diagnostic core."

Mydei obeyed without question, perching neatly on the edge.

"And you," Hyacine said, turning toward Phainon, "either sit quietly or wait outside. According to your very dramatic message, this is going to take a while."

Phainon immediately dropped onto a nearby counter, crossing one leg over the other. "Do continue. I'll be quiet as a star in vacuum."

"Mm-hm."

She didn't bother responding further, only turned her attention back to her instruments. Her hands moved with practiced precision—quick, sure, gentle. The scanner hummed softly, light drifting across Mydei's profile.

Phainon leaned back, watching the two of them—the healer at work, the patient perfectly still. He smiled faintly, chin in hand.

The day had barely begun, and already, he could feel the headache blooming behind his eyes.

It was going to be a long one.

At some point, Phainon must've dozed off.

That was the only explanation for why he jolted like a man electrocuted when a very gentle tap brushed his shoulder.

He flailed, nearly catapulting himself out of the chair—only for a strong hand to catch him before his skull could introduce itself to the floor.

When the blur settled, he found himself half-hanging off the cot, Hyacine standing beside him with an expression that was disappointed but not surprised, and Mydei holding him upright with one effortless grip. Both wore identical looks: unimpressed, faintly exhausted.

They could've been siblings.

Phainon cleared his throat and wriggled free, tugging his coat straight like dignity was a fabric he could smooth back into place. "Ahem. Right. So… you guys wrapped it up?"

Hyacine's smile was kind, but her eyes carried the quiet, terrifying calm of someone who spent years keeping warriors alive through sheer willpower, and about to do the same to him. "For now," she said lightly, stylus tapping against her tablet. "Everything reads within range—mostly." Her tone cooled a few degrees on that last word, and when she glanced up at him, the look said *we will discuss this later.*

Phainon managed a polite, long-suffering look of his own that translated neatly to *yes ma'am, later ma'am.*

Her answering nod said, *good*.

To anyone else, it would have looked like gibberish.

“Well,” she continued, locking the tablet, “while you were peacefully drooling into my patient’s linens, I called up Professor Anaxa. He should be here within thirty minutes.”

Phainon blinked. “You called Anaxa?”

“You did say urgent,” she replied, smoothing a strand of hair behind her ear.

He gave a low whistle. “That’s… a decision.”

She looked like she had a migraine incoming. “And yet one of us had to make it.”

“Fair.”

The faintest crease of exhaustion marrowed her features, and for a moment the clinical medbay lights caught on the fine, translucent markings under her skin—Skyfolk vascular lines, threads that pulsed in time with her heartbeat. The air around her always smelled faintly of rain, a side effect of the microcurrents her kind naturally generated.

“While we wait,” she said, glancing at him, “you still wanted that checkup, didn’t you?”

Phainon sighed theatrically but nodded. “Might as well. Haven’t had one since you last bullied me into it.”

“That sounds about right.” She smiled sweetly. “Try not to move.”

She stepped closer, her presence a comfort as she retrieved a thin diagnostic scanner. Its soft sound layered over the distant buzz of filtration vents, the Grove’s heartbeat somewhere deep below the station’s floor.

Phainon relaxed into the chair while she worked, eyes half-lidded. “You know,” he murmured, “you’re wasted on the Grove. You could open a clinic anywhere and people would line up just to have you scold and treat them.”

“Scolding keeps them alive,” she said, not looking up. “Now stop talking or I’ll find a reason to keep you here overnight.”

He shut up immediately.

Mydei sat a short distance away, relaxed as ever. Polite. Still. Almost distant—except for the faint tilt of his head that suggested he was listening to everything.

It wasn't until Hyacine leaned forward to steady Phainon's arm, her fingers brushing his skin, that something imperceptible shifted.

It was so subtle at first that he almost dismissed it—a slight drop in temperature, the faint drag in the flow of space around them. But being Okheman meant he *felt* it, like a dissonant note caught under the skin.

Phainon frowned faintly. "Hm."

Hyacine paused mid-motion, hand still on his wrist. The light from the scanner flickered once.

"…You feel that?" he asked quietly.

She didn't answer. Her eyes were focused past his shoulder, pupils narrowing.

He tilted his head, following her line of sight. "What—"

He turned—

—and the chill vanished like it had never existed.

Mydei sat exactly as before, composed, serene. The soft glow from the nearby panel haloed his hair, his expression calm and faintly bored.

For half a second, Phainon wondered if he'd imagined it.

Then, because he didn't know what else to do, he raised a hand with a lazy, playful wave. "Hi~"

Mydei blinked slowly, and lifted his hand in the smallest echo of the gesture.

Phainon smiled, turning back around, tone bright. “Anyway! You were saying something about how stunningly healthy I am?”

Hyacine hesitated for just a heartbeat too long, then smoothed her voice. “Yes. Surprisingly, everything looks normal.”

“Surprisingly?” he said.

“For someone who never sleeps, eats like a wayward pigeon, and insists on wandering into crossfire for fun? Miraculous, really.”

He grinned sheepishly. “Talent.”

She gave a small huff of laughter before returning to her screen. The scanner light shimmered against her hair, and he caught the faint scent of rain again as she moved.

They stayed like that for a few minutes—quiet, familiar, easy. When she finally withdrew the scanner, she set it aside with a soft click.

“Well,” she said, tone warm again, “still reckless, still loud, still alive. I’ll take it.”

“Hey, consistency is key.”

“Consistency,” she echoed, amused. “That’s what you’re calling it now.”

Their shared smile felt like sunlight through glass.

After a beat, Phainon leaned back, stretching his arms behind his head. “Say, where’s Professor Anaxa anyway? Thought he’d—”

He didn’t finish.

The door slammed open hard enough to rattle the ceiling panels. Hyacine jumped, nearly dropping her tablet.

Phainon closed his eyes and sighed, already regretting his life choices. “… Of course.”

“Professor Anaxa,” he said after a pause, not turning around, “you certainly know how to make an entrance.”

A cold voice answered, each syllable clipped like the edge of a blade. “It’s *Anaxagoras*.”

Phainon winced. “Ah. Right. Some things never change.”

Phainon waited a full beat before daring to turn around.

Anaxagoras—because stars forbid you ever call him “Anaxa”—stood framed in the doorway, one gloved hand still resting on the metal rim like he owned it. The man hadn’t aged a day. Same immaculate posture, same composure that made people instinctively straighten their backs. His voice, when it came, could still make a classroom go silent out of sheer survival instinct. (Partially because he *would* pull a weapon on you if you interrupted his lecture. Only once, but the legend stuck.)

Phainon cleared his throat and pasted on his best smile. “Well, uh—this is awkward timing but, uh—Professor, this is Mydei.” He gestured toward Mydei, who stood at his usual level of tranquil that bordered on eerie. “Mydei, meet Professor Anaxagoras, my *lovely* former instructor back when I was still pretending to be a model student.”

Anaxagoras didn’t even spare him a glance. His gaze snapped straight to Mydei—sharp, assessing, as if trying to read the entire man in one go.

“You’re coming with me,” he said flatly.

Phainon blinked. “Now, now, let’s not be too—”

“Okay,” Mydei said.

Phainon’s jaw nearly hit the floor. “I—wait, *what*?”

Hyacine coughed delicately into her hand. Phainon swore she was smiling.

He whipped around, offended. “You agree *that* easily? Where was that cooperative spirit when I was trying to stop you from almost *touching* a live

reactor core?”

Mydei just tilted his head in mild apology, a ghost of amusement flickering in his eyes.

Before Phainon could gather enough outrage to keep going, Hyacine—sweet, deceptively gentle Hyacine—rested a hand over his mouth and turned to the professor with a radiant smile. “That would be wonderful, Professor Anaxagoras. Thank you for taking the time.”

Phainon muffled a protest, something along the lines of “*wonderful my ass*”, but one look from her—polite, serene, deadly—made the words die a quick, merciful death.

Right. Message received. Shut up.

Anaxagoras gave the faintest nod, his coat whispering against the floor as he turned. “Follow me,” he said.

Mydei didn’t hesitate. Just walked out after him without so much as a backward glance.

The door shut behind them with an airtight hiss.

Phainon stared for a long moment, hands on his hips. “Well,” he said finally, “that wasn’t ominous at all.”

Hyacine set her tablet aside, exhaling softly. “To be fair, that’s *mild* for him.”

“*Mild?* I once saw him reduce a Council member to tears for mispronouncing ‘axial inversion.’”

Hyacine gave a faint laugh, but it didn’t reach her eyes.

Phainon squinted. “What’s got him all ruffled anyway? He looked ready to vivisect the air itself.”

She hesitated—always a bad sign. “I may have… forwarded him the results from my diagnostic earlier.”

He perked up. “Oh, *that*.” He leaned back against the counter, arms folded. “Right, you said you wanted to wait till we were alone to talk about it. And look at that—” he gestured broadly, “privacy achieved.”

Hyacine didn’t immediately answer. She turned toward her workstation, flipping through a few sheets of synth-paper. The hum of the medbay filled the silence, accompanied by the soft pulse of the hydroponic vents.

Phainon waited, for once not rushing her.

When she finally looked back, her voice was quieter. “The readings were strange,” she said. “There was something… old. Titanal resonance.”

Phainon’s smile faded. “Titanal? You’re kidding.”

“I wish.” She pressed a hand against the console, eyes flicking to him. “Not residual, either. Active. Traceable.”

His tone shifted instantly, the levity dropping away like a mask. “Whose signature?”

Hyacine’s expression tightened. “Nikador’s.”

For a second, the only sound was the hum of the diagnostic screens.

Phainon went still. “You’re sure?”

“Triple-checked. It wasn’t a misread.”

He rubbed his temples, muttering something under his breath that might’ve been a prayer or a curse. “That’s impossible.”

Hyacine shook her head. “I know. And yet.” She drew in a deep breath, her bioluminescent markings dimming slightly. “Everything else was normal—organ health, energy flow, cognitive rhythm. He’s perfectly fine. But the

Titanal levels were through the roof. If I didn’t know better, I’d say he’s acting as a conduit.”

“That hasn’t happened since—”

“The Fall,” she finished quietly.

Phainon looked down, jaw tight. “You think it’s connected to the recent distortions? The ones eating at the fringe colonies?”

“Maybe.” She exhaled, pressing the heel of her palm against her forehead. “The readings don’t match the usual anomaly patterns, but they’re close enough to make me uneasy. Whatever’s going on, it’s not just a fluke.”

When she lifted her gaze again, her voice softened. “Be careful, Phainon. Please. If Mydei really is tied to that signature, we might be standing too close to something we don’t understand.”

He smiled faintly, though it didn’t reach his eyes. “When have I ever not been careful?”

“Do you want the list alphabetically or chronologically?”

He laughed, short and genuine, though it dissolved quickly. “Point taken.”

A beat of silence passed between them, quieter now, less professional—something more like friendship resting heavy between the words.

Then Phainon straightened, adjusting his coat with that overdone flourish of his. “Well, looks like I’ve overextended my welcome. As always, Doctor Hyacine, a delight.”

She sighed, but there was fondness behind it. “Phainon—”

“I’ll see myself out,” he said, already halfway to the door.

“Give them a few hours,” she said suddenly.

He paused mid-step, back to her. "…You always know everything, don't you?"

"Someone has to."

He snorted, the corner of his mouth twitching.

"Maybe," she continued, "take that time to go out. Get some air. Do something not self-destructive for once. You'll be here longer than planned anyway."

He turned just enough to flash her a look. "Shopping therapy. How very clinical of you."

But something lit up behind his eyes—mischief, sudden and bright.

Hyacine immediately groaned. "No. Whatever you're thinking, *no*."

"Oh yes," he said, far too pleased with himself. "Mydei's got a sweet tooth. Maybe I'll bring him something nice. Chocolate, maybe. Or those crystalline sugar leaves from the Grove markets."

"Phainon."

He waved her off, strolling out before she could finish.

The doors hissed closed behind him.

Hyacine stood there for a moment, hand over her eyes. "Trouble," she murmured. "Every damn time."

The medbay hummed back to its usual rhythm, faintly smelling of ozone and rain.

The Grove was at its loudest during midday.

Music bled from every corner—bells, laughter, the rhythmic clatter of glass trinkets being shaken for attention. The air shimmered with scent and color:

spice, pollen, ozone. Phainon wandered through it like someone who'd lost his purpose halfway through the journey and decided to just enjoy the detour.

He had a bag slung over his shoulder, weighed down by… things. He wasn't even sure what half of them were anymore. Some merchant had pressed glowing seed-pods into his hand, swearing they "improved mental conductivity." Another had sold him a pair of floating glass fish that "symbolized equilibrium." He didn't even *like* fish.

Whatever. He had time.

By the time the Grove's skies dimmed from gold to violet, the noise had thinned, and Phainon realized he hadn't seen Anaxagoras since morning. The man had shut himself and Mydei away in the study and hadn't emerged since.

He didn't actually see him again until dawn.

"You'd think you were a damn dog with how long you've been parked out here."

Phainon cracked an eye open. He was sitting cross-legged against the wall outside Anaxagoras's office, coat half-buttoned, hair a mess, an open bag of sweets in his lap.

"Four hours," Anaxagoras added mildly, like he was commenting on the weather.

Phainon yawned. "I call it dedication."

"I call it a waste of floor space."

He grinned. "Missed me?"

"Desperately," Anaxagoras said dryly, stepping over him to unlock the door.

Phainon stretched his legs and stood, brushing himself off. “So,” he said, tone casual but his curiosity edged in it, “you and Mydei finally done in there?”

Anaxagoras didn’t answer immediately. He adjusted his gloves, straightened a sleeve, a deliberate pause before replying, “Who knows?”

That… wasn’t normal.

Phainon blinked. “I’m sorry—what?”

“Curious patient you’ve brought me.”

“Yeah, he’s adorable. What about him?”

Anaxagoras’s gaze flicked toward him briefly. “Adorable,” he echoed, with the kind of tone that suggested *deep scientific offense.*

“Uh-huh.” Phainon squinted at him. “You’re being weirdly vague, and it’s scaring me a little.”

“I’m being accurate,” Anaxagoras said, not missing a beat.

“Right. And I’m being patient,” Phainon muttered. “So maybe you could tell me what you actually found?”

That finally earned him a look, more a side-eye really. “You want the short version or the one that makes you regret asking?”

Phainon raised a brow. “Let’s gamble.”

Anaxagoras folded his hands behind his back. “He’s not just recovering memories. It’s more so he’s reconstructing them.”

Phainon frowned. “Isn’t that the same thing?”

“No.” He said immediately. “Recollection is retrieval. Reconstruction is creation. He’s piecing things together that may not have survived in their original state.”

“So he’s… improvising?”

“In a manner of speaking.” Anaxagoras’s aqquited, but there was something beneath it—a note of concern. How odd. “That’s the danger. Reconstruction breeds deviation.”

Phainon tilted his head. “You mean he’s—what—rewriting himself?”

“That’s one way to describe it.”

Something about the way he said it made the back of Phainon’s neck prickle.

“So what are you suggesting? That I stop him?”

“I’m suggesting,” Anaxagoras said, turning to face him fully now, “that you pay attention. If what he rebuilds isn’t what you remember… you’ll need to decide whether you still recognize who’s standing in front of you.”

Phainon blinked, caught off guard by the sudden weight in his tone. “Bit dramatic, don’t you think?”

Anaxagoras’s expression didn’t change. “If he ever looks at you like he remembers you,” he started, “Just run. Nikador’s signature isn’t one to be underestimated. Don’t take any chances.”

Then he stepped past him, hand briefly brushing Phainon’s shoulder in a gesture that felt more like punctuation than comfort. “He’s still inside. Try not to distract him.”

Phainon watched him go, the air in the hallway still humming faintly from the exchange.

“…Right,” he muttered to himself. “That’s definitely not ominous at all.”

He stood there a while, running the words over again. “Run.”

Yeah, sure. That sounded like Anaxagoras’s version of affection.

He shook it off with a sharp exhale and adjusted the strap of his bag. No sense getting worked up over riddles. Whatever weird theory Anaxagoras had cooked up, it didn't change what he came here for.

Besides, Mydei was fine. Probably.

He started walking.

The study door slid open with a soft hiss, and light spilled out—soft blue, tinted with gold from the crystalline lamps.

Phainon stepped inside, already reaching for the bag. "You know," he said casually, "some of us age while waiting outside, and—"

He stopped.

Mydei was at one of the tables, hair loosely tied back, strands of blonde falling against his cheek. He was bent over one of Anaxagoras's scanning lenses, eyes narrowed slightly in concentration. A soft hum filled the space—the device running, his faint breathing, the quiet world that formed around him when he focused.

Phainon leaned against the doorframe, watching him for a beat too long.

He looked… unfairly pretty like that.

Phainon sighed helplessly. "You really like stealing other people's labs, huh?"

Mydei didn't look up. "Borrowing," he corrected mildly.

"Sure, sure. That's what thieves say before prison."

"Prison implies they caught me."

Phainon laughed under his breath, crossing the room. "Touché."

He stopped beside the table, set the bag down, and nudged it toward him. "Brought you offerings."

Mydei finally glanced up. “Offerings?”

“Tribute. Payment. Bribe. Take your pick.”

He peeked inside, lifting out one of the sugar petals. “You bought these from the central market?”

“Technically, yes. Realistically, I think I was scammed.”

“Most likely.”

Phainon pressed a hand over his chest, mock wounded. “Your faith in me is astounding.”

Mydei smiled faintly, then popped one of the petals into his mouth. “Sweet.”

“Right? I figured it fits your personality.”

“Questionable taste?”

“Addictively pleasant.”

He melted when Mydei’s ears turned faintly pink at that, though the man’s expression didn’t otherwise change. He just went back to his instruments, movements careful.

Phainon leaned against the table again. For a second, everything Anaxagoras said earlier dimmed, replaced by this small, quiet moment—the rustle of paper, the hum of machines, the faint sound of Mydei crunching on another sugar petal like nothing else in the universe mattered.

And maybe that was enough.

“Hey,” Phainon said softly.

Mydei hummed, eyes still on the scanner. “Hm?”

“Just making sure you’re real.”

That earned a small, sidelong glance—half confusion, half question—before he looked back down again.

“Unfortunately for you,” Mydei said, “I am.”

Phainon felt himself loosen up. “Lucky me.”

“Welp,” He started finally, stretching his arms until his back popped. “Guess we’re stuck here a bit longer. Doubt Anaxa’s gonna stop poking at your brain anytime soon. He’s probably printing copies of your thoughts as we speak.”

Mydei looked up from the counter, idly picking at the edge of another sugar petal before popping it into his mouth. “He mentioned something about ‘extended observation.’”

“See? I told you.” Phainon gestured with both hands like he’d just been proven right in court. “You’ve officially become the world’s prettiest lab rat.”

“I don’t mind,” Mydei said thoughtfully.

Phainon stared. “That wasn’t a compliment, y’know.”

“It sounded like one.”

He blinked. “That’s… honestly worse.”

Mydei hummed, completely unfazed.

Phainon sighed, dragging a hand through his hair. “Alright, fine. While our beloved mad scientist does whatever he’s doing, we might as well figure out where we’re staying. Any preferences for your temporary living arrangements?”

Mydei didn’t even hesitate. “Can I sleep with you?”

Phainon inhaled wrong. “*—I’m sorry, what?”*

Unbothered, Mydei brushed a crumb off his sleeve. “It helped before. It was calming.”

Phainon froze mid-cough. “Oh. Oh, you mean—sleep sleep.”

“Yes. That is what I said.”

“Right. Totally. Sleep sleep. Naps. Innocent, platonic, medically recommended sleep.” Phainon nodded like a man trying to convince himself of gravity. “Yeah. Sure. Why not. Love that for us.”

Mydei just blinked. “You look flushed.”

“Do I?” Phainon croaked, rubbing his neck. “Probably—uh—low blood sugar. Nothing to do with the topic. Completely unrelated.”

He cleared his throat, desperately changing tracks. “So! Anything else? Blankets? Pillows? You like soft lighting or more of a candlelight-gothic thing? Need me to hum lullabies? I do a mean impression of ocean waves —”

“No.” Mydei’s tone shifted faintly—absent, half somewhere else. “The sooner we start, the better, no?”

Phainon blinked. “Start what—oh, right, *the study.* Yeah. Of course. That.”

Before he could embarrass himself further, Mydei stood, adjusting his sleeves with that quiet grace that made Phainon forget words for a second. “I’ll meet you outside. From what I’ve overheard, I’m assuming you already found us a place?”

“Caught red-handed!” Phainon exclaimed, throwing up his hands. “You got me.”

“Show me, then.”

“Gladly,” Phainon said, maybe too quickly.

They looked at each other eye to eye before Mydei slipped out the door.

Phainon stayed behind for a beat, reaching for his bag. He was halfway through tightening the cord when his fingers stilled.

Mydei was humming.

Soft, rhythmic, something familiar.

Phainon frowned. It took him a moment to place it—and when he did, he couldn’t help but still.

A Kremnoan hymn.

Old, very old. The kind sung under breath in temples.

Phainon’s hand hovered mid-air. For a heartbeat, his chest tightened.

Then he huffed out a shaky laugh. “Right. Because that’s not at all ominous,” he muttered. “He probably just… likes the tune.”

He slung the bag over his shoulder, raising his voice. “—coming!”

And just like that, the tension cracked. His cheer slid back into place, easy and bright as ever, as he jogged after Mydei down the hall—sweets clinking faintly with every step.

Whatever it was, he’d figure it out later.

For now, there was someone waiting.

It happened slowly, the way things that change your life usually do.

One day he was pacing sterile halls, arguing with Anaxa over containment parameters and caffeine limits. The next, he was here—somewhere between sunlight and dreamlight—watching dew roll down glowing roots while pretending this was still part of the job.

It had been about three weeks, give or take. Long enough for the Grove to start recognizing his footsteps. Long enough for him to forget what silence

without breathing trees sounded like.

And long enough for Mydei to start taking morning walks.

Phainon told himself he only followed out of routine—security detail, supervision, nothing personal. But the truth was far less professional. Mydei would drift through the outer paths at dawn, hair unbound, the pale gold of the sun catching on it like threads of fire. He always carried tea. Always seemed to know which roots not to step on, like the Grove itself bent around him.

Sometimes Phainon would walk a few paces behind, pretending to check readings on his wristband while memorizing the shape of Mydei's silhouette against the light. One morning, Mydei had smiled at something in the fog—soft, almost private—and that had been that. Phainon decided no sunrise was worth watching unless that smile came with it.

Their quarters—*shared purely for logistical reasons*, he reminded himself far too often—had fallen into rhythm. Mydei brewed tea with an impossible kind of blend, timing the pour down to the second. The air always smelled faintly of flowers and citrus, and he always hummed while he worked. Phainon never admitted how much those little tunes stuck in his head… or how every so often, they carried the echo of something that didn't belong here on the Grove.

He didn't bring it up.

In exchange for tea, Phainon handled breakfast, which mostly meant getting in the way while Mydei tried to stop him from weaponizing sugar. There'd been an incident with a syrup explosion that both of them had mutually agreed to pretend never happened.

He told himself the warmth between them was normal. A side effect of proximity. *Familiarity.*

(It was also, unfortunately, golden and unbearable—the kind that crawled under the ribs and stayed there long after you'd laughed it off.)

The area itself had begun… responding.

At first, it was small things: vines that brushed his sleeve instead of recoiling, lights that brightened when he entered the room. But lately, the timing had started to feel *too* exact. The way the glow swelled when Mydei laughed. The way the air pulsed—soft, rhythmic—as if syncing to a heartbeat that wasn't theirs.

He kept telling himself that was normal too.

It wasn't.

Then there were the calls.

The first time Tribbie's holo-link flickered to life, Phainon nearly fell out of his chair. One second he was reviewing data, the next there was a floating pastel cube hovering in front of him, voice crackling with static.

"Snowy, are you *nesting*??"

Her tone was pure delight, glitchy laughter breaking through the interference. "Domestic bliss achieved! Oh, this is rich. We leave you alone for a few weeks and you go feral and start cohabitating with military."

"It's called *mission parameters*, thank you," Phainon said dryly, trying and failing not to groan.

"Uh-huh. Parameters. That's what they all say."

"You're just jealous I've got sunlight and breakfast."

"Please. Castorice gave us a new shell. It has *cup holders*."

"…damn, okay, that's fair."

Their conversations never lasted long. The connection—whatever channel she was using—wasn't supposed to exist. Even Anaxa didn't know how she was managing it. Tribbie brushed off the question every time, exclaiming,

“Classified protocols! Don’t worry about it!” like that wasn’t the single least reassuring phrase in the galaxy.

Once, when he asked about Okhema—about what happened after the recall—she froze. Her cube-body stuttered midair, flickering between frames.

Then, bright as ever, “Can’t talk about that, Snowy! Sorry! Totally fine though! Everyone’s great!”

And the link cut.

It was weird.

He’d sat staring at the dark space where her projection had been, his surroundings pressing in like a living silence.

He trusted Tribbie. Always would. But the way her code *wanted* to speak and couldn’t—it made his stomach twist.

He told himself it didn’t mean anything. It always did.

At least he had distractions.

Mydei had somehow revealed himself to be an unreasonably competent cook. The food was—there was no polite way to put it—sinful. Phainon would make noises that should’ve been classified, then try to pass them off as coughs.

“Too sweet?” Mydei asked once, head tilting with genuine concern.

“Perfect,” Phainon rasped, halfway between admiration and cardiac arrest.

But under the comfort, something was… off.

It started with the water. He’d noticed ripples in still bowls when Mydei passed. Then the lights—bioluminescent veins along the walls—would flare in time with his breath. Sometimes, even the air shimmered, faint distortion waves rolling through the room when Mydei was relaxed or distracted.

It wasn’t violent, more so wrong. Like a system glitch trying too hard to be organic.

Hyacine had been monitoring it quietly. She didn’t say much, but one morning she handed him a datapad over breakfast.

“Biotic response indicates recognition,” the note read.

Recognition.

Phainon didn’t like that word. He’d stared at it long enough for his tea to go cold.

He told her not to overthink it. He told *himself* not to overthink it.

After all, Mydei was just—Mydei. Warm tea, quiet hums, absent-minded grace.

Surely the Grove wasn’t alive enough to *recognize* him.

Right?

He kept telling himself that, even as the lights dimmed softly when Mydei slept.

Even as the vines shifted to make room when they walked side by side.

Even as the Grove seemed to breathe with them.

Phainon chose to ignore it. The sun was too bright, breakfast too good, and Mydei—too close—for anything ominous to settle for long.

And so the days went on—sweet, steady, golden—like a dream that didn’t quite know it was a dream.

“How does your lattice measure empathy? Is it quantifiable?”

Phainon nearly winced. Oh, great. We’re doing *those* questions today.

He didn’t even get the chance to open his mouth before Anaxa, seated behind his usual mountain of diagnostics, answered instead.

“Empathy isn’t measured,” the man said without looking up. His voice was perfectly level, like he’d sanded it smooth from years of exhaustion. “It’s correlated. We observe how affective resonance patterns align with behavioral shifts, then archive those alignments as harmonic signatures.”

“Ah.” Mydei’s head tilted slightly. He was perched on the edge of the scanner platform, posture graceful even when relaxed. “So, you *store* emotions.”

“Responses to emotions,” Anaxa corrected automatically, adjusting a dial. “Okheman latticework doesn’t hold feelings. It records the *echoes* they leave behind.”

Phainon leaned lazily against the doorway, arms crossed. “Ease up, professor,” he said. “He’s gonna start billing you for therapy if you keep this up.”

Anaxa gave him the kind of look that belonged to a man who hadn’t slept in a week and blamed him personally for it. “He’s not a patient.”

“And you’re not a comedian,” Mydei added mildly, eyes still fixed on the faintly glowing readout in front of him.

Phainon raised his hands in defeat. “Not today, I’m not. Today, I’m moral support with style.”

Anaxa muttered something about “biological interference” under his breath, fingers dancing across the console. The scanner’s lattice shimmered to life around Mydei—a faint, fluid geometry of light that pulsed in rhythm with his heartbeat. Pale blue at first, then shading warmer when Mydei exhaled.

Phainon found himself staring despite himself. The colors always fascinated him—the way they moved like tidewater, alive and sensitive, catching every flicker of thought. He’d seen scans before, but something about this one moved differently.

“How does it store it?” Mydei asked quietly, still watching the light ripple. “The resonance data. Does it degrade over time?”

“Not linearly,” Anaxa said. “Connections formed through sustained or strong affective bonds retain coherence longer. Think of it as a frequency loop—memory by proximity.”

Mydei nodded. “So, memory and emotion are linked.”

“That’s one interpretation.”

“It’s also the only one that makes sense.”

Anaxa hesitated just long enough for Phainon to notice. “Perhaps,” he allowed.

Phainon broke the tension with a sigh

and facepalm. “You two realize you sound like a philosophy major and his dissertation advisor, right? Next thing I know, someone’s bringing up the meaning of love.”

Neither of them responded.

He stepped closer, placing a hand lightly on Mydei’s shoulder. “Hey. Don’t fry your brain on him too early in the morning. You’ll start seeing equations in your dreams.”

The contact was nothing—just a casual touch—but the scanner’s light flared sharply, twin pulses overlapping, then snapping apart with a soft hiss of static.

Anaxa’s head jerked up. “Wait—”

But by then the waveform had stabilized, as if nothing had happened.

Phainon blinked. “Did I break something?”

Anaxa hesitated.

“…No.” Anaxa’s voice was quiet now, careful. “Just interference.”

He didn’t sound convinced. Phainon opened his mouth to ask but stopped when he caught Mydei’s gaze watching Anaxa with an unreadable patience that made the atmosphere around them feel thick.

Whatever Anaxa had been about to say, he didn’t.

The scan continued. Mydei’s tone turned almost conversational. “So if the lattice records resonance patterns, can it recognize familiar ones?”

“In theory,” Anaxa replied. “If the harmonics align strongly enough.”

“And can those harmonics affect the host in return?”

“That depends on exposure levels.”

Mydei hummed thoughtfully, eyes following the flickering light that wove between his fingers like it was listening. “Then what happens,” he asked, “if two fields resonate at the same frequency?”

Anaxa hesitated again. “That would imply synchrony. Which—under normal conditions—shouldn’t occur without intentional calibration.”

Phainon added idly, simplifying it. “Translation: that’s a fancy way of saying it’s impossible.”

“Unlikely,” Anaxa corrected.

Mydei’s gaze slid briefly to Phainon. “Not impossible, though.”

There was that tone again—light, curious, like he didn’t realize he was dissecting a live wire. Phainon forced a laugh, rubbing the back of his neck. “Right, well, I think we’ve maxed out the existential dread quota for the morning. Markets are calling. You done with him yet, doc?”

Anaxa glanced down at the last string of data, then, after a beat, powered down the scanner. “For now.”

Phainon clapped his hands together. “Perfect! Come on, Mydei. If we hurry, I might even buy you that tea you keep pretending not to like.”

He had just turned toward the door when Anaxa’s voice cut through, crystal clear. “Wait.”

Phainon stopped mid-step, glancing back.

“Could Mydei stay a little longer?”

“Uh, sure,” Phainon said slowly. “A little longer as in…?”

Anaxa didn’t look up. “A while.”

Phainon blinked. “Oh. Right. ‘A while.’ My favorite unit of time.” He gave a weak laugh. “Okay then.”

He turned toward Mydei, half expecting some protest. But Mydei was still seated, posture straight, gaze locked on Anaxa.

Phainon lingered, awkward now. “So, uh… I’ll just wait outside?”

“Mydeimos,” Anaxa said softly.

Mydei didn’t look away. “Phainon.”

“Yeah?”

“Go home.”

Phainon blinked. “…Okay.”

He gave a salute that was more flustered than formal and backed toward the door. “Guess I’m… dismissed. Again.” Under his breath, he muttered, “I swear I’m turning into a house pet.”

The door hissed shut behind him, cutting off the sound of his voice.

Silence.

Anaxa’s gaze drifted toward the scanner still faintly glowing beside Mydei. The harmonics hadn’t settled—they pulsed faintly, residual energy shimmering in paired signatures.

“Curious,” he murmured, almost to himself. “Your harmonics reacted before he even touched you.”

Mydei didn’t answer.

The lattice light flickered once, dimmed, and faded to black.

Phainon had planned to head straight home after the scan. Really, he had.

But the Grove had a way of keeping him longer than intended.

It started simple enough—a call from one of the outer domes. An apprentice linguist had somehow managed to erase three hours of rare vocal data from the archives and was now on the verge of tears. Then came the second favor, and the third. And by the time he realized what was happening, he was already knee-deep in the day’s chaos with a polite smile and a resigned sense of purpose.

Because apparently, when people saw *Phainon,* they saw “friendly and competent and available.”

By noon, he’d recalibrated an entire team’s light filters, repaired a sensor grid that had been short-circuiting since the last storm, and been conned into carrying crates of luminescent roots across the main walkway because —quote—*“You’ve got good balance, sir.”*

He did not have good balance.

But he smiled and did it anyway.

“Careful—careful—those are volatile specimens!” a harried botanist shouted as Phainon stumbled slightly, the crate humming ominously in his hands.

“Volatile?” he repeated, steadying it. “You could’ve led with that part!”

“Don’t drop it!”

“Thank you, invaluable advice!”

When he finally set the crate down, a few nearby students clapped like he’d just prevented a catastrophic explosion. Phainon gave a small, dramatic bow.

“All in a day’s work,” he said lightly. “Try not to hand me anything that glows next time, yeah?”

That set the rhythm for the rest of the day.

He stopped by one of the field labs to help a group of students struggling with harmonic resonance equations. “No, no—see here,” he said, leaning over a display. “Your calibrator’s off by 0.002. That’s why your waveform keeps collapsing. There—perfect.”

Then he got pulled into a heated argument between two biologists over whether the Grove’s bloom cycles were lunar or purely artificial. “You’re both right,” Phainon announced, deadpan. “Congratulations, you’ve discovered that science is subjective suffering.”

They threw paper filters at him. He deserved it.

Later, he fixed an archive pod that refused to sync to the central system. It had apparently been offline for months. He got it running again in fifteen minutes.

For all his self-deprecation, it turned out his hands still remembered what they were doing. He was rusty, sure—but not lost. Life might’ve taught him how to survive chaos; Anaxa had taught him how to navigate it.

Still, between the laughter and the noise, his thoughts kept drifting back to the one thing he was trying to avoid.

Aglaea.

The idea of reaching out to her made his stomach twist.

She'd been the one to pull him out of the wreckage of his own mistakes once. The one who'd refused to give up on him when everyone else already had. A leader, yes—but also the closest thing to home he'd ever had.

And now he had to tell her that not only was he alive, but he was harboring *Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos*—the man she'd spent a decade raging about due to how notoriously difficult he is.

He could already imagine it. The tight-lipped calm. The pointed silence. The inevitable, disappointed sigh. Then, maybe, a smack to the head. She wouldn't hit him, not really—but she'd *want* to.

And then she'd start asking questions. Questions he wasn't ready to answer.

Because what was he supposed to say?

Hi, surprise, I'm alive. Also, I may or may not be gaslighting a Kremnoan commander into emotional recovery while hiding from two governments. Hope you're well.

Yeah. That'd go beautifully.

"Phainon?"

He blinked, realizing he'd been staring into the soft glow of a data terminal for far too long. A young researcher—Tavi, one of the new recruits—was watching him nervously. "The resonance readout's still oscillating. Did I… mess it up again?"

Phainon leaned over, glancing at the display. "Nope. You're fine. You're just overcorrecting—ease the modulation by one point three. There. Now watch the stabilizer."

Tavi adjusted the control, eyes widening as the oscillations flattened into a steady rhythm. "It worked."

“Of course it worked,” Phainon said with mock indignation. “You think I’m here just for decoration?”

Tavi opened their mouth, reconsidered, then shut it.

“Good choice,” Phainon said cheerfully, handing back the datapad. “Keep at it. You’ll get it down before Anaxa invents another crisis to keep us all up at night.”

He left before Tavi could ask if he was joking.

By midafternoon, he’d somehow acquired a trail of stragglers—students, researchers, technicians—all orbiting him for “a quick second opinion.” He didn’t mind. Their questions kept his hands busy, their chatter filling the space that guilt and dread would otherwise occupy.

Now and then, though, something flickered—a pulse of blue across a research display, the faint echo of harmonic feedback that made the back of his neck prickle. It reminded him of the scan earlier. He tried not to think too hard about it.

Instead, he helped an engineer troubleshoot a sensory relay that refused to stop beeping. “You know,” Phainon said as he crouched beside the console, “I could’ve been home two hours ago. Drinking apple juice. Pretending to read a report.”

“You volunteered,” the engineer reminded him.

“I was manipulated by the power of polite suggestion.”

“Uh-huh.”

“Don’t judge me for being a people pleaser,” Phainon said, reconnecting the last cable. “There. Try it now.”

The relay hummed to life with a soft chime. Perfect.

The engineer blinked. “How did you—?”

“I’m magic,” Phainon said solemnly. “Don’t question it.”

It wasn’t until he stood up, stretching out the stiffness in his shoulders, that he noticed the light had changed. The Grove’s canopy had darkened from amber to deep indigo, and the biolights along the walkways had begun to glow, one by one, like grounded stars.

Huh.

He hadn’t realized how late it had gotten.

Around him, the domes were beginning to quiet. Researchers packed up their notes, voices soft and tired, laughter carrying faintly between the paths. Somewhere above, a student was playing something on a string instrument—slow, delicate, drifting.

Phainon sighed, pushing his hair back and glancing toward the glowing path leading home. “All right,” he muttered. “Enough accidental productivity for one day.”

The air smelled faintly of moss and silver, the night cycle settling across the Grove like a gentle exhale.

Time to head back.

His kitchen was a mess courtesy of him.

Well—him more so than the kitchen.

He’d told himself he’d go straight to bed. He’d even tried. For approximately seven minutes.

Now he was standing barefoot on cold tile at an ungodly hour, elbows propped on the counter, drinking apple juice out of the carton because he’d long since abandoned the illusion of dignity after midnight. The drink was lukewarm. That offended him more than it should’ve.

He sighed, glaring down at the half-empty glass like it had personally failed him. “Brilliant,” he muttered. “You save three divisions from implosion and can’t manage basic sleep.”

Okheman biology wasn’t supposed to *need* much rest. His people could function days without it—something about neural efficiency or some smug physiological advantage he couldn’t currently appreciate. But lately his body had been acting traitorous, craving sleep, craving stillness.

He knew exactly why.

Because somewhere along the line, he’d gotten used to sleeping *with* someone.

A certain Kremnoan who slept like gravity didn’t apply to him, took up most of the bed, and radiated heat like a forge. Mydei had an infuriating talent for curling into his side until their limbs tangled, and Phainon—very much against his own better judgment—had adapted.

He rubbed his temple and muttered, “You’ve gone soft.”

And maybe he had.

It wasn’t just the warmth he missed—Okhemen ran hot enough to rival a small star. It was the quiet beside him. The steady rhythm of breath against his back. The weight of another person’s body, anchoring him in a way he hadn’t realized he’d wanted until it wasn’t there.

Mydei’s hair came to mind first, as usual—wild and heavy, like he’d wrestled with the wind and won. He could still feel it brushing his face when Mydei shifted closer, the faint mineral scent of the soaps he favored—clean, with an undertone that always reminded Phainon of sky and storm and flight.

Sometimes he caught himself absently carding his fingers through it, just for the feel of it—thick, soft, ridiculously soothing. He’d never admit it aloud.

Gods. He was down bad.

He sat at the table, one arm sprawled out, the other supporting his head as he stared up at the slow swirl of light rippling across the ceiling. His glass sat forgotten beside him. His eyes were heavy but stubbornly awake, hovering in that bleary half-dream where his thoughts blur.

He leaned forward, cheek pressed to the cool tabletop. The metal warmed faintly beneath his skin. It felt grounding. His eyes fluttered shut. Maybe he could pretend for a moment—pretend that warmth was still there beside him.

Which, apparently, was the exact moment someone decided to throw something over him.

He jolted, nearly knocking his chair back. The fabric slid over his shoulders, soft and sudden. It took a few seconds for his brain to catch up—blanket first, person second.

“Mydei?”

The man stood a few feet away, one hand still clutching the edge of the blanket, gaze faintly amused at the sight of Phainon frozen mid-flinch.

Phainon blinked blearily at him. “I didn’t even hear you come in… damn, you’re good.”

Mydei made an approving noise as he stepped past, the stretch of his shoulders smooth and feline. He dropped into the chair beside Phainon, all quiet confidence and ease, like he’d been there all along.

“Not tired?” he asked, voice soft enough that it didn’t break the quiet.

Phainon dragged his hand down his face, half laughing under his breath. “Depends,” he said after a pause. “Do you have the energy to talk?”

Instead of answering, Mydei reached over and took the glass from his fingers. He drank from it without ceremony, throat working in a slow

swallow that somehow demanded too much of Phainon’s focus. Then he set it back down with deliberate finesse, eyes glinting faintly with amusement.

“Is that even a question?”

And then—because apparently he enjoyed making Phainon’s night more complicated—he licked his lips.

Phainon’s brain shut down for one full, dignified heartbeat.

The blanket slipped further down his shoulders. Outside, the night cycle deepened, painting everything in shades of blue.

And suddenly, Phainon didn’t mind being awake.

Yeah, okay,” Phainon said at last, rubbing at his jaw with a small sigh. “Let’s talk.”

He drummed his fingers against the table, pretending to think very hard about something that wasn’t the fact that Mydei’s hair looked like it was catching moonlight. “So,” he began casually, “what did you and Anaxa end up doing today?”

Mydei blinked, slow. “Today?”

“Yeah. You were gone for hours,” Phainon said, leaning back. “Just making sure he didn’t make you alphabetize his files again. Or—whatever cult activities he does for fun.”

That earned a soft exhale, almost a laugh. “Diagnostics,” Mydei said after a pause. “Adjustments. Nothing interesting.”

Phainon narrowed his eyes. “That’s vague.”

“Is it?”

“You say that every time you’re avoiding an answer.”

“I wasn’t aware I was.” What a boring response.

“Uh-huh.” Phainon squinted at him. “You’re terrible at lying, you know that?”

“I’m not lying.”

“Then tell me what you actually did.”

Mydei tilted his head, studying him for a beat. Then—lightly, intentionally—he reached over and flicked the cuff of Phainon’s sleeve. “You spill something.”

Phainon looked down. “That’s—barely anything.”

“It’s on your cuff.”

“It’s apple juice.”

“That doesn’t make it better.”

Phainon sighed. “You’re impossible.”

“Only selectively.”

He groaned, dragging a hand down his face. “You’re deflecting.”

“I’m redirecting.”

“That’s the same thing!”

Mydei’s mouth curved. “It worked, didn’t it?”

That earned Mydei a reluctant defeat out of him. “You’re lucky you’re cute.”

“I’m lucky,” Mydei echoed, “that you have no filter.”

That made Phainon laugh—genuine, the sound delicate enough that it barely disturbed the air. Somehow that broke the stiffness between them. The tension eased, replaced with something lazy, warm.

They drifted from one topic to another, the words slow and unhurried.

“Did I tell you one of the apprentices tried to ‘manifest’ lightning last week?” Phainon said. “Nearly fried his notes.”

Mydei’s brow lifted. “Did he survive?”

“Barely. He yelled something about *the storm being within him* and then passed out.”

“That sounds like something you would’ve done,” Mydei muttered.

“I would’ve done it successfully.”

“Of course.”

“Okay, rude.”

“According to Anaxa, you set your sleeve on fire during junior year.”

“That was *controlled experimentation*.”

“It was panic.”

Phainon stared at him. “You weren’t even there!”

“I heard about it.”

“Unbelievable,” he muttered appalled, but he was smiling again. “You gossip.”

“I gather data.”

“You gossip *efficiently*.”

That earned the faintest chuckle from Mydei, genuine this time. The faint ticking of the wall clock followed. Even the air felt drowsy.

Then, when the silence had stretched long enough to feel safe, Mydei spoke again.

“Do you ever miss home?”

Phainon blinked. “Home?”

That didn’t deter Mydei. “What’s it like?” he asked. “Living in a city that breathes with you.”

Something in his tone shifted—uncertain, in a way that felt rare for him. It drew Phainon out of his half-lidded ease.

“It’s… hard to explain,” he said slowly. “The city isn’t just walls and towers. It moves. You think, it stirs. You breathe, it answers back. You start forgetting where you end and it begins.”

He glanced down at his glass, rolling it between his palms. “Sometimes it feels alive in a way that’s—beautiful. Other times it’s like it’s watching you too closely. You start wondering if you’re living inside it, or if it’s living inside you.”

When he looked up again, Mydei hadn’t looked away. There was a faint, awed look in his eyes—one that made Phainon’s chest ache, just slightly.

“Do you miss yours?” he asked before he could stop himself.

Mydei hesitated, gaze flickering toward the window. “I wouldn’t know,” he said finally. “I don’t remember what it felt like.”

“Oh.” Phainon’s throat felt suddenly dry. “Right. Sorry.”

“It’s fine.”

They sat in quiet for a while after that, just the hush of late hours and the faint mechanical hum from the corridor.

Phainon broke it first—he always did. “Maybe I’ll build you a new one,” he said lightly. “You can design it, I’ll do all the heavy lifting.”

Mydei glanced at him, lips curving faintly. “You? Build?”

“Hey, I’m good with my hands.”

“That remains to be seen.”

“I’ll prove it,” Phainon said, mock-offended. “You’ll see. You’ll be begging me to build your next—uh—whatever it is you people build.”

“Buildings?”

“Sure. Buildings.”

The corner of Mydei’s mouth twitched. “Damn HKS.”

It slipped out so naturally—soft, fond, like muscle memory—that Phainon didn’t notice it at first. He was too distracted by the warmth in Mydei’s voice, the way his lashes caught the light.

Then it hit him.

The word.

It crashed through his head a second too late.

He froze. His smile faded.

“What did you just call me?”

Mydei looked puzzled. “What?”

“That word.” Phainon’s voice had gone tense. “What did you say?”

Mydei frowned, eyes searching his face. “I didn’t say anything.”

“You did.”

“I didn’t.”

“Mydei,” he said sharply, and then stopped—because he shouldn’t be yelling at him for this. “You said—something. In Kremnoan.”

“If I did,” Mydei said carefully, “I didn’t mean to.”

Phainon stared at him for a long moment, unreadable. The warmth that had filled the space between them just minutes ago drained out, leaving only a thin, brittle silence.

He pushed his chair back. The scrape against the floor was too loud. “I’m—gonna take a bath.”

Mydei’s brows drew together. “Phainon—”

“Yeah, no, it’s fine.” His voice was too quick. “Just need to… clear my head or something.”

He stood, grabbing the blanket that had been draped over his shoulders, and turned toward the hallway.

“I didn’t mean to upset you,” Mydei said softly.

Phainon paused, one hand braced on the doorframe. His voice, when it came, was apologetic . “You didn’t,” he murmured. “I just—need a minute.”

Then he was gone. The faint sound of his footsteps receded down the hall.

Mydei sat there for a long while, unmoving, eyes fixed on the empty chair opposite him—on the faint, invisible warmth still clinging to it.

Outside, the night pressed closer, heavy and silent.

Phainon wasn’t sure how he’d ended up being the resident pack mule for every healer in the Grove, but here he was again, hauling a crate half his size down one of the south corridors while Hyacine trailed beside him, cheerfully oblivious to the laws of weight distribution.

“You know,” he said, voice strained but level, “for someone who studies restorative resonance, you have an interesting relationship with manual labor.”

Hyacine blinked innocently. “I *am* helping.”

“You’re carrying a box of herbs.”

“It’s heavier than it looks.”

Phainon glanced at her load—a small wooden case barely bigger than her hands. “Right. Tragic burden.”

She smiled sweetly. “That’s why I brought you.”

“Remind me to stop answering your messages,” he muttered, adjusting his grip as the crate’s weight shifted.

The hallways were quiet this hour, all pale stone and morning light filtering through the canopy windows. Strands of bioluminescent ivy crawled lazily up the glass walls, the faint shimmer of the city’s pulse gliding beneath the floor with every step they took. The soft hum of the Grove filled the silence between their banter—alive, breathing, the way Okhema always was.

Hyacine peeked over at him. “You’re very dramatic for someone who can lift twice his body weight.”

“I’m preserving my right to complain,” Phainon said. “It’s part of my coping mechanism.”

“Coping with what?”

“Working with you.”

She laughed, bright and unoffended, adjusting what she was holding in her hand. “If it makes you feel better, I appreciate it. I really do.”

“It doesn’t, but thanks,” he said jokingly.

By the time they reached the southern infirmary wing, Phainon set the crate down on a bench with a heavy exhale and leaned his forearms on it like it might collapse if he didn't. "There. Delivered. Any chance this was your grand plan all along? Trick me into free labor under the guise of friendship?"

Hyacine's lips quirked. "Would you believe me if I said no?"

"Not even slightly."

"Well, I *also* wanted to talk to you," she said, tone shifting.

"Ah," Phainon said, straightening. "There it is. The real reason."

Her face immediately fell into guilt. "I'm sorry," she said. "I didn't mean to __"

He waved her off before she could finish. "Hey, I'm teasing. You don't have to apologize for having an ulterior motive. Everyone here does."

That earned him a weak but grateful nod. "Still. I didn't mean to make you haul everything before bringing it up."

"Please. It's nice to feel useful for once."

She shot him a look that said she didn't believe that for a second.

"Anyway," he said, dusting his hands and leaning against the worktable, "I assume this has something to do with Mydei?"

Hyacine's expression turned thoughtful, though a touch of worry flitted behind her eyes. "Unfortunately, you're right. But for this particular case," she said carefully, "you should also speak to Professor Anaxa afterward. He's been cross-analyzing the results with me."

Phainon arched an eyebrow. "The fact you're passing me off to *Anaxa* already doesn't fill me with confidence."

“It’s nothing bad,” she said quickly. “At least—I don’t think it is. Just… different.”

“That’s the same tone people use before saying ‘don’t panic,’” Phainon muttered.

Hyacine ignored him, turning toward one of the smaller lab tables. She rifled through her stack of readings—pages of color-coded data, layered resonance graphs, faintly glowing transcriptions. “My latest readings have been—well. Unusual. Not at all like what we’ve been seeing these past weeks.”

He leaned closer, squinting at the glowing lines. “Unusual how?”

“Titanal resonance.” Her voice took on that academic cadence she slipped into when she got serious. “Normally, when a strain event occurs, the readings destabilize first—wild fluctuations, irregular decay, then a slow return to baseline as the system restores itself.”

“Sure,” Phainon said. “That’s the normal healing process.”

“Right. Only this time, it’s not happening.”

He looked at her. “Not happening?”

She nodded. “The resonance isn’t decaying. It’s stabilizing *too fast*. No transition window or gradual recovery curve. It’s like something’s skipping the middle entirely.”

Phainon frowned, dragging a hand through his hair. “You’re saying he’s not healing.”

“Not *healing*,” she corrected, “*rebuilding.* The structure’s changing—self-reinforcing. Think of it like… scar tissue, except smarter. It’s not patching damage; it’s reconfiguring the system itself.”

Phainon’s brows furrowed. “That doesn’t happen naturally.”

“No,” Hyacine said softly, pushing one of the diagrams toward him. “Not unless there’s an external factor guiding it. Or someone.”

He stilled, eyes flicking up to hers.

Hyacine’s voice mellowed again, careful. “I’d rather show you before I start drawing conclusions.”

“Right,” Phainon said slowly. His tone was mild, but the muscles in his jaw had gone tight. “Can’t wait.”

Hyacine hesitated, fingers smoothing the edge of the paper as if weighing whether to go on. Then she looked back up at him.

“Shall I continue?”

“Please.”

She flipped to another page, thumb pressing faintly into the corner. “There’s one more thing,” she said after a moment. “And it’s what’s been bothering me the most.”

Phainon tilted his head, expression still light but attentive. “Which is?”

Her eyes flicked between her datapad and him, as though trying to decide where to start. “It’s not just the synchronicity itself anymore. The Grove’s flora are… reacting to him. On their own. I’ve recorded growth surges, dissonant pulse shifts, and—in a few samples—complete data corruption in the bioluminal tissues whenever he’s within range.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed. “You mean the plants are—what—glitching?”

The plants moving by themselves weren’t anything unusual here; that was half the Grove’s charm.

Hyacine exhaled through her nose. “Glitching is a crude way to put it,” she admitted, “but… yes, in essence. Except it isn’t random. The shifts spiral outward, patterned, synchronized to his Titanal field. Normally, everything in the Grove harmonizes with Etheric frequencies. His, though—” she

tapped a rhythmic beat against the datapad, "—is starting to overwrite the baseline resonance instead."

Phainon blinked. "Overwrite?"

"Think of it like a heartbeat," she said, slipping into explanation mode. "The Grove breathes on a collective rhythm—the same pulse that sustains every organism here. But Mydei's resonance is pushing against that rhythm, introducing a counter-frequency strong enough to rewrite it. The vines near his chamber are showing fractal mutations, the root systems beneath have stopped responding to network prompts, and the luminal moss along the walkways dims when he passes."

He stared at her, brows furrowing deeper. "Couldn't that just be a localized reaction? Happens sometimes when you have overlapping energy fields, right?"

"I thought so too," Hyacine said softly. "At first. But the readings show an outward drift. Slow, yes—but consistent." She hesitated, then added, "If it keeps accelerating at this rate…" Her voice faltered for the first time. "I don't know whether it's going to escalate or not."

Silence pooled between them.

Phainon's jaw tensed. He'd had a sinking feeling since she started talking, but hearing it out loud pressed the air from his lungs. "…what're you trying to say?"

Hyacine's shoulders slumped. "I'm saying," she said quietly, "that if this continues, we can't risk keeping him here much longer. The Grove's biosphere is too sensitive. If his resonance keeps destabilizing the Etheric matrix, we could see feedback through the entire system. Maybe even collapse in the deeper roots."

Phainon didn't say anything. His instinct—to argue, to defend, to tell her she was wrong—tightened in his chest. Mydei wasn't dangerous. He wasn't some contagion to be expelled. But Hyacine wasn't prone to dramatics, and

she wasn’t cruel. If she was saying this, it meant she’d already spent sleepless nights ruling everything else out.

He dragged a hand through his hair, posture slowly slumping from that tight, guarded stillness into something silent. The fight drained out of him before he even realized it.

“…where’s Anaxagoras.”

Hyacine blinked, surprised by the flatness of his tone. “Still at the laboratory, most likely. South wing.”

He nodded once, already turning. “Right.”

“Phainon—” she started, but he stopped only long enough to glance over his shoulder.

“Thanks for telling me,” he said simply.

Her expression changed—guilt and sympathy threading together. “I wish it were better news.”

He gave a faint hum that wasn’t quite agreement or denial. The door sighed open at his touch, flooding the room with pale light from the corridor. For a heartbeat, he lingered there—outlined in that sterile glow, quiet, unreadable—before stepping out and letting the door close behind him.

The walk there was, in all honesty, uneventful.

Seven minutes, give or take. The corridors were mostly empty—thankfully lacking students or stray apprentices. The south wing always smelled faintly of gun oil and mint, which, as far as anyone could tell, was Anaxa’s personal brand of comfort.

He slowed as the lab came into view. The door was sealed, the glass darkened. If Anaxa was in there, he hadn’t triggered the transparency lock. Which usually meant *something* volatile was happening inside.

Phainon approached carefully. He'd seen what happened the last time someone opened one of Anaxa's doors too fast. It took three days to scrape crystallized residue off the ceiling—and that had been *after* the cleanup crew recovered enough samples to confirm they were once alive.

So, naturally, he reached for the panel with the caution of a man defusing a bomb.

And that's exactly when someone grabbed him by the sleeve and *yanked* him inside.

Phainon shrieked.

A dignified shriek, obviously. Deep. Commanding. Heroic.

Completely justified.

He stumbled, caught his balance, and spun around, already halfway through preparing to punch whoever thought that was a good idea—until he found himself face-to-face with his dear professor.

"Professor—what the *fuck*!"

"Language," came the deadpan reply.

Phainon blinked. "Since when do you care about language? You literally swore at a Council delegate last week." At least from what rumors say.

Anaxa looked up from his workbench with the tired, disbelieving expression of a man who'd given up expecting intelligence from anyone under forty. "I said context matters, not that you should abandon vocabulary altogether."

"Right," Phainon muttered, rubbing his arm where he'd been grabbed. "Because nearly dislocating my shoulder to save me from a pressure seal was such a *contextually polite* thing to do."

"You're welcome," Anaxa said without looking up, already scribbling something on a datapad. "You were about to open a chamber vent. We'd

both be dead.”

“Ah. My hero.”

“You’re talking again.”

Phainon sighed, stepped closer, and leaned against a nearby counter, hands in his pockets. “Anyway, I won’t waste your time. I know how valuable it is, Professor, so let’s get to the point, yeah?”

Anaxa finally looked up, one brow lifting. “Who do you think you’re talking to? That’s already a given.”

He knew better than to spar when Anaxa was mid-project; that was how people lost eyebrows. So instead he asked, “Then what’s your take?”

Anaxa didn’t hesitate. “He can’t stay here.”

Phainon’s stomach dipped.

Damn it. He’d been hoping—just faintly—that Hyacine had overreacted. That Anaxa would roll his eyes, maybe lecture her about premature conclusions. But no.

He swallowed, jaw tightening. “And where should we go?”

“*We?*” Anaxa’s head tilted.

“Yeah, *we*.” Phainon met his gaze evenly. “You really think I’m leaving him alone?”

The older man studied him for a long moment, something between disapproval and reluctant respect passing behind his eyes. Then he exhaled through his nose. “Every damn decade,” he muttered, “same story.”

“Sorry?”

“Nothing.” He straightened. “Lucky for you, I’ve already come up with a solution.”

Phainon arched a brow. “That was fast.”

“I don’t sleep.”

“That explains… a lot, actually.”

Anaxa gave him a look that could have sterilized glass, then brushed past him toward the far corridor. “Walk with me.”

Phainon followed, the two falling into a steady pace. The professor’s stride was brisk, purposeful, and accompanied by a faint crackle from the electrical coils embedded in his coat.

“You ever considered taking a day off?” Phainon asked.

“I did once.”

“And?”

“Terrible experience.”

“Yeah, I bet.”

Anaxa didn’t dignify that with a reply. Their conversation drifted as they walked, mostly idle chatter to keep it from going quiet: mild jabs, half-serious musings about patterns, Anaxa’s quiet rant about the council requisitioning half his catalysts for “nonessential outreach experiments.”

“Nonessential outreach—” Phainon barked a laugh. “That’s what they’re calling civic fireworks now?”

“They’re calling it public morale enhancement.”

“That’s worse.”

“Exactly.”

Their steps echoed down the hall, and Phainon found himself almost relaxed again until—

—Anaxa stopped walking.

Phainon nearly ran into him. “What—?”

Anaxa keyed a panel beside an unmarked door. The lock hissed open, light spilling from the seam. He turned slightly, face indecipherable. “After you.”

Phainon hesitated. “You’re not going to tell me what’s in there first?”

“Would you prefer to be surprised?”

“Not particularly, no—”

But Anaxa was already waiting expectantly.

Phainon sighed and stepped inside. The room was lit softly, the air unnaturally still—one of those sterile, sealed chambers Anaxa used for testing remote simulations. He took a few steps in, mid-sentence. “You know, for a man who hates people, you sure love the drama of—”

“…So you were right.”

The words slid through the air like a blade.

Phainon froze.

That voice.

Every instinct in his body went still. His breath caught somewhere between disbelief and dread. Slowly, he turned.

In the center of the room, light shimmered and coalesced into a figure—holographic, flickering faintly with residual energy, yet unmistakably solid in her bearing. Her posture was regal, expression composed, her eyes the exact shade of green that made the air feel colder just by existing.

“Phainon,” Aglaea said, smooth and measured. “We have *much* to talk about.”

The world tilted.

For a heartbeat, he couldn’t breathe. His mouth opened, closed—no sound came out. Then, faintly, “You’ve got to be kidding me.”

Behind him, Anaxa reached past and quietly shut the door.

The click of the seal was sharp and final—like the sound of a trap closing.

Anaxa’s gaze flicked to the projection. For a moment, the air itself seemed to constrict.

And gods, the tension between her and Anaxa was *palpable*. Phainon could almost *hear* the mutual disdain vibrating between them, the kind that could level a symposium.

Anaxa crossed his arms, voice deceptively casual. “I’m assuming you’ve figured out what my plan is.”

Phainon’s pulse hadn’t slowed since Aglaea’s face appeared. His fingers twitched once at his side before he managed to still them. Slowly, reluctantly, the pieces in his head clicked together—one by one—until the shape of it formed, and his stomach dropped.

He let out a shaky breath that he disguised as a laugh. “You two actually talked it out? Compromised?”

Anaxa didn’t bother to look at him. “Nope. I’m leaving that up to you.”

Damn it, Anaxa.

Phainon dragged a hand over his face, then schooled his features into that perfect calm that had carried him through far worse disasters. He turned toward the projection, toward her.

“Aglaea—please,” he began softly. “I can explain.”

“Then start.”

No hesitation. Her tone had the same cadence as a scalpel—clean, sharp, unflinching.

He inhaled slowly. “You thought I was dead,” he said. “And for that, I apologize. I should have—”

“You *should have*,” she cut in, her eyes narrowing. “And yet, here you are. Alive, acting without sanction, harboring a Kremnoan general, falsifying data transmissions, and—if I’m not mistaken—violating three intergalactic statutes.”

Her words weren’t raised, but they landed like hammer strikes. “So forgive me if I’m not inclined to be moved by apology.”

Phainon swallowed the urge to flinch. “I didn’t do this for myself.”

“No,” she replied. “You did it because you thought you knew better.”

He forced his hands behind his back to hide the tremor starting there. “If I *hadn’t* intervened,” he said, “you would have had an uncontrolled Titanal resonance surge that could’ve destabilized a star system’s lattice entirely.”

Aglaea’s expression didn’t waver. “You acted on incomplete data and assumption.”

“It was better than acting too late,” he said.

Anaxa sighed from the side, utterly unhelpful. “If you two are done rewriting history, perhaps we can move on to the part where we decide whether the Grove collapses before lunch.”

Aglaea turned on him with a look so sharp it could’ve slit glass. “You may hold your tongue, Anaxa. You’ve already done enough.”

Anaxa raised a brow. “You’re welcome, actually. Without me, the Grove would *already* be a crater.”

“I would hardly call self-preservation altruism.”

Their tones were civil. Their words were not.

Phainon stepped forward before one of them decided to test how far a holographic feed could transmit violence. “Enough,” he said, louder than intended. He forced himself to exhale and tried again. “Listen to me. I know how this looks, but you need to hear the logic behind it.”

Aglaea gave no indication of granting that mercy, but she didn’t interrupt either.

So he began.

“Mydei isn’t just another anomaly,” Phainon said, voice tightening as he leaned into the argument. “If the readings are right, he’s the first stable Titanal resonance in centuries. Not diminishing like Cyrene was, not decaying like me—*stabilizing*. On his own.”

Aglaea’s brow twitched faintly. “And you believe that justifies harboring him here, under false identity?”

“I believe not understanding why he’s stable is the greater danger,” he countered. “The potential applications—if this is a naturally occurring recovery pattern, we could redefine containment theory itself. Every model we’ve built assumes instability is inevitable, but what if—”

“You’re speculating.”

“That’s what science *is*,” he shot back, then immediately adds on. “Educated speculation. The data supports it—his field doesn’t behave like any recorded form. It’s structured, Aglaea. Self-correcting. The decay curve folds back on itself, regulating output through inverse frequency correction.”

Her eyes flicked downward, briefly. “You’re saying he’s rewriting his own resonance state.”

“Exactly. Which shouldn’t be possible. Yet somehow, it *is*.”

The faintest pause followed.

Then, quietly: “Or he’s a living weapon we don’t understand.”

He almost smiled—an exhausted, humorless one. “Wouldn’t you rather he be under *your* eyes than *theirs*?”

That made her still. A subtle shift, barely perceptible, but it was there.

She didn’t speak right away. Her gaze slid from Phainon to Anaxa, and the temperature in the room seemed to drop.

When she did finally answer, her voice sounded reluctantly contemplating. “You’re proposing transfer to Okhema proper.”

“I’m proposing a controlled relocation,” Phainon corrected, “under full containment and oversight.”

Anaxa, who’d been fiddling with something on the console, chimed in. “For scientific continuity.”

Her head snapped toward him. “You would *volunteer* for that?”

He shrugged. “Better me than one of your bureaucrats.”

“That’s not an argument.”

“It wasn’t meant to be.”

The two of them stared each other down in silence that stretched far too long.

Finally, Aglaea exhaled through her nose. “Fine,” she said. The word was clipped, reluctant—more treaty than agreement. “Containment under my jurisdiction. Anaxa will oversee the subject’s monitoring.”

Phainon’s breath escaped him in something between relief and disbelief. The tension bled from his shoulders, though he didn’t dare show too much gratitude.

Then she added, “However, you and Anaxa will travel separately. You’ll go first. Preparatory arrangements will be handled en route.”

“Separately?”

“Precaution,” she said simply. “I’d rather not risk both of you—and the subject—on one vessel.”

Anaxa’s smirk was almost audible. “Sensible. I’ll take the longer route with Mydeimos to ensure containment stability.”

Phainon shot him a flat look. “You’re enjoying this.”

“Immensely.”

Aglaea ignored them both. “The Council will need official notice within the hour. I expect coordination from you both.”

She turned slightly, her profile stark against the projection light. Phainon opened his mouth before he could stop himself.

“Wait.”

Her head turned back.

He hesitated, then said, quieter, “After this is over… can we talk?”

A pause.

When she finally spoke, her tone was hard to decipher. “Of course. Depending on how quickly this is resolved.”

Not a promise. Not quite a dismissal either.

Then the feed flickered once, and she was gone—leaving the room dimmer and far too still.

Phainon stood there for a moment, hands loose at his sides. His pulse refused to slow.

Behind him, Anaxa sighed, as if the whole thing had been mildly inconvenient. “Well. That went better than expected.”

Phainon turned slowly. “You are unbelievable.”

“I’m aware,” Anaxa said, already tapping a sequence into the console. “You should start packing. I’ve prepped a ship for you—west hangar. I’ll brief Mydei myself.”

Phainon frowned. “I can—”

“You won’t have time,” Anaxa interrupted smoothly. “Knowing her, she’ll have Council documentation ready before you finish a sentence. Best you leave before she decides to change her mind.”

Phainon hesitated. It was reasonable. Logical. *Too* logical, maybe.

Still, he nodded once. “Right.”

He lingered a moment longer, hand tightening on the table’s edge.

Anaxa’s tone had been perfectly calm, perfectly measured.

Too perfect, actually.

Phainon knew that voice.

It was the one Anaxa used when he was keeping something to himself.

“Name and clearance?”

The officer didn’t even bother to look up. His voice was flat enough to sand wood.

Phainon handed over his ident-chip, the motion brisk and polite—mostly out of habit. The scanner whirred, pulsed white, then, with all the enthusiasm of divine mockery, flickered gold.

He stared at it. The light shivered once, like a heartbeat deciding whether to bother.

Back home, and already flagged. Wonderful.

The officer frowned faintly. “You’ve been marked for secondary verification. Record mismatch.”

“Yeah,” Phainon said dryly. “That tends to happen when you’re declared dead.”

The officer’s expression didn’t so much as blink. “Please refrain from sarcasm. It interferes with the empathic conduit.”

Immediately, the air around them *rippled*—a low, quivering pulse that glowed faintly along the archway’s edges. The structure itself seemed to *bristle*, like a cat reacting to raised voices.

Phainon exhaled slowly through his nose. “Oh, for the love of—”

“Please also refrain from irritation,” the officer added blandly. “It causes resonance feedback.”

He muttered something under his breath that definitely wasn’t in the *Conduit Regulation Handbook*. The light nearest his shoulder flickered in subtle agreement, as though the architecture itself was quietly rooting for him.

The officer continued typing at a pace that could only be described as vindictive. “Purpose of visit?”

“Existence,” Phainon said. “Maybe a dash of redemption.”

A bored blink. “Scientific or diplomatic classification?”

He dragged a hand down his face. “Research,” he said finally. “Definitely research.”

A hum of data processing followed—long enough for him to mentally draft and delete six different complaint letters.

While the officer squinted at an uncooperative hologram, Phainon's thoughts drifted—against his better judgment—to the trip here.

The shuttle had been half-empty, the cabin silent and cold, recycled air hissing at him. Aglaea had insisted on separate transports "*for safety*," which in Okhema-speak meant control.

He'd spent most of the ride trying to write his report—then deleting every version after realizing how insane it sounded to put *"resurrected self"* and *"amnesiac war criminal roommate"* in the same summary.

Eventually, he'd given up and stared out the viewport instead. The stars passed by in quiet accusation. Somewhere out there, Anaxa and Mydei were probably arguing—or worse, getting along—and he couldn't decide which thought horrified him more.

When the officer finally cleared his throat, Phainon looked up.

"Is anyone accompanying you?"

"He'll arrive a few days after me," Phainon said. "Lucky bastard."

The officer blinked, clearly unsure if that qualified as information. "Specify identity?"

"No."

A pause. "That was not a yes-or-no question."

"It was when I said it."

The scanner light pulsed again—judgmental—as if considering whether to flag him for insolence.

"I require additional identification," the damn officer said.

Phainon rummaged through his coat, produced another chip, and slid it across the counter. The scanner accepted it with a thin whine before half-melting the corner into a hiss of steam.

He winced. “Damn it.”

“Emotional disturbance in the conduit field,” the officer said without missing a beat. “Please wait for recalibration.”

He pressed a glowing cube onto the console. It began to hum softly, releasing a faint scent of bureaucracy. The light surrounding them dimmed from gold to a sluggish violet, vibrating in quiet disapproval.

Phainon crossed his arms, watching the cube hum like it was performing interpretive suffering. “You know,” he said, “I used to teach half of you this system.”

“Then you should remember the importance of patience.”

“Funny,” Phainon muttered. “Didn’t remember it being this inefficient when I left.”

“Technically,” the officer replied, “you didn’t leave. You expired.”

Oh so they had jokes now.

The cube chirped brightly, pleased with itself.

Phainon stared at it for a long moment. “You people are terrifying.”

The officer’s mouth formed into a smile. “Welcome home, Diplomat Phainon.”

“Thrilled,” Phainon said flatly.

He was still trying to salvage the molten remains of his ident-chip when a voice cut through the sterile hum of the checkpoint.

“Move, you damn bureaucratic fossil.”

Phainon froze. He knew that voice.

And for the first time since landing, he almost cried actual tears of joy.

Because really—who else could it be but Castorice, looking every bit like someone who'd finally decided to stop asking nicely.

She breezed past the officer, coat sweeping like she was late to her own coup, and flashed a sigil so high-level the scanner let out a pitiful beep and shut itself off.

"He's with me," she said crisply.

Phainon tilted his head. "Apparently not officially."

"Apparently officially enough," she shot back, grabbing his arm before he could earn himself another flag and dragging him through what used to be a functioning checkpoint.

The officer just stared at the smoking console.

By the time they made it through integration—three signatures, two recalibration scans, and one emotionally unstable cube—they were finally stepping into the outskirts of Okhema.

And gods, it hit him harder than he expected.

The city spread out like a living map of memory. Streets curved through open air, held aloft by the slow pulse of glowing aetherroots. Buildings shimmered faintly, edges breathing with color as if the skyline itself were alive. People passed in loose clusters, and each movement left behind faint traces—ribbons of light or soft threads of sound that wove briefly into others before fading.

Above it all, the sky rippled a gentle gold—the kind of hue you only got when the city's emotional systems were stable.

Phainon exhaled, tension loosening in his shoulders. It was ridiculous how much he'd missed this.

"You've been back all of five minutes," Castorice said, glancing at him sidelong, "and already managed to get flagged. That has to be some sort of personal record."

"I didn't realize 'coming back from the dead' came with paperwork," he said.

She laughed, and the air brightened with her mood—the Lattice responding like an affectionate pet.

For a moment, it almost felt like old times. Almost.

"The Council's losing its collective mind," she said eventually while walking. "Half want to interrogate you, half want to sanctify you, and the rest are still debating whether you count as legally alive."

"Effective as always," Phainon said.

"Aglaea's keeping them from tearing each other apart. She's been balancing Styxia's Oceans against Adonia's Winters since dawn."

He gave a low whistle. "So I'm under escort now?"

"'Protective supervision,'" she corrected, overly formal. "Aglaea's orders. You're technically on house arrest until Mydeimos and professor Anaxa arrive—thirty-six hours, give or take."

"Doesn't trust me to walk myself home?"

"She trusts you just fine," Castorice said. "She doesn't trust the thirty-two factions currently drafting theories about your resurrection."

"That's comforting."

"Think of it as an honor guard," she said lightly. "Except without the honor. Or the guard part."

He gave her a look. “You missed me.”

“Barely,” she said, but her excitement gave her away.

They walked in companionable quiet for a while before she asked, offhand but not really, “So—after you left for the Grove… what happened out there?”

He blinked. “I was wondering the same thing on your end.”

The air rippled before he could say more—an almost imperceptible vibration that built until it felt like it was drilling through his skull.

Both froze.

A flash of white split the Lattice like a nerve spasm. Pain hit a moment later, sharp and resonant, a frequency that made thought itself go brittle.

Phainon staggered, teeth clenched. Castorice hissed through hers, hand pressed to her temple.

Then it passed. Just like that. The air steadied, embarrassed, pink returning to their quiet gold.

She was the first to speak, voice thin but controlled. “Can’t… talk about it. Apparently neither can you.”

Phainon tried to reply, but his throat locked—words cutting off like someone had switched off language.

He exhaled through his nose. “Fantastic.”

Castorice grimaced, testing the edges of her own thoughts like she might trigger it again. “About your companions…” she said carefully, each word measured, “I don’t know why, but it might take longer for you to see them again. Something about timing—on their end.”

That earned her his full attention. Whatever Aglaea had told her, it wasn’t meant for him. He could see it in the tension around her mouth, the way she

didn’t quite meet his eye.

His instincts shifted, clicking into the cold, professional mode he’d spent years cultivating. Questions formed, too many of them—but he wasn’t about to push her into another psychic feedback spike.

Instead, he just nodded once. “Appreciate the warning.”

Her shoulders eased a little, and she gestured toward the street ahead. “Almost there.”

He followed her around the next curve—and stopped.

It took him a second to place it: the soft glow of the wards, the ivy trailing through the aetherglass, the faint pulse in the entry gate that still recognized him. His residence. Exactly as he’d left it.

Castorice glanced at him, a half-smile ghosting across her face. “Welcome home, Phainon.”

He looked at her, then at the house, not sure how to feel.

“Good to be back,” he said.

And this time, it almost sounded true.

House arrest was going great, actually.

Phainon cleaned up his house, ate breakfast and dinner, watered his plants, took a bath, and slept.

Then he did it again.

Then again.

And again.

No big deal though, right?

A few days and then Anaxa and Mydei should arrive. That was the plan. The delay Castorice mentioned, the political interference, the orbit clearance—all of it was temporary. That's what everyone said.

Hell, he'd even heard from one of the insiders (read: Hyacine, who he doesn't even know *how* she gets her information when she's still in the damn Grove, but he's learned not to question her methods) that their ship was finally in Okhema's orbit.

Right?

Well, imagine his fucking surprise when the second he got confirmation they'd landed, the same insider sent another message that began with:

> *"Before you get excited—Mydeimos convulsed and passed out."*

Phainon blinked at the message, reread it twice, and then, very calmly, stood up, grabbed his coat, and said aloud to absolutely no one,

"Well, fuck house arrest."

By the time Aglaea realized he'd left, he was already halfway across Okhema—cutting through the city's mirrored bridges, coat half-buttoned, muttering something about "totally fine, just visiting the ER," like that would make it true.

The treatment wing of the Aetheric Research Hall smelled like sterilized regret.

He spent hours there, pacing.

No one told him anything. He tried polite first, then charming, then quietly terrifying, and finally gave up and parked himself by the door.

When they finally let him in, it was already what passed for "night" in Okhema—the hour when the lights dimmed just enough for shadows to remember they existed.

Phainon didn’t walk; he practically ran inside. “Mydei—”

And then stopped.

There he was.

Mydei sat upright on the examination cot, posture still too straight for someone who’d just *died for a second*, a shimmer of half-dried circuitry across his neck where the stabilizers had latched on. His hair was a mess—well, a controlled sort of mess, like it had decided to rebel just enough to stay fashionable.

Anaxa stood beside him, green hair catching the pale glow from the monitoring screens. He looked like he’d been carved out of restraint.

They were talking in low tones about something Phainon couldn’t hear. Probably about him.

Didn’t matter.

“Mydei—” He started again, but it came out softer this time, halfway between relief and disbelief. “You’re— you’re awake.”

Mydei’s gaze slid up to him, slow. Not startled or even surprised. Just… restrained.

And suddenly, Phainon forgot how to keep moving.

For one beat too long, neither of them said anything. The monitors hummed, steady and impersonal.

Something about the way Mydei looked at him—it wasn’t blank, but it wasn’t the same either. Like someone had quietly rearranged the person behind his eyes while Phainon wasn’t looking.

“Mydei?” he tried again, quieter.

That seemed to break the silence. Mydei blinked, expression smoothing into something almost too impassive. “Phainon.”

His voice was there. Familiar, even. Except it wasn’t. The cadence was different—unperturbed at the edges, aloof in a way that made Phainon’s pulse jump.

“Are you alright?”

It was an innocent question.

Mydei tilted his head slightly, almost curious. Then he breathed out a quiet, unamused laugh. “Define alright.”

Phainon’s stomach did an unpleasant flip. He wasn’t sure why.

When Mydei looked down, it wasn’t dazed like he’d expected—it was sober.

“I’m fine,” he said, tone monotone.

It should’ve been reassuring. Somehow, it wasn’t.

Anaxa hadn’t moved. Phainon turned to him. “What’s going on?”

Anaxa finally met his eyes. Polished, practiced, perfectly diplomatic. “We’re relocating Mydei to one of the lower residences. My supervision for the next few cycles.”

“No.” Phainon’s reply came out before he’d decided to speak.

Both of them glanced at him, the same look mirrored twice.

He could already hear footsteps in the hall—official ones. Great. Aglaea had probably sent half a squad to haul him back to confinement.

“You’re staying with me,” he said, addressing Mydei more than Anaxa now. “He’s staying with me.”

Mydei blinked once. Slowly. “That’s against regulation.”

Phainon shrugged. “So is this conversation.”

For the first time, something resembling amusement ghosted across Mydei's face. It was small, almost imperceptible—but the kind that made Phainon's chest ache because *there* it was. That impossible, quiet arrogance that had always driven him insane.

And maybe it was stupid, but he smiled too.

No big deal, right?

As long as it was Mydei.

He took a step back, half-turning toward the door as the hall lights flared brighter—guards incoming. "I'll… see you later, alright?"

"Sure," Mydei said, voice so vague it could've meant *anything*.

Phainon hesitated, but didn't push it. He was already in enough trouble.

As the door closed behind him, he realized his hands were still shaking a little.

He told himself it was from running.

He didn't quite believe it.

Three days.

Three days since he'd seen Mydei, and still nothing. No visits, no messages, not even a rumor except the standard, sterile update from the Council feed: *Stabilization successful. Patient under observation.*

So now he was pacing his room again, half-dressed, hair a mess, lights dimmed to a muted amber while the communicator glowed faintly on the desk.

"I'm not overreacting, Hyacine," he hissed, low and defensive, like someone expecting to be told he was. "I'm *observing*."

On the other end, Hyacine's voice was the same brand of flat she used on reports that ran too long. "Observing what, exactly? The patient you're banned from visiting not sending you a personal thank-you note?"

He groaned and dragged a hand down his face. "That he's *different*, Hyacine. And don't—don't give me the 'psychological trauma' line again. You didn't see how he looked at me. It wasn't like before."

"I didn't see it because you broke house arrest *and* breached a restricted ward."

"Technically, the guards broke me in."

"That's worse, Phainon."

He stopped pacing, glaring at the air like she was physically standing there to receive it. "I'm serious. There's something off about him. Not bad—just… *wrongly calibrated.* His aether resonance was cleaner than it should've been. Like something scrubbed him down to the bone and hit restart."

A pause. Then Hyacine's voice, a little softer but no less skeptical: "You're projecting care onto a phenomenon you don't understand."

Phainon's jaw worked. "It's not like that."

"Then what is it?"

"It's—" he waved a hand helplessly, searching for the right word, "—pattern recognition. He doesn't behave the way he used to. It's like he remembers the outline of himself but not the rest. Like he's trying to reinhabit his own skin."

She sighed. "Phainon, your risk index has been climbing since you left the Grove. If it spikes again, I'll have to file it. You know what that means."

He winced. "Yeah, I know. More appointments, fewer travel permissions. Great for morale."

“Then stop acting like the universe revolves around one man who—”

“It’s not—” He broke off, laughed a little too hard. “Okay, maybe it’s a *little* like that. But come on, you saw what he did to the Grove before he left. His presence alone bent the flora network. What if it’s happening again? What if—”

“Phainon.”

That tone again. “You’re chasing ghosts. That’s dangerous.”

He turned toward the window, jaw tight, the glow of the city outlining his reflection. The skyline pulsed with slow, living light. He stared at himself a long moment. His reflection looked tired, almost like it was tired of *him*.

“…What’s dangerous?”

The words weren’t his.

He froze.

The communicator slipped slightly in his hand as Hyacine’s voice pressed through—distant, muffled: “Phainon? What was that? Hello?”

Arms slid around his waist, unhurried. A head came to rest on his shoulder, warm breath ghosting his collar. His pulse stuttered.

A quiet voice, curious and faintly amused, spoke against his ear:

“Didn’t mean to interrupt. Just curious about what your talking about.”

Every muscle in Phainon’s body went taut.

He thumbed the line off without looking, Hyacine’s voice cutting out mid-syllable. The room fell still again—so quiet he could hear his own heartbeat.

He turned slowly, forcing his body to obey even as it screamed not to.

The first thing he saw was the shimmer of red tracing down an arm. Ink and light both.

“Mydei.”

The name came out halfway between breath and disbelief.

Mydei tilted his head. “You were talking to Hyacine.”

“When did you—where were you?”

Mydei’s eyes flicked down briefly, as if thinking, then back up. His smile was small, almost distracted, but something about it made the it hard to breath. “Here,” he said softly. “Listening.”

Phainon blinked. “You—how long—”

But Mydei was already speaking again, his tone conversational, like they hadn’t skipped a beat.

“You said something about resonance. And danger.” He hummed faintly, the sound vibrating against Phainon’s back. “Let’s get back to that, shall we?”

Phainon’s breath caught.

Shit.

His brain short-circuited for a half second before his mouth jumped in to save face.

“It—uh—wasn’t anything important,” he said, too quick, the lie slipping out like muscle memory. “Just… diagnostics talk. You’d rather die than listen to that.”

Mydei’s arms, which had tensed when Phainon spoke, eased. Slowly, almost lazily, he let go—his fingers catching briefly on the fabric of Phainon’s shirt before trailing away. It wasn’t long enough to mean anything. Which was exactly why Phainon’s pulse spiked anyway.

He forced an exhale and turned around like nothing had happened. “Diagnostics, huh?” Mydei said. His tone was neutral, but his eyes had that faint spark of humor that always made Phainon feel like the punchline to a joke he hadn’t heard yet. “You lie like you’re auditioning for it.”

Phainon crossed his arms, expression dry. “Or maybe I’m just trying to stop you from biting me.”

“That would only work if you stopped talking.”

“You see what I deal with?” Phainon muttered to the ceiling. “I save your ass one time and suddenly you’re a menace with free housing.”

“Free housing,” Mydei repeated. “I recall you offered.”

“Yeah, before I knew you’d take ‘make yourself comfortable’ as a binding contract.”

That earned the faintest flicker of amusement—blink and you’d miss it.

“Why are you here, anyway?” Phainon asked finally. He didn’t mean it to sound suspicious, but it came out that way.

Mydei looked at him like a cat humoring a question. “Did you not say I’m staying with you? I can leave if you’d like.”

“No,” Phainon said too fast, the word snapping out before he could stop it. He coughed into his fist, trying again. “No. I just meant—where’ve you been the last few days? You vanished.”

“Resting.”

“Resting where?”

“Wherever I ended up.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the one I have,” Mydei said shrugging, the damn bastard. “You can be suspicious if it makes you feel better.”

“I’m not suspicious,” Phainon said—then winced. “Okay, I’m a little suspicious. You say creepy shit like that and expect me not to be?”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “Creepy?”

“Yes, creepy. The kind of thing people say right before they sprout extra limbs and start reciting prophecy.”

“Would it bother you if I did?”

Phainon paused for half a second, unsure if he was joking. “…That depends. How many limbs are we talking?”

“Enough.”

Phainon sighed, pinching the bridge of his nose. “You’re impossible.”

“So I’ve been told.”

“Yeah, by me. Multiple times.”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Then you must be an authority.”

Phainon snorted. “Unfortunately.” He studied him for a second longer, frowning. “I’m serious, though. You’ve been off since you came back. You keep… saying weird things. Like you’re testing me or something.”

Mydei’s gaze flicked toward him. “Would you prefer I pretend?”

“That’s not what I—”

“You talk like I’m one of you,” Mydei said abruptly, with a faint smile. “You wouldn’t, if you had more sense”

“Mydei—“

“Shush. I’m also being serious. If you knew what kind of man I am,” Mydei said, almost laughing, “you’d stop pretending I’m one.”

Phainon’s brows furrowed. What an odd and abrupt thing to say.

Was he… feeling sick?

A pause.

Then idly, he added, “But you’d still look at me, wouldn’t you?”

Phainon was still confused but did answer the question after a reluctant moment. “I’d call you *you*. That’s enough for me.”

Mydei’s eyes lingered on him for a long moment, something complicated flickering there before it smoothed out again.

“Good,” he murmured. “I’ll remember that.”

They stood there a moment longer—close enough that Phainon could feel the faint signs of aether still thrumming beneath Mydei’s skin. It made his hair prickle. It also made him not want to move.

Then, as if sensing that he’d dug deep enough, Mydei’s tone shifted—light again, smooth as though the last few seconds hadn’t happened. “I heard there’s going to be a festival soon. In Okhema.”

Phainon blinked, thrown by the sudden turn. “Uh… yeah. The Festival of Kephale. Celebration of the Titan’s birth—worldbearing, moons aligning, all that mythic fanfare.”

“Will you come with me?”

Phainon opened his mouth, closed it, and then opened it again, his brain lagging behind his heart. “What, like… with you?”

“That was the question, yes.”

He felt the corner of his mouth pull upward before he could stop it. “What, you asking me on a date or something?”

“If that’s what it takes to get you to agree.”

“Oh, I’d have said yes either way,” Phainon said, grinning despite himself. “But sure. Let’s call it that.”

Mydei looked almost pleased—almost. “Then it’s settled.”

“Gods, you’re efficient,” Phainon said with a laugh, rubbing the back of his neck. “Can’t even give a guy time to make himself look mysterious first.”

“Too late for that.”

“Rude. I was going for charming.”

“You overshot.”

“Okay, that’s it, I’m rescinding your free housing privileges.”

Mydei stepped past him, glancing around the room with the faintest smirk. “You wouldn’t.”

“I *might*.”

“You won’t.”

Phainon sighed dramatically, then swept into an exaggerated bow, one arm out like he was introducing royalty. “Fine. Since you’re already here, my terrifyingly enigmatic houseguest, allow me to show you around my very humble abode. Try not to destroy it with your… *mystical presence* or whatever.”

Mydei glanced his way and dipped into a bow of his own—graceful, poised, and way too princely for someone doing it just to be polite. Typical showoff.

“Lead the way.”

Phainon straightened, fighting the smile threatening his face as he turned toward the hall. “Yeah,” he muttered, half to himself. “I’m definitely doomed.”

Phainon got used to having Mydei around again faster than he cared to admit, again.

It started with small things—an extra mug on the counter, the faint scent of Mydei’s preferred tea steeping before dawn, the quiet sound of someone else moving through the house like they’d always been there.

He told himself it was fine. Normal, even. Then Mydei started straightening his collar in the mornings, brushing a hand down his sleeve before handing him a cup of coffee, and somehow “temporary” started to stretch further and further out of reach.

Phainon pretended not to notice how domestic it all felt.

Mostly because he didn’t hate it.

Like before, the kitchen stayed organized. Breakfast appeared on time. His paperwork—how, he had no idea—kept ending up sorted into tidy stacks. Half of his chaos disappeared before he could even complain about it. And when he did catch Mydei humming under his breath while setting the table, it was quiet, tuneless, but oddly steady—like he was syncing himself to the house somehow.

It should’ve been comforting.

It was comforting. Mostly.

The Council finally decided Phainon wasn’t a flight risk. House arrest: lifted.

Mostly.

He didn’t argue. The first thing he did was reconnect to the Tribios’s network. It’d been ages since he’d seen Trianne, Trinnon, or Tribbie face-to-face—or core-to-core, technically.

The reunion should’ve been happy.

It wasn’t.

Their AI core had been damaged—badly enough that Tribbie had been running on fragmented projections for weeks. Those phantom visits in the Grove, the flickers of Tribbie chatting like nothing was wrong—yeah. Not a trick of the light. She’d been burning herself out just to check in on him.

Now she was offline entirely, in deep hibernation mode, conserving what energy was left. Anaxa had taken over repairs, which was… odd. Engineering wasn’t his thing. But lately, Anaxa had been doing a lot of odd things.

Phainon didn’t question it. If Anaxa wanted to play mechanic, fine. Better him than someone careless. He trusted Anaxa—well, mostly. The alternative was staying up all night imagining worst-case scenarios, and he was already bad enough at sleeping.

The real weirdness was the way Mydei and Anaxa kept working together.

“Research,” apparently.

Phainon had walked in on them more than once—screens everywhere, diagrams spilling across every surface, the technology screeching in the walls. Mydei always looked right at home there, sleeves rolled up, asking questions that made even Anaxa pause.

“What would happen,” he’d said just yesterday, “if a harmonic failsafe was removed from a Titanal core?”

Anaxa had sighed without looking up. “Theoretically?”

“Theoretically.”

“It would destabilize everything tied to it. Let’s not make that a trend.”

Phainon had left before they could rope him in, assuming they were just nerding out. Which, to be fair, they were.

Probably.

Still, the halls buzzed with quiet rumors—missing calibration logs, re-indexed files, anomalies in the archive drives. He told himself it was nothing. Just the usual bureaucratic noise.

Because right now, he had better things to think about.

Okhema was gearing up for the Festival of Kephale—streets draped in gold-white banners, air rich with incense and static light. The annual celebration of the Titan whose body became the world itself.

And for once, Phainon wasn’t scheduled to save or supervise *anything*.

He had a festival to attend.

And, apparently, a date to keep.

“Are you *trying* to make us late?”

Phainon yawned mid-step, dragging his feet while Mydei towed him forward by the wrist. His other hand clutched a half-finished drink like it might justify his pace.

The irony wasn’t lost on him—usually, he was the one doing the dragging.

“Relax,” he muttered, stifling another yawn. “It’s not like we’ll miss anything.”

“That’s exactly what people say,” Mydei replied without looking back, “right before missing something.”

And then they stepped into the light.

Okhema had transformed overnight.

The city no longer hummed—it *sang*. Gold-white banners stretched between the spires like ribbons of trapped sunlight, shifting as though alive. The avenues below pulsed with color and sound: dancers in mirrored masks moved in perfect formations, their reflections scattering the light into shards that danced across glass walls. Drones spiraled above them, releasing bursts of shimmering dust that coalesced into miniature suns before dissolving into the haze. Somewhere deeper in the streets, chants layered over mechanical tones, an old hymn woven into the heartbeat of the city itself.

Every district glowed a different hue.

Veins of deep blue light ran beneath the streets—Kephale's lifeblood—while the central spire throbbed in slow rhythm, golden and steady: the Titan's "heart." Even the air shimmered faintly, charged by the city's pulse. It was hard to tell where the celebration ended and the world itself began.

They could've taken the lev-line like everyone else, but Mydei had insisted on walking. "To see everything properly," he'd said. And honestly, Phainon couldn't complain. There was something infectious about the way Mydei's eyes caught on every passing color, every flicker of movement—like he was trying to memorize it all.

He'd never seen him like this before.

Relaxed. Open. Laughing quietly at something a child vendor shouted at them. It caught Phainon off guard—he almost didn't recognize him without the usual tension hanging between his shoulders.

It was a strange sort of softness, one that made Phainon blink twice before realizing Mydei was calling his name.

"—Phainon?"

He rubbed his eyes quickly. "Sorry. Zoned out. What were you saying?"

"I said, what do you want to do first?"

Phainon made a show of thinking, glancing over the crowd. “Hmm… The Parhelion Procession’s probably starting soon. Or the Crystal Gardens? Though that’s—what—half a kilometer that way?” He gestured vaguely.

Mydei frowned. “You’re suggesting we walk *more*?”

“As if you weren’t the one to recommend that.” Phainon smirked. “Kidding. I’m not cruel. Let’s start small.”

“Such as?”

“The Remembrance Lanterns,” he said, voice livening up a little. “Should be right around the corner.”

Mydei tilted his head, curious, and followed as Phainon led the way down a narrower street. The noise dimmed there; the air felt charged with quiet anticipation.

“It’s a tradition,” Phainon explained. “People write wishes or memories onto light-lanterns, then release them into the river of light. They drift up through the sky like little suns. Kind of a symbolic offering to Kephale—returning the light, I guess.”

Mydei looked interested albeit confused. “But Okhema never has night.”

“Not during the year,” Phainon agreed. “But for the festival, they change the city’s atmosphere cycle. The sky actually darkens for once. Makes the lights look… real.”

Mydei’s eyes flicked up, watching the glow fade slowly toward dusk. “Can we do that?”

Phainon couldn’t help the laugh that slipped out. “Where do you think we’re going?”

They turned the corner—and there it was.

The Lantern Court spilled out before them like a pocket of starlight. Dozens of children sat cross-legged on the smooth ground, carefully painting

glowing ink across translucent orbs. Each one pulsed faintly with their touch, as though responding to every wish whispered over it. Trails of released lanterns drifted upward, curving through the dimming sky toward the spires like constellations being drawn in real time.

Mydei slowed, his expression softening as he watched one float away. The reflection of the drifting lights played across his face—half awe, half quiet wonder. Phainon found himself smiling.

“Wait here,” he said, before Mydei could ask why, and slipped through the crowd toward the vendor’s stall.

The vendor was an older woman with a headscarf that shimmered faintly under the lanterns’ glow. “For you and your partner?” she asked with a knowing look.

Phainon blinked. “Partner? Oh—no, no, not like that, he’s just—”

“Mm-hm,” she said, handing him two lanterns anyway. “Then take the pink one. It’s the not like that friendship color.”

He sighed, but accepted both. “I feel very seen right now.”

“Good,” she said brightly. “Means it’ll work.”

He returned to where Mydei stood, still watching the children. “Here,” he said, offering him one of the lanterns.

Mydei took it carefully, the light pooling between his fingers. “It’s warm.”

“That means it’s listening,” Phainon said gravely.

Mydei blinked. “Listening?”

“Yeah,” Phainon said, completely straight-faced. “To see if your wish is stupid.”

Mydei didn’t fall into the bait.

“Then I’d better think carefully.”

Phainon huffed and then looked away before he gave himself away too.

Mydei turned his lantern in his hands, brow furrowed slightly—as if he were trying to decide which pieces of himself were safe to entrust to flame. Then, with a quiet sigh, he crouched down and began to write.

Phainon, predictably, leaned in like a nosy cat.

“Whatcha writing?”

Without missing a beat, Mydei tilted the lantern away. “Private.”

Phainon blinked, feigning deep offense. “Private? You’ve been living in my house for three weeks. You’ve stolen my tea, rearranged my archives, borrowed my coat, and now suddenly we have boundaries?”

“That’s different.”

“Different how?”

“Those were necessary.” He said it with such unbothered certainty that Phainon could only stare.

“Necessary,” he repeated flatly. “You’re calling drinking my imported hibiscus blend *necessary*?”

A pause. “It was there.”

“Unbelievable,” Phainon muttered, craning his neck again only for Mydei to block him with a graceful twist of his wrist. “What are you writing that’s so classified? State secrets? Coordinates to your tragic backstory?”

Mydei mused for a moment before answering. “You’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

“Oh, I’d frame it,” Phainon said solemnly. “Next to the last time you smiled on purpose.”

Mydei shook his head and went back to writing, hair falling forward like a curtain. The lantern light slid over his cheekbones, and Phainon, for reasons he didn’t care to name, went very still.

When Mydei finally straightened, the glow around his lantern had softened to a deep amber. “Done,” he said, setting it aside.

“Good,” Phainon said, pushing himself up. “Now let’s—”

“You haven’t written yours.”

He blinked. “Mine?”

“You can’t release an empty one,” Mydei said, folding his arms.

“I usually do.”

“They don’t let you.”

“They?”

“The gods,” Phainon said with a vague gesture skyward. “Or the Bureau of Lantern Compliance. I don’t know, no one’s ever complained.”

“Write something,” Mydei said. “It’s a wish festival. Participate.”

Phainon sighed, glancing down at the blank lantern. “Fine, fine. A small one, then.”

He thought for a moment, contemplating. “If I had to pick… my wish is to fulfill everyone else’s wishes.”

A silence followed. Then Mydei blinked once, slowly. “…That’s stupid.”

Phainon laughed. “Yeah, I thought so too.”

“HKS,” Mydei murmured, almost under his breath.

Phainon paused, the sound brushing against something half-buried in his chest. “…What?”

“HKS,” Mydei repeated.

He forced a light chuckle. “You really need to stop cursing me in Kremnoan.”

“I’m not.”

“Then what does it mean?”

Mydei’s eyes didn’t leave the lanterns. “Maybe I’ll tell you. When you’re ready.”

That earned a small, disbelieving snort from Phainon. “You sound like Cyrene.”

“I’ll take that as an insult.”

He stuck his tongue out despite himself, and on impulse, caught Mydei’s wrist. “C’mon. I know a better spot.”

They slipped out from the Lantern Court into quieter streets, where laughter and music dissolved into distant echoes. The glow overhead thinned to drifting ribbons of light as they climbed. By the time they reached the upper terraces, Okhema spread below them like a mosaic—streets glittering, sky a dark ocean pricked with lanterns.

“This,” Phainon said, a little breathless, “is my secret place for pretending I have my life together.”

Mydei looked down. “It’s convincing.”

They leaned against the railing, the city breathing softly beneath them.

“It’s beautiful,” Mydei murmured. “I never thought I’d be allowed to be this… carefree.”

“Allowed?” Phainon asked.

“I wasn’t built for leisure.” Mydei’s tone was matter-of-fact. “From what I remember—fragments, really—freedom was something other people got to have. I was meant to observe, not live.”

Phainon made a sound of acknowledgment. Then: “I don’t remember what normal feels like either, if that’s any comfort. I wasn’t born here—my parents were from Aedes Elysiae. Only my mother was Okheman. They passed on early. After that it was just Cyrene and me.” He exhaled through his nose. “We got scooped up by Aglaea and… well, you know the rest.”

“That’s lonely,” Mydei said softly.

“Maybe,” Phainon said. “But it was also the start of a lot of great things.”

The wind picked up, tugging gently at their sleeves. Wordlessly, they lifted their lanterns together. The glow pooled between their fingers, merging—soft gold and white, humming faintly.

“Three,” Phainon said under his breath. “Two. One.”

They released.

The lanterns drifted upward, spinning into the thousands already ascending. The reflection on the glass terraces made it look as if the sky and city traded stars between them.

Phainon turned to say something, but Mydei was already looking at him. The space between them felt smaller, electric in a way that made the whole world fade. Their hands brushed. Neither pulled away.

He realized, distantly, that he was staring at Mydei’s mouth.

“Mydei—” he began, but never finished.

“Phainon.”

The voice was sharp, cutting through the air like a wire snapping.

Both of them froze.

Phainon spun around, pulse hammering. A figure stood at the edge of the terrace—silhouette sharp, posture unmistakable even in the half-light.

Wait a damn minute.

Was that—

"…Hysilens?" His voice pitched up half an octave. "You—how are you even—"

She stepped forward, light glinting off her insignia. Her face was grim, eyes hard in a way that immediately pulled him back to a battlefield.

"I was recalled from the Aelion front," she said evenly. "Under Cerydra's direct order."

Phainon's stomach dropped. "Why? What happened?"

Hysilens held his gaze. "Anaxagoras has disappeared."

The words hit like a bell toll—clean, final, and impossibly loud in the quiet.

The lanterns kept rising.

No, no, no…" Phainon muttered under his breath, rifling through Anaxagoras's things with growing urgency. Drawers slammed open and shut, papers scattered, datachips rolled across the floor. The overhead light flickered with every frustrated movement—like it, too, was nervous.

The room was neat. *Too* neat. Anaxagoras's quarters were exactly as he'd left them—bed made, surfaces cleared, every item placed with his usual precision. To anyone else, it would look harmless. But to Phainon, the order was its own alarm bell.

"He wouldn't just—" His words cut off as he yanked open another drawer and dumped its contents onto the floor. A half-eaten ration bar tumbled out

alongside shards of crystal and several datapads. “He wouldn’t just go.”

Mydei, crouched quietly near the desk, didn’t say anything. He was leafing through a pile of papers.

Aglaea had been furious when the news came in—*truly* furious, which was rare. The kind of anger that didn’t raise its voice, only promised consequences. Whole data sectors had been scrubbed clean, sensitive archives half-wiped, and someone had run encrypted downloads through multiple servers just before Anaxagoras vanished. Whatever he’d taken, it wasn’t small. And now, Okhema’s enforcement network was running on overdrive trying to find him.

This wasn’t a disappearance.

It was a departure.

Phainon stopped long enough to press his hands over his face, dragging them down with a groan. “He wouldn’t. He *knows* what’s at stake. He’d never—”

A soft clink interrupted him.

He turned, half expecting bad news. Mydei was standing by the far desk, holding something in both hands—a faint blue light pulsing between his fingers.

“…What’s that?”

Phainon rubbed at his eyes, exhaustion dragging down his tone. “If it’s another log file, toss it—wait.” He froze, the breath catching in his chest. “Is that—”

He crossed the room in three quick steps. “That’s the *Tribios’s* core.”

Mydei blinked. “The what?”

“The ship we were on before,” Phainon explained, taking it gingerly from him. The device was cracked down one side, its energy weak but persistent.

“There were three AIs installed on this model—Trianne, Tribbie, and Trinnon, if you remember.” He tapped the faintly glowing panel. “Only Trianne’s still active? No way. That doesn’t make sense.”

“Why not?”

“She’s the navigation and records unit,” Phainon said distractedly, turning the core in his hands. “Looks like she somehow booted back online after partial corruption. That shouldn’t even *happen* without manual access to—”

He stopped mid-sentence when he realized Mydei had moved closer, gaze fixed on the pulsing light.

“Recorder,” Mydei murmured. “So she could record transmissions?”

Phainon gave him a sideways look. “Technically, yes. But not much. At this level, she’d barely manage ambient resonance—music, soundwaves, background hums. Anything verbal would be static.” He blinked at him. “Why are we talking about this?”

“I was curious.”

“Well, be curious *later*,” Phainon said, sharper than he meant to. Then, “We’ve got bigger problems.”

He set the core aside and started pacing again, his hands moving through the air as if trying to grab hold of some logic that wasn’t there.

Behind him Mydei’s voice came, trying to sound reasonable, as well as comforting. “He’ll come back soon.”

Phainon froze.

Mydei didn’t look up. “A week at most, really.”

Phainon turned slowly. “…What?”

“Two days,” Mydei repeated. “Maybe less.”

Phainon stared, the disbelief settling in like a chill. “…How do you *know* that?”

Mydei’s eyes lifted, mild as ever. “A guess.”

Phainon’s pulse quickened. “Don’t do that.” He stepped closer, the words tight. “You don’t guess things like that. Mydeimos, no—how do you know?”

For a heartbeat, neither of them moved.

Then Mydei looked at him fully, his tone aloof. “Does it matter?”

It shouldn’t have been such an impactful lines but it was.

Phainon’s grip faltered, fingers loosening from the fabric of Mydei’s sleeve. His mind spun with suspicion, questions clawing at the edge of his tongue —but before he could voice a single one, Mydei spoke again.

“But anyway,” he said, with a sudden cadence that didn’t belong in the room, “back to more important matters.”

Phainon blinked. “*What* could possibly—”

“I have a gift for you,” Mydei interrupted.

A faint beep cut through the silence.

Phainon’s head snapped toward the sound before his body followed. He shoved aside a pile of scattered notes, crouched low by the desk, and dug until his fingers brushed cold metal.

“There you are,” he muttered, dragging the small device into the light. It was rectangular—half datastream relay, half bad omen. Lines of red pulsed unevenly along its surface, flickering like a heartbeat trying to remember its rhythm.

“Mydei,” he called, voice tightening. “Come here. What the hell is this?”

The other man leaned over his shoulder. “Looks like a partial transmission unit.”

“It’s active.”

“Clearly.”

Phainon shot him a sideways glare before turning back. The screen blinked again—now streaming a river of distorted glyphs and half-rendered code. “No, I mean *it’s transmitting right now*.” He tapped the corner, coaxing it into a diagnostic. “These are lattice schematics. Someone’s been sending gridwork data from *here*.”

“From Anaxa’s quarters?”

“Where else?” Phainon muttered. “And it’s still going. Fantastic.”

He plugged a cable into the side port, jaw tight. The feed brightened, then shrieked into static so loud it made him wince.

“Oh, come on!”

Before he could hurl it across the room, the light pulsed again—once, twice—and the whole space seemed to stutter. For a fraction of a second, the air warped. Then—nothing.

The relay went dark.

“…Did it finish?” Mydei asked.

Phainon stared at the dead screen, pulse hammering. “I—don’t know.” He ran a quick diagnostic anyway, but the system refused to respond. “I don’t know if it *stopped* or if it *transferred*. Either way, that’s—”

He caught himself before the curse left his mouth, forcing a slow exhale. Then he set the device down with almost exaggerated care, as if breathing on it might trigger another meltdown.

“You’re pale,” Mydei observed. “You should sit.”

“I should figure out where the hell that went.”

Mydei hummed. He dug into one of his pockets—and for a second Phainon thought he’d found a lead. Until Mydei turned back holding something small and glinting.

It took Phainon a moment to register what it was.

“…Are those—earrings?”

“They’re the gift.”

“Now? You’re *seriously*—” He stopped, squinting at them. They weren’t normal metal. The red gleam in the surface caught the light like liquid, layered, almost alive. “…Where did you even get these?”

Mydei smiled faintly. “Made them.”

“You *made*—? When?”

“Recently.”

“Recently,” Phainon repeated flatly. “Of course. In the middle of this absolute meltdown.”

“Exactly,” Mydei said, stepping closer with infuriating calm. “Hold still.”

“Mydei, I swear—”

But it was too late. Mydei fastened one onto his ear with practiced ease. Phainon squirmed on reflex but didn’t stop him—maybe out of exhaustion, maybe because there was something weirdly hypnotizing in Mydei’s tone.

The clasp clicked.

Warmth bloomed through him suddenly. His shoulders loosened before his mind caught up with what had happened.

“What the—”

Mydei was already attaching the second one. “For when I’m not near.”

Phainon blinked, the words taking a second too long to process. His heartbeat still felt wrong—too fast, too aware.

“…You’re unbelievable.” He managed a half-laugh, half-groan. “You realize this is the *worst possible time* for sentimental gestures, right?”

“Perhaps. But it felt appropriate.”

“Appropriate—? Mydei, there’s an active transmission feeding into the grid, Anaxa’s missing, and I’m fairly sure command’s on the verge of burning this entire sector to the ground, so—”

He stopped, catching the smile in Mydei’s expression. It was disarming in a way that worked far too well.

Phainon exhaled, rubbing the bridge of his nose. “You’re impossible.”

“I’ve heard that before.”

He looked up, suspicion threading through his fatigue. “What are you trying to pull here, exactly?”

“Nothing,” Mydei said, tone light. “I’ll see you outside once you’ve… finished with this.” His gaze swept the chaos of overturned drawers and glowing screens. “Try not to dismantle the entire apartment before then.”

Before Phainon could answer, he was already walking out.

The door slid shut behind him with a muted hiss.

Phainon stood there for a beat, staring at the mess and the faint reflection of himself in the dark screen. Then he sighed. “Unbelievable.”

He turned back to the desk, running another scan purely out of stubbornness.

Something shifted.

A slow chill crept down his spine.

He turned sharply toward where he’d left the relay.

“…Where’d the transmitter go?”

Phainon was working again.

The relay incident, according to command, was “contained.” Which, in bureaucratic language, meant they’d stopped asking questions. The official summary called it a minor grid fluctuation—resolved, isolated, no external cause. Phainon would’ve loved to believe that, if the interference hadn’t kept crawling through Anaxa’s network like a fever that refused to break.

It wasn’t constant. Just enough to make him doubt sleep when he tried to take it. Flickers in his periphery. Lines of code jumping half a frame. The faintest static hum in the walls whenever he passed by.

The city itself had gone back to normal—air shuttles overhead, datastreams pulsing, people moving like they hadn’t almost lost half the grid two weeks ago.

But the red signatures still haunted every diagnostic. And the missing relay never reappeared.

He’d been at it since dawn, running cross-checks and recalibrations until the console heat made his eyes sting. The only thing that made him feel remotely steady anymore were the earrings—quiet warmth against his skin, a small pulse like something living.

He didn’t notice the door open until the scent hit him.

Mydei stepped in, balancing a tray with one hand, steam curling up in soft ribbons. Something savory, clean, with a hint of ginger.

“You’re supposed to be off shift,” Phainon said, eyes still on the screen.

“I am,” Mydei said. “You’re not.”

“That’s different.”

“Not really.” Mydei set the tray down beside the console. “Eat before you start seeing double.”

“I’m fine,” Phainon murmured automatically.

“You’ve said that four times this week,” Mydei said, peeling the cover off one of the bowls. “Three of which were followed by you shorting out a terminal.”

“That was one time,” Phainon corrected.

“It was three,” Mydei said. “I counted.”

Phainon’s mouth twitched despite himself. “You’re insufferable.”

“Efficient,” Mydei said, sliding the bowl toward him. “And occasionally right.”

Phainon sighed, finally turning away from the monitor. The food smelled stupidly good. “You really don’t have to keep bringing me things.”

“I know.” So he was just being sweet, was he trying to kill Phainon? “But you forget to eat when you work. I’ve seen you.”

“You make me sound hopeless.”

“I’d say endearingly fixated.”

Phainon chuckled softly. He rested his elbow on the desk, chin on his palm. “Endearingly. You practice these?”

“Sometimes,” Mydei said, taking the seat across from him. “Depends who they’re for.”

Phainon glanced up at that. “You always like making people squirm, don’t you?”

“Only when it’s you.”

His breath hitched. The only sound came from the low beeps of the data hub and the soft clatter of chopsticks when Phainon finally picked them up.

He ate quietly for a minute, eyes drifting toward the terminal every so often. Mydei noticed. Of course he did.

“You’re overworking again,” he reminded him again.

Phainon set the bowl down, sighing. “There’s still a missing relay out there. Until I know where it went, I can’t stop.”

Mydei tilted his head. “Can’t, or won’t?”

Phainon smirked faintly. “You always have to phrase it like that?”

“It helps you think.”

“Annoying technique.”

“Effective,” Mydei retorted, watching him. Then, quieter: “You don’t need to solve everything yourself, Phainon. Not in one night.”

Phainon glanced down at the faint red glow of the earrings reflected in the glass console surface. “It’s not about solving it,” he said. “It’s about knowing. I just… don’t like when something hides in plain sight.”

“Then look in front of you, not behind,” Mydei murmured.

Phainon looked at him. “That a proverb?”

“A suggestion.”

He threw a pillow he had nearby. “You’re terrible at giving advice.”

“Maybe,” Mydei said, catching it with ease, “but you listen anyway.”

Phainon leaned back, gaze softening without his permission. There was something absurdly grounding about the way Mydei existed. He didn’t know how to word it. Being around him was a relief.

He didn’t say any of that, of course.

Instead, he muttered, “You really are the worst influence.”

“I prefer ‘reliable anchor.’”

“That sounds even worse.”

Mydei glared at him.

For a long moment, the silence was easy—almost domestic. It was just them, basking in each other’s presence.

Phainon caught his eyes glowing gold without realizing it. “Give me one second,” he said. “Another diagnostic should be done by now.”

Mydei nodded. “Go on.”

Phainon turned back to the screen. He expected nothing. Just another corrupted readout, another line of indecipherable code. He scrolled through the data once, twice—then stopped.

Something was different.

The feed pulsed faintly—red, rhythmic. Familiar.

Behind him, Mydei’s voice came distantly. “Is something wrong?”

Phainon didn’t answer. He only stared, pulse steadying in time with the glow as the color bled across the interface like it was alive.

Phainon frowned, leaning closer to the display. What should’ve been a simple cascade of diagnostics was mutating in real time, script lines braiding into pulsing, arterial patterns. The colors were wrong—too bright, too deliberate.

“No—Mydei, come here and look at this.”

Mydei drifted over from his post, pausing beside him. “Hm?”

Phainon didn’t answer right away. He expanded the data window and dragged the overlay into view. “See this? The cross-references. You’ve got signal traces stamped *Okhema*, but the vectors—look. They’re Kremnos-marked. Military grade.”

Mydei’s eyes flicked over the display, narrowing. “That’s not possible.”

“Yeah, that’s what I said the first time I read it,” Phainon muttered, half to himself. “Unless someone decided to invite an entire Kremnos relay inside Okhema’s network core for tea.” He tried for a laugh, but it came out strained. “These two haven’t shared bandwidth in—what, seven years?”

“Eight,” Mydei corrected softly.

“Right. Eight.” Phainon leaned back, rubbing the bridge of his nose. “And now they’re both leaving fingerprints on the same lattice schematic—stolen lattice schematic, mind you—looping through the civic network like it owns the place.” He reached for his telaslate, opening a comm feed. “I’m calling Aglaea. This is—”

A sharp tone sliced through the air. His device buzzed once, twice, then erupted with rapid alerts. Text scrolled faster than he could read:

RESONANT DISTURBANCES DETECTED—FIELD DISRUPTION SPREADING THROUGH LOWER DISTRICTS. CIVILIAN REPORTS: EMOTIONAL CONVERGENCE, AUDITORY STATIC, UNVERIFIED DREAM SHARING.

Phainon stared at the screen. “What the hell does *emotional convergence* even—”

The rest of his sentence broke off as the air around him shifted.

It started faintly, like the room itself had inhaled. The hum of the consoles deepened, and for a moment the lights seemed to pulse in rhythm with

something he couldn’t quite hear. Then came the weight—slow, creeping, pressing against his chest like invisible hands.

His heartbeat stuttered.

Then the noise hit.

It wasn’t sound. It was *everything else*. A flood of thoughts, panic, grief, laughter, pain—none of it his, all of it *through* him. Fear from somewhere east, rage from somewhere close, despair rising like waves until it drowned his own pulse. His breath hitched; his knees almost buckled.

This wasn’t from him.

This was from *everyone* in the damn city.

“It hurts,” he rasped. *“It—it hurts, it hurts, it hurts inside, I can’t—”*

Mydei was on him in an instant, one steady arm around his back, obviously caught of guard by the sudden shift. “Phainon!? What are—*never mind* that. Focus. Tell me what’s going on. What’re you feeling?”

“What I’m—?!” Phainon’s laugh came out strangled. “Everyone! I can feel *everyone*—” He clutched at his temples, every nerve alive and screaming. “Make it stop—”

“Phainon.”

The single word cut through the pain.

He drew Phainon in, palm at the back of his neck, and lowered his forehead until it touched his own.

The shift was immediate—like diving into cold water. A low pulse echoed through the contact, coolness spreading outward until the daze began to thin. Phainon’s body went slack in his arms, trembling, eyes half-open as the pain dulled from unbearable to distant.

He exhaled hard, breath shuddering. “You—you did that?”

“Stabilizing feedback,” Mydei said, shifting the topic. “Just breathe.”

Phainon forced himself upright again, jaw tight. “Yeah. Breathing. Great. Not helping the part where the whole city just decided to share brainspace.” He grabbed the telaslate again, wiping sweat from his forehead with the back of his hand. “No, this isn’t normal. We’re calling Aglaea.”

Mydei only nodded, watching him carefully in concern.

Phainon keyed the line. The screen blinked once, twice—then the feed opened. Or tried to. The connection stuttered, visual static blooming across it like frost.

“Come on,” he muttered. “Come on—”

A voice came through at last, broken but recognizable.

[Phainon?]

Relief hit him all at once. “Aglaea—finally. Listen, something’s wrong. I’m getting dual signatures from both Okhema and Kremnos, and the lattice is splicing itself through the civic relay. The resonance field’s collapsing, and people are reporting spikes, dreams, gods, I don’t even know. Where are you right now? We need to—”

**“P̸̛̛̛

“Aglaea?”

No response.

Phainon’s throat tightened. “Please answer—Aglaea, what’s wrong? Where are you?”

The comm stuttered once, then burst open with static, fractured light rippling across the console. Through the distortion came her voice—glitched, strained, but unmistakably hers.

[Phainon…] a hiss of feedback. **[You have to listen. We don’t have time.]**

He exhaled shakily, half in relief. “Gods, finally. What’s happening? You’re barely coming through—”

[Okhema’s central lattice is destabilizing. Containment breach through conduit three and seven. The core’s fracturing—] static sheared through the words **[—Kremnos is en route. I confirmed the signal myself.]**

The breath left his chest. “Confirmed? You mean they’re actually here?”

[Approaching vector thirteen.] Her tone was all business now, battle calm layered over exhaustion. **[Listen to me. If this fails—if I don’t come back—you’ll need to assume command.]**

He froze. “…What? Aglaea, don’t start talking like that—*what the hell is happening?* You *can’t* do *this*, it’s too sudden, c’mon just yesterday we were having dinn—”

[There’s no other way. The lattice is feeding back into itself. The only path left is integration. If I merge with the core, I can halt the cascade before it reaches the outer network.]

His hand clenched against the console.

Was she *serious*?

“That’s suicide.”

[It’s time. Someone has to hold the structure together from inside. I can do it—buy everyone else enough time to evacuate.]

“Aglaea, no. There’s still time come on, we can reroute from here—”

[There isn’t.] Her voice softened, the distortion pulsing around it like a heartbeat. **[You’ll need to protect the city. And Phainon—find Castorice. She’s working with Cipher as well as Hysilens. The core they’re using is unstable. If Kremnos reaches it first, the collapse won’t stop at Okhema. It’ll chain-react across the entire network.]**

The line dissolved into noise. He could barely catch fragments through it—containment, resonance, don’t let it spread.

Phainon was already moving, grabbing his coat, breath unsteady but his mind burning through panic. “Alright. Okay. I’ll get the Council online, initiate evacuation. Mydei’s with me now—we can—”

The transmission stuttered, went silent.

Then, abruptly—

[…Mydei?]

He blinked. “Yeah. Why?”

The static began to climb, frequency scraping higher, sharper.

[He’s—] a burst of feedback so violent it made his teeth ache. **[Heir… of… Nika—]**

“Aglaea?”

[—RUN.]

The line split open into a scream of static, blinding red streaking across every display.

Then nothing.

Silence swallowed the room. Phainon stood frozen, the glow of the monitors washing over him like the last light before a blackout.

His pulse wouldn’t slow.

Behind him, Mydei’s voice broke through.

“Well,” he said conversationally, as if the world hadn’t just dropped out from under them, “we should move fast. If Kremnos really is inbound, Castorice will still be near the Scepter. Docking bay shouldn’t be far—assuming the lower decks haven’t sealed yet.”

Phainon didn’t answer. His attention stayed fixed on the flickering light where Aglaea’s signal had died, that last pulse of red still echoing behind his eyes. Then, slowly, he turned.

“You said lower decks,” he said.

Mydei glanced over his shoulder. “Yeah?”

“The lower decks were decommissioned two cycles ago,” Phainon said carefully. “Only the central engineers ever had the blueprints. Not even the Council has clearance.”

A quiet settled between them.

Phainon’s voice came softer, careful. “How do you know that?”

For a heartbeat, Mydei didn’t react. His expression stayed the same—steady, unbothered—but something subtle in him *stilled*. The small, unconscious movements—the blink, the faint fidget of his hand—just… stopped.

Then he sighed.

“I suppose I shouldn’t.”

Phainon’s stomach dropped. “What?”

“You heard me,” Mydei said easily, like this was a casual chitchat and not a shattering realization. “You seriously ask too many questions, you know.”

His voice stayed level, but something in his stance changed. The ease in his tone wasn’t poise anymore—it was the disinterest of someone who’d stopped pretending to care.

“You really don’t know when to shut up, do you?”

He said it with a laugh that didn’t reach his eyes.

Phainon’s body moved before thought did—muscle memory, survival instinct, both screaming *run*. He tore himself free and spun, bringing the closest thing he had up in a clean, defensive arc—

—but the space between them vanished.

He didn’t even see the transition. One second, Mydei was standing a few feet away. The next, he was there—close enough that Phainon could feel the heat radiating off him. His hand caught Phainon’s wrist mid-swing and twisted with just enough force to make the weapon clatter to the floor.

Pain cracked up Phainon’s arm, but he pivoted anyway, driving a knee, a strike—anything. It didn’t land. Mydei’s other hand caught his shoulder, redirected his weight, and slammed him back against the console hard enough to rattle the panels.

Phainon gasped, breath knocked out of him—then felt it.

Not pain—*pull*.

It started deep under his ribs and crawled outward, a cold ache running through every nerve. His fingers tingled, then went slack. The world flickered at the edges.

“Mydei—what—”

He didn’t get the rest out. Mydei caught his other wrist, pinning it easily, and the contact made the sensation worse. Like something in his chest was

unraveling thread by thread.

The faint pulsing of the earrings was made worse against his skin—alive, wrong, synchronized with the energy siphoning through him.

Mydei's gaze flicked to them, then back to Phainon's face. His voice was soft, almost pitying.

"You should've taken them off when you had the chance."

Phainon tried to twist away. Mydei didn't even have to tighten his grip. The pressure itself was enough—a reminder of how completely outmatched he was.

"What did you do?" Phainon rasped.

"I didn't do anything," Mydei said, almost thoughtful. "You just never asked what they were connected to."

Then that faint, crooked smile returned. "But it's cute you thought I'd give you something harmless."

It took a second to process what he meant.

The earrings.

Phainon's pulse jumped. He tried to lunge again, but his legs didn't answer. The drain had sunk deeper, numbing everything it touched.

Mydei leaned in, voice dropping to a whisper. "You always were so good at seeing through people. Shame you never tried it with me."

"Mydei," Phainon rasped, his breath catching against the pressure in his chest. "What—what the hell is happening to you?"

Mydei's gaze lifted, almost lazily, as if Phainon's question amused him.

"Who said anything's happening to me?"

Phainon swallowed hard. “Then who *the hell* are you?”

“Does it really matter?”

That answer hit him harder than it should’ve. His thoughts scattered, tripping over each other—Aglaea’s final broadcast flashing behind his eyes, fragmented and distorted. *Heir of Nikador.*

That name rang through the haze, ancient, heavy with meaning. Nikador—the Titan patron of Kremnos. The old royal line had sworn their blood to it before the purge. But Kremnos’s monarchy had been erased centuries ago—burned from history, its survivors executed or exiled.

There wasn’t supposed to be a line left.

Unless…

He blinked hard. The Rift.

The way Mydei had been found—suspended inside that crystal, alive when no one should’ve been. Barely a pulse, barely a data signature, just a body the encasing refused to let go. He’d joked once he’d gotten over it with Mydei—half out of disbelief—that maybe some old god had claimed him.

Now, that didn’t feel like a joke.

Phainon looked up. Mydei hadn’t moved. He stood watching him with quiet fascination, as though he’d been waiting for Phainon to finally catch up.

“You’re—”

“Careful,” Mydei interrupted. “Say it only if you’re sure.”

Phainon didn’t finish his sentence.

He pivoted the topic.

“Mydei,” he said again, softer now. “You lied to me.”

A blink. “You lied first.”

Well he’s not wrong.

Phainon’s mouth twisted. “So what was this then? You play at loyalty, get what you need, and throw the rest to rot?”

“Don’t make it sound so cheap,” Mydei clicked his tongue. “I liked you. Still do, in a way.”

That *in a way* burned worse than venom.

He tried to pull his wrist free; Mydei didn’t let him. The grip stayed—firm, almost loose, except for the pulse of strength beneath his skin.

“You’ve been pulling the strings this whole time,” Phainon managed. “Aglaea—”

“Handled herself,” Mydei interrupted. “I simply didn’t interfere.”

It took a second for the meaning to register, and when it did, something inside him splintered.

“You killed her.”

“I said I didn’t interfere,” Mydei corrected. “There’s a difference.”

He leaned closer.

“She was going to stand in the way. You won’t.”

“You’re fucking insane.”

“Maybe, but you can’t seriously say you hadn’t expect anything to happen.”

The draining intensified. Phainon’s knees threatened to buckle. His vision ghosted at the edges, but Mydei’s voice kept threading through it all.

“Okhema’s command will fracture before dawn. Their fleets, their data lines—all gone. No one left to order you around. No one to tell you who to save.”

Phainon forced out a broken laugh. “You’ll kill everyone I’ve ever known, and call that mercy?”

“Mercy for you,” Mydei corrected. “You can stop choosing, right? You *had* complained about this before, if I recall correctly. I’ll take care of the rest, and if it happens to benefit me as well, then...”

He lifted a hand, tracing the edge of Phainon’s jaw with his thumb.

“You’ve got that habit,” Mydei said suddenly. “Picking people apart, seeing what makes them tick. I wonder, did you figure out mine?”

Phainon’s glare deepened. “You think I’m afraid of you?”

“No.” He tilted his head, meeting Phainon’s eyes directly. “You’re just scared of being right. Honestly—how many red flags did you need before getting to this point?”

Phainon tried to move, to strike, to *do* something—but his muscles wouldn’t listen.

“You’re—Castorice and—” he started, and his voice cracked.

“Don’t say her name,” Mydei cut in suddenly as his grip shifted—a small warning that bit deep into bone.

Phainon stared at him, dazed and furious. “What, jealous now?”

“You have no idea.”

He leaned in.

“You keep bringing up everyone else when I’m right here. Look at me.”

Phainon's gaze lifted before he could stop himself. Mydei's thumb rested against his throat, tracing the pulse that wouldn't calm.

"I only want your attention," Mydei murmured. "The rest of it can burn."

The words slid under his skin like a blade wrapped in silk. The pressure at his throat tightened, not tightly—just enough to remind him who held him there.

"You don't get to decide that," he managed, though the strain in his voice betrayed him.

Mydei's expression loosened, but it wasn't kindness. "You think you still have a say?" His tone was almost admiring. "You're adorable."

Phainon jerked against the hold. His fingers bit deep, cutting a harsh red against his wrists.

"Mydei—let me go."

The earrings responded before Mydei did, splitting his vision into shards of light.

He violently lurched away—or attempted to at least.

Mydei caught him easily, one arm looping around him. "Careful," he said. "You'll hurt yourself for nothing."

"You—think this is—*winning*?"

"Of course not." Mydei's hand lingered at his side, fingers splayed. "Winning's such a pedestrian term. This—" he tapped the pulse at Phainon's throat, "—is a cooperation of sorts."

Phainon tried again to wrench free, a rough noise catching in his throat. His muscles rebelled, trembling under invisible weight. Every movement felt dragged through syrup—thick, impossible.

"Stop fighting it. You're embarrassing us both."

“Go to hell,” Phainon bit out.

“Already been,” Mydei shrugged. “Didn’t like the company.”

Phainon felt his vision darkening as he kicked his legs weakly.

“Even now,” he sighed, “you refuse to understand that you’re safe with me.”

Phainon’s breath hitched. “You… can’t…”

“I can,” Mydei interrupted, tone honey-sweet. “And I will.”

His thumb brushed along Phainon’s jaw, tracing the tremor beneath his skin. “You’ve done enough damage to Okhema bringing me here already. Let someone else decide how this ends, alright?”

Phainon tried to speak, but the sound wouldn’t come.

Mydei’s voice followed the collapse like a lullaby. “Sleep, Phainon.”

He fought it—once, twice—but the current beneath his skin had already chosen its path. His knees gave out. Mydei guided him down with infuriating care, the motion practiced.

“Always fighting,” Mydei tutted. “Even when you’ve already lost.”

Phainon’s lips moved; nothing followed.

The last thing he heard was the voice that undid him—low, coaxing, certain.

“See you tomorrow.”

The words sank into him like a hand closing over a wound.

Darkness gathered at the edges of his sight and folded in, slow as a door sealing shut.

Then—static.

A ragged crackle tore through the quiet, bright and cruel.

“Hephaestion, secure the perimeters. Leave the Adonian researcher to me. I’ll handle her personally.”

The comm cut out with a final pop of distortion, leaving the air hollow.

Mydei looked down at the body in his arms. Phainon’s breath still hitched faintly against his wrist; the light from the earrings pulsed once, twice, as though refusing to die.

Something in Mydei’s face turned thoughtful.

He brushed a thumb over Phainon’s temple, smearing a trace of light that wasn’t his to touch. “Always the difficult ones,” he sighed. “You make me work for it.”

He straightened, still holding him, eyes catching the faint red of the console lights. For a heartbeat, his voice eased again—gentle in the way a knife is when it slips between ribs.

“Goodnight, Deliverer.”

The station dimmed around them, machinery powering down one echo at a time until the room was nothing but breath and pulse.

His own heartbeat steadied, syncing unconsciously with the one pressed against him.

A slow smile ghosted across his mouth.

The kind that promised endings—and beginnings no one asked for.

Truly, the start of a love story worth burning worlds for.

End Notes

Yeah, the ending's rushed, by the time I hit 70k, I was physically fighting the document and decided to cut out a lot and then just got sick of writing this because it didn't fit my vision. Originally it was supposed to go way darker and more cosmic horror-y, with full collapse scenes and confirmed deaths for basically everyone.

Since I had to cut all that for length, here's what was meant to happen, some of it is the same but I didn't really go into detail:
• Aglaea dies merging with the core to delay the lattice collapse.
• Castorice stays behind protecting the Tribios; her logs are all that's left of her because yeah she dies.
• Hyacine gets caught in the feedback loop during the meltdown. (Here she's at the Grove so unfortunately didn't get to add that)
• Tribios leak the coordinates and get wiped from the system, just faint lullabies left in the debris. (Mostly implied here Mydei did sm with their core but it was really vague. She was meant to play a bigger role in my og universe with a grand master plan but look at how that turned out)
• Anaxa defects to Kremnos before everything goes to hell (leaving that up to interpretation as to what happened here…)
• Cyrene dies in a final blast—her last hologram triggers the overload that cracks the Lattice (not added obviously)

And then for the Kremnos side
• Hephaestion originally dies shielding Mydei during the fall.
• Perdikkas burns out trying to restart his heart.
• Leonnius gets atomized mid-flight; his signal becomes static in the Rift sky.
• Ptolemy dies clutching his research (already knew abt the fragments hence why he went to explore it)
• Peucesta plays one last harmonic to stabilize the field and dies when it breaks.

Basically everyone was supposed to die violently, beautifully, and with too much symbolism, and then Mydei was supposed to go full evil-god

mode. But deadlines (and sanity) won.

Anyway, thank you for reading <3 next one-shot will be better, I promise.

I genuinely disappointed myself with this since again I had this all planned out in some master plan/grand scheme, but I still hoped you guys liked it 😭

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!